TRIPLE QUANTUM SCHUBERT CALCULUS

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ABSTRACT. We study the structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ that arise when a product of two quantum double Schubert polynomials in *different* sets of equivariant parameters, $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z)$, is expanded in the basis $\{\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)\}$. We call them triple quantum Schubert structure constants; they specialize to the equivariant quantum Littlewood–Richardson coefficients when $z = y$ and to the ordinary triple Schubert structure constants when $q = 0$. Adapting an argument of Xiao and Yue, we show that they are polynomials in the differences $y_i - z_j$ with nonnegative integer coefficients. We prove a Pieri formula for multiplication by a quantum factorial elementary polynomial, indexed by a quantum analogue of Sottile's relation, in which each coefficient is a monomial in q times a product of differences $y_a - z_1$; the proof is a self-contained analysis of chains in the quantum Bruhat graph. We also prove a doubled Pieri formula for the quantization of a product of two elementary polynomials in the same variables, which selects the compatible pairs of chains and is the paired step of the multiplication algorithm. We extend the Peterson–Woodward comparison formula and the quantum-to-classical reduction of Huang and Li to the triple constants, thereby reducing the computation of the parabolic triple quantum structure constants to the complete flag case. Finally we describe the algorithms implemented in the package `schubmult` for computing these constants, and give an interpretation of the coefficients in terms of the Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov difference operators.

Keywords: quantum double Schubert polynomial, structure constant, Littlewood-Richardson rule, Pieri formula, quantum Bruhat graph, Peterson–Woodward comparison formula

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1. INTRODUCTION

Let $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$, $w \in S_\infty$, denote the double Schubert polynomials of Lascoux and Schützenberger, which represent the torus-equivariant Schubert classes of the complete flag variety, and let $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$ denote the quantum double Schubert polynomials of Kirillov and Maeno [10], which represent the Schubert classes in torus-equivariant quantum cohomology [11]. The structure constants of the equivariant quantum cohomology ring are the coefficients in

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;y) = \sum_{w,d} q^d\, c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;y)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y),$$

and Mihalcea [13] proved that they are polynomials in the negative simple roots $y_{i+1} - y_i$ with nonnegative integer coefficients.

In this paper we study the coefficients obtained when the two factors carry *different* equivariant parameters:

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z) = \sum_{w,d} q^d\, c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

We call the $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ the *triple quantum Schubert structure constants*. At $z = y$ they recover the equivariant quantum structure constants, and at $q = 0$ they recover the triple Schubert structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w}(y;z)$ of [18], which were recently shown by Gao and Xiong [6] to be polynomials in the differences $y_i - z_j$ with nonnegative integer coefficients. The triple constants carry strictly more information than the equivariant ones: the equivariant quantum constant $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;y)$ is a specialization of $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$, while conversely $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ is recovered from the constants $c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y;y)$, v_2 ranging over the right factors of the reduced factorizations $v = v_1 \cdot v_2$, by the quantum Cauchy identity (Lemma 2.1).

Our main results are the following.

(1) *Positivity* (Theorem 2.3). The constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ lie in $\mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[y_i - z_j]$. The proof, which we reproduce from the manuscript of Xiao and Yue [22] with their permission, combines the geometric argument of Mihalcea with the Graham-positivity theorem of Gao and Xiong for B^--stable effective cycles.

(2) *A quantum Pieri formula* (Theorem 3.4). Let $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_1 s_2 \cdots s_k}(x;z)$ be the quantum factorial elementary polynomial. We prove

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,w) \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)} (y_a - z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y),$$

where $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ is a quantum analogue of the relation introduced by Sottile [20] for the classical Pieri rule, $q_k(u,w)$ is a monomial in the q_i recording the length-decreasing steps of a chain from u to w in the quantum Bruhat graph, and $\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)$ is the set of values fixed by the chain in the first k positions. This is an explicit instance of the positivity theorem, and it is the engine of the multiplication algorithm. The proof occupies Section 6; it proceeds by induction on k via the single-variable Monk formula, and rests on an intrinsic description of the chains (every cycle of $u^{-1}w$ has exactly one element exceeding k, and a single length identity) which makes the term-by-term cancellations tractable. In the non-equivariant case the quantum Pieri formula for complete flag manifolds is due to Ciocan-Fontanine [3] and Postnikov [16].

(3) *Parabolic reduction* (Proposition 2.10). The Peterson–Woodward comparison formula, in the form proved by Huang and Li [7] for equivariant quantum cohomology, extends verbatim to the triple constants. Consequently the triple structure constants of the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials of Lam and Shimozono are equal to triple constants of the complete flag variety, and in particular they are also Graham-positive (Corollary 2.12).

(4) *Algorithms and operators* (Sections 4 and 5). We describe the algorithms implemented in the package `schubmult` [19] for computing products of (quantum) double Schubert polynomials, which combine the Pieri formula on one factor with a signed expansion of the other factor into products of factorial elementary polynomials. We prove this expansion, in both its classical and its quantum form (Theorems 4.3 and 4.4); the key step is a formula for the skew divided differences, in the sense of [17, 18], of a product $\prod_{j \le k}(x_j - z_i)$ with respect to the z-variables (Theorem 7.6), in which the terms of the iterated Monk rule that revisit a position cancel by a rotation argument (Lemma 7.5). The quantum algorithm also uses a "doubled" Pieri rule (Theorem 8.4) for the quantization of a product of two elementary polynomials in the same variables, which is obtained from two iterated Pieri steps by omitting the pairs of chains that are not compatible in a precise cycle-theoretic sense. We prove this doubled rule in general (Theorem 8.4): it is equivalent to a termwise identity between pairs of chains (Theorem 8.23) which telescopes along explicit blocks of pairs and is then established by an injection built from a single local lemma, a generalization of the up/down pairing used in the proof of the Pieri formula (Theorem 8.36). We also show that the Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov quantization operators [5] package the triple constants: the coefficient of ∂^u in $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)$ is $\sum_d q^d c^{1,d}_{u,v}(x;z)$. Finally, we extend the quantum-to-classical reduction of Huang and Li to the triple constants.

The paper is organized as follows. Section 2 fixes notation, proves the positivity theorem and treats the parabolic case. Section 3 states the Pieri formula, whose proof is given in Section 6. Section 4 describes the algorithms and the operator interpretation, Section 5 the quantum-to-classical reduction, Section 7 proves the expansion formulas used on the v-side of the algorithms, Section 8 the iterated Pieri formula, and Section 9 the Peterson–Woodward comparison formula.

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2. Definitions and statement of results

2.1. **Quantum double Schubert polynomials and triple quantum Schubert structure constants.** We fix $n \ge 1$ and write

$$x = (x_1, \ldots, x_n), \qquad y = (y_1, \ldots, y_n), \qquad q = (q_1, \ldots, q_{n-1}).$$

For $1 \le a < b \le n$, set

$$q_{ab} := q_a q_{a+1} \cdots q_{b-1},$$

and use the cohomological grading $\deg q_i = 2$ (equivalently $\deg q_{ab} = 2(b-a)$).

Let s_i act on the y-variables by swapping y_i, y_{i+1}, and define the divided difference operators

$$\partial_i^{(y)} f := \frac{f - s_i f}{y_i - y_{i+1}} \qquad (1 \le i \le n-1).$$

For $w \in S_n$, if $w = s_{i_1} \cdots s_{i_r}$ is any reduced word, set

$$\partial_w^{(y)} := \partial_{i_1}^{(y)} \cdots \partial_{i_r}^{(y)}.$$

Following Kirillov–Maeno [10], define the quantum elementary polynomials $e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \ldots, x_k)$ by

$$\Delta_k(t \mid x_1, \ldots, x_k) := \sum_{j=0}^{k} t^{k-j} e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \ldots, x_k),$$

where

$$\Delta_k(t \mid x_1, \ldots, x_k) = \det \begin{pmatrix} x_1 + t & q_1 & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ -1 & x_2 + t & q_2 & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & -1 & x_3 + t & \ddots & 0 \\ \vdots & \ddots & \ddots & \ddots & q_{k-1} \\ 0 & \cdots & 0 & -1 & x_k + t \end{pmatrix}.$$

Let $w_0 \in S_n$ be the longest permutation. The top quantum double Schubert polynomial is

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{w_0}(x; y) := \prod_{i=1}^{n-1} \Delta_i(-y_{n-i} \mid x_1, \ldots, x_i),$$

and for $w \in S_n$ we define

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x; y) := (-1)^{\ell(w_0) - \ell(w)} \partial_{ww_0}^{(y)} \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{w_0}(x; y).$$

Its specialization

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x) := \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x; 0)$$

is the quantum Schubert polynomial. In particular, at $q = 0$ these recover the ordinary double and single Schubert polynomials.

Given their stability property, we may let the number of variables be infinite, indexing the polynomials by S_∞. As a module over $\mathbb{Z}[q][y]$, the quantum double Schubert polynomials form a basis of $\mathbb{Z}[q][x, y]$, and we may write

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x; y)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x; z) = \sum_{w,d} q^d c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y; z)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x; y)$$

where $d = (d_1, \ldots, d_{n-1})$ is a weak composition and $q^d = q_1^{d_1} \cdots q_{n-1}^{d_{n-1}}$. The coefficients $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y; z)$ are the *triple quantum Schubert structure constants*, which are polynomials in y and z with integer coefficients. This product respects the grading where for each i, $\deg y_i = \deg z_i = 1$ and $\deg q_i = 2$. In particular, if $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y; z) \neq 0$, then $\deg c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y; z) = \ell(u) + \ell(v) - \ell(w) + 2\sum_i d_i$. Unlike the usual triple Schubert structure constants, they do not exhibit triangularity in Bruhat order, and indeed we may have $\ell(w) < \ell(u) + \ell(v)$. There is an ordering in which the quantum double Schubert polynomials are triangular, but we will not need this in full generality.

Throughout, a factorization $w = v_1 \cdot v_2$ written with a dot is understood to be *reduced*, i.e. $\ell(w) = \ell(v_1) + \ell(v_2)$. The following identity will be used repeatedly to pass between the triple constants and the equivariant quantum structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y; y)$. Setting $y = 0$ in it recovers the expansion $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x; z) = \sum_{v_1 \cdot v_2 = w} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0; z)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x)$ of Kirillov–Maeno [10] in terms of quantum Schubert polynomials.

Lemma 2.1 (Quantum Cauchy identity)**.** *For all $w \in S_\infty$,*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x; z) = \sum_{v_1 \cdot v_2 = w} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y; z)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x; y).$$

Consequently, for all u, v, w and d,

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y; z) = \sum_{v_1 \cdot v_2 = v} c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y; y)\ \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y; z).$$

Proof. Let θ denote the quantization map of Fomin, Gelfand and Postnikov [5], the $\mathbb{Z}[q]$-linear map on polynomials in x which sends each standard elementary monomial $\prod_j e_{i_j}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$ to $\prod_j e^{(q)}_{i_j}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$, extended linearly over any further coefficient variables. Since the divided differences in the y-variables commute with θ, the definition of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$ by y-divided differences gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)=\theta(\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y))$ [11, (10)]. Now apply θ, which is $\mathbb{Z}[y,z]$-linear, to the classical Cauchy-type expansion $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;z)=\sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=w}\mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x;y)$ [12, (6.3)]: the left side becomes $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z)$ and the right side becomes $\sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=w}\mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x;y)$. For the second assertion, multiply the first identity (with $w=v$) by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expand each $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x;y)$ in the basis $\{\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)\}$ with coefficients $q^d c^{w,d}_{u,v_2}(y;y)$. □

Remark 2.2 ($\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ and the quantum k-Bruhat order). The *quantum k-Bruhat order* was introduced by Benedetti, Bergeron, Colmenarejo, Saliola, and Sottile [1] and studied further by Colmenarejo and Mayers [4]. That order $\preceq^{\mathbf{q}}_k$ on $S_\infty[\mathbf{q}]$ is generated by cover relations

$$u' \lessdot^{\mathbf{q}}_k \mathbf{q}^\gamma u' t_{ab}, \qquad a\le k<b,$$

each of exactly two kinds: a *classical* cover, with $\gamma=0$ and $\ell(u't_{ab})=\ell(u')+1$, or a *quantum* cover, with $\ell(u')+1=\ell(\mathbf{q}^\gamma u't_{ab})=\ell(u't_{ab})+2(b-a)$, that is $\ell(u't_{ab})=\ell(u')-2(b-a)+1$ and $\gamma=e_a+\cdots+e_{b-1}$. These are exactly the two alternatives of condition (4) of Definition 3.1. Consequently every sequence $t_{a_1b_1},\dots,t_{a_pb_p}$ witnessing $u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ is a saturated chain from u to $\mathbf{q}^\alpha w$ in the quantum k-Bruhat order, where $\mathbf{q}^\alpha$ is the monomial recorded by $q_k(u,w)$; in particular $u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ implies $u\preceq^{\mathbf{q}}_k\mathbf{q}^\alpha w$.

The relation $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ is *not* the full order $\preceq^{\mathbf{q}}_k$, however. Definition 3.1 imposes the additional requirements that the lower indices $a_1,\dots,a_p$ be pairwise distinct, so that $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ admits only those saturated chains of a special form. Thus $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ is strictly larger than the covering relation $\lessdot^{\mathbf{q}}_k$ but strictly smaller than $\preceq^{\mathbf{q}}_k$: a general chain in the quantum k-Bruhat order may reuse a lower index a_i, and such chains do not contribute to the Pieri expansion. This is the quantum counterpart of the classical situation, where the Pieri relation of [20, 18] is likewise the restriction of the k-Bruhat order to chains with distinct lower indices, and it is exactly this restriction that makes the Pieri coefficients well defined.

What we use below is only that each individual step of a $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ chain is a cover, and hence is governed by the following length-free description of the covers [1, Proposition 3.1] (see also [4, Proposition 4.2]): with $i\le k<j$, the step $u'\lessdot^{\mathbf{q}}_k\mathbf{q}^\gamma u't_{ij}$ is a classical cover exactly when $u'(i)<u'(j)$ and no l with $i<l<j$ satisfies $u'(i)<u'(l)<u'(j)$, and it is a quantum cover exactly when $u'(i)>u'(j)$ and every l with $i<l<j$ satisfies $u'(j)<u'(l)<u'(i)$. This characterization is an immediate consequence of the standard formula for the length of $u't_{ij}$ (Lemma 6.2 below), and it is the form in which the covers are used throughout Section 6.

For $d=(0,\dots,0)$, this is the ordinary triple Schubert calculus structure constant, and it was proved in [6] that these have the positivity property that they are polynomials in the differences y_i-z_j with nonnegative integer coefficients. We will refer to this as *triple Schubert positivity*. Our first main result is that it persists in the quantum setting.

Theorem 2.3 (Triple quantum Schubert positivity)**.** *For all u,v,w and d, the structure constants $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)$ are polynomials in the differences y_i-z_j with nonnegative integer coefficients.*

Proof. The proof below is adapted from the manuscript of Tongren Xiao and Yihua Yue [22], with their permission. Their product is written with the output basis carrying the parameters of the second factor. Commutativity of multiplication therefore identifies their coefficient $C^{w,d}_{v,u}(z,y)$ with $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)$. It is enough to prove that $C^{w,d}_{u,v}(y,t)$ is in $\mathbb{Z}_{\ge0}[t_i-y_j]$.

Fix $u,v,w\in S_n$, increasing n if necessary so that all permutations and parameters occurring in the coefficient under consideration are included. Write $\mathbf{a}=(t_1,\dots,t_n,y_1,\dots,y_n)$, and let $\tau\in S_{2n}$ interchange the two blocks, so that $\tau\mathbf{a}=(y_1,\dots,y_n,t_1,\dots,t_n)$. Regard the product expansion in S_{2n}:

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;\tau\mathbf{a})\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;\mathbf{a})=\sum_{w\in S_{2n}}C^{w,\tau}_{u,v}(\mathbf{a};q)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;\mathbf{a}). \tag{2.1}$$

We recall the geometric interpretation of these coefficients. Let $e_i(x)$ and $E_i(x,q)$ denote, respectively, the elementary symmetric polynomials and their quantum analogues in $2n$ variables, and set

$$J^{2n}_{\mathbf{a}}=\langle e_i(x)-e_i(\mathbf{a}) : 1\le i\le 2n\rangle, \qquad J^{2n}_{q\mathbf{a}}=\langle E_i(x,q)-e_i(\mathbf{a}) : 1\le i\le 2n\rangle.$$

The Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov deformation map [5], extended $\mathbb{Z}[\mathbf{a}]$-linearly, induces

$$\bar{\theta} : \mathbb{Z}[x, \mathbf{a}]/J^{2n}_{\mathbf{a}} \longrightarrow \mathbb{Z}[x, \mathbf{a}, q]/J^{2n}_{q\mathbf{a}}.$$

The classical Borel presentation identifies the source with $H^*_T(X)$, and Kim's presentation [9] identifies the target with $QH^*_T(X)$, where $X = \mathrm{Fl}_{2n}$. Under the Lam–Shimozono identification [11] of quantum double Schubert polynomials with quantum Schubert classes, (2.1) is the quantum equivariant Littlewood–Richardson expansion for the classes obtained by applying $\bar{\theta}$ to the first factor. Consequently,

$$C^{w,\tau}_{u,v}(\mathbf{a}; q) = \sum_{d \geq 0} q^d (\pi_{M_d})^T_* \left(\mathrm{ev}_1^*[\tau X_u]^T \ \mathrm{ev}_2^*[X_v]^T \ \mathrm{ev}_3^*[Y_w]^T \right). \tag{2.2}$$

Here $M_d = \overline{M}_{0,3}(X, d)$, $\mathrm{ev}_i : M_d \to X$ are the evaluation maps, $\pi_{M_d} : M_d \to \mathrm{pt}$ is the structure map, and X_r and Y_r denote the Schubert and opposite Schubert varieties indexed by r.

For each effective degree d, put

$$F = (\mathrm{ev}_1, \mathrm{ev}_2) : M_d \longrightarrow X \times X, \qquad I^d_{u,v} = F^{-1}(\tau X_u \times X_v), \qquad \Gamma^d_{u,v} = (\mathrm{ev}_3)_*[I^d_{u,v}].$$

The incidence scheme $I^d_{u,v}$ is reduced and locally irreducible, and all its irreducible components have codimension $\ell(u) + \ell(v)$. Indeed, the moduli space M_d is irreducible by Thomsen's theorem [21], and Mihalcea's incidence lemma [13, Lemma 6.3] applies after diagonal translation by $a_0 = 1 \times w_0 \in S_{2n}$, where w_0 is the longest element in the second block: it identifies $\tau X_u \times X_v$ with $w_0^{(2n)} X_u \times X_v$. The codimension is therefore

$$\mathrm{codim}_X(w_0^{(2n)} X_u) + \ell(v) = \ell(u) + \ell(v).$$

By the incidence formula of Mihalcea [13, Section 3.1], this gives

$$\mathrm{ev}_1^*[\tau X_u]^T \ \mathrm{ev}_2^*[X_v]^T \cap [M_d]^T = [I^d_{u,v}]_T. \tag{2.3}$$

The cycle $\Gamma^d_{u,v}$ is effective and $B^-(\tau)$-invariant. To see invariance, write $N^-(\tau) = N^- \cap \tau N^- \tau^{-1}$ and $B^-(\tau) = TN^-(\tau)$. The varieties X_v and τX_u are stable under the corresponding actions, so their product, its inverse image under the equivariant map F, and its proper push-forward under ev_3 are $B^-(\tau)$-invariant. Effectivity follows from the reducedness of $I^d_{u,v}$.

There is a unique expansion

$$[\Gamma^d_{u,v}]_T = \sum_{r \in S_{2n}} p^{r,d}_{u,v}(\mathbf{a}) [X_r]_T \quad \text{in } H^*_T(X).$$

By Gao and Xiong's Graham–positivity theorem for $B^-(\tau)$-invariant effective cycles [6, Theorem 2.3 and Corollary 2.4],

$$p^{r,d}_{u,v}(\mathbf{a}) \in \mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[t_i - y_j : 1 \leq i, j \leq n].$$

Finally, by equivariant Poincaré duality, (2.3), and the projection formula,

$$(\mathrm{ev}_3)^T_* \left(\mathrm{ev}_1^*[\tau X_u]^T \, \mathrm{ev}_2^*[X_v]^T \right) = [\Gamma^d_{u,v}]_T,$$

and hence the degree-d summand of (2.2) is

$$(\pi_X)^T_* \left([\Gamma^d_{u,v}]_T [Y_w]^T \right) = \sum_{r \in S_{2n}} p^{r,d}_{u,v}(\mathbf{a}) (\pi_X)^T_* \left([X_r]^T [Y_w]^T \right) = p^{w,d}_{u,v}(\mathbf{a}).$$

Thus every coefficient $C^{w,d}_{u,v}(y, t)$ is in $\mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[t_i - y_j]$. Replacing (u, v, y, t) by (v, u, z, y) proves the asserted positivity of $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y; z)$. □

Example 2.4. We compute the product $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15423}(x; y) \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1432}(x; z)$:

$$\begin{aligned}
&q_2 q_3 \, (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2) \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{124635}(x; y) + q_2 q_3 \, (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2) \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{13452}(x; y) \\
&+ q_2 q_3 \, (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2) \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{14253}(x; y) \\
&+ q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{125634}(x; y) + q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{126435}(x; y) + q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{13542}(x; y) + q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{214635}(x; y) \\
&+ q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{23451}(x; y) + q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{24153}(x; y) + q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{31452}(x; y) + q_2 q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{41253}(x; y) \\
&+ q_2 \, (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2) \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{146235}(x; y) + q_2 \, (y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2) \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{24513}(x; y) \\
&+ q_2 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{246135}(x; y) + q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1724356}(x; y) + q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{261435}(x; y) + q_3 \, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{35142}(x; y)
\end{aligned}$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
&+ \left(q_2q_3 + q_2\left(\left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2\right) + \left(y_4 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_1\right)\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{14523}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(\left(y_4 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_3\right) + \left(y_4 - z_1\right)\left(y_1 + y_2 - z_1 - z_2\right)\right.\\
&\quad \left. + \left(y_5 - z_2\right)\left(y_5 - z_3\right) + \left(y_5 - z_2\right)\left(y_1 + y_2 - z_1 - z_2\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{25413}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(\left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_1 - z_3\right)\left(y_4 - z_2\right) + \left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_1 - z_3\right)\left(y_5 - z_1\right) + \left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_5 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_2\right)\right.\\
&\quad \left. + \left(y_1 - z_3\right)\left(y_4 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_1\right) + \left(y_4 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_2\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15423}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(q_2 + \left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_1 - z_3\right) + \left(y_1 - z_3\right)\left(y_5 - z_1\right) + \left(y_5 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_2\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{156234}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(q_3 + \left(y_1 - z_1\right)\left(y_4 - z_1\right) + \left(y_5 - z_2\right)\left(y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{45123}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(q_2q_3 + q_3\left(\left(y_1 - z_1\right)\left(y_1 + y_5 - z_2 - z_3\right) + \left(y_5 - z_2\right)\left(y_5 - z_3\right)\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15243}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ q_3\left(y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{162435}\left(x;y\right) + q_3\left(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{25143}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ q_2q_3\left(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{12543}\left(x;y\right) + q_2q_3\left(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{21453}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ q_2q_3\left(\left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_1 - z_3\right) + \left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_2 - z_2\right) + \left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_4 - z_1\right)\right.\\
&\quad \left. + \left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_5 - z_1\right) + \left(y_2 - z_1\right)\left(y_4 - z_1\right) + \left(y_4 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 - z_3\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{12453}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1742356}\left(x;y\right) + \left(y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{461235}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{35412}\left(x;y\right) + \left(y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{45213}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(\left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_1 - z_3\right) + \left(y_1 - z_2\right)\left(y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2\right)\right.\\
&\quad \left. + \left(y_1 - z_3\right)\left(y_4 - z_1\right) + \left(y_4 - z_1\right)\left(y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2\right)\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{164235}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{256134}\left(x;y\right) + \left(y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{165234}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \left(y_1 + y_2 + y_4 + y_5 + y_6 - 2z_1 - 2z_2 - z_3\right)\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{264135}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1752346}\left(x;y\right) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{265134}\left(x;y\right) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{2741356}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{356124}\left(x;y\right) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{364125}\left(x;y\right) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{462135}\left(x;y\right)\\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{561234}\left(x;y\right)
\end{aligned}
$$

By inspection, we can see that the coefficients exhibit triple Schubert positivity.

Remark 2.5. The Pieri formula of Theorem 3.4 below is an explicit instance of Theorem 2.3: for $v = s_1 s_2 \cdots s_k$ each coefficient $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z)$ is a product of differences $y_a - z_1$. The parabolic reduction of Proposition 2.10 shows that the structure constants of the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials of the next subsection are also triple Schubert positive (Corollary 2.12).

2.2. **The parabolic case.** Unlike ordinary cohomology or equivariant cohomology, quantum cohomology and equivariant quantum cohomology do not demonstrate simple functoriality, in the sense that a projection of the complete flag variety G/B to a partial flag variety G/P does not induce a homomorphism of rings $QH_T^*(G/P) \to QH_T^*(G/B)$, and indeed the quantum cohomology of G/P is not isomorphic to the subring of the quantum cohomology of G/B generated by the Schubert classes indexed by W^P. This is reflected in the fact that there are parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials defined in a different manner that represent Schubert classes in $QH_T^*(G/P)$ [11] and are not in general equal to the quantum double Schubert polynomials above.

Definition 2.6 (Parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials)**.** Following Lam and Shimozono [11], we define parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials as follows. Fix an integer $n > 0$. A parabolic subgroup W_P of S_n, which has Coxeter generators $s_1, \ldots, s_{n-1}$, is generated by a subset $P \subseteq \{s_1, \ldots, s_{n-1}\}$. In terms of the subgroup's properties, it is most natural to identify P by the reflections that it *excludes*. If P is generated by $S \setminus \{s_{i_1}, \ldots, s_{i_k}\}$ in increasing order, we define integers $n_1, \ldots, n_{k+1}$ with

$$n_1 + \cdots + n_{k+1} = n$$

by $n_1 = i_1$ and $n_p = i_p - i_{p-1}$ for $2 \leq p \leq k+1$. Then N_j for $j \geq 1$ is defined by

$$N_j = n_1 + \cdots + n_j$$

for $0 \leq j \leq k+1$.

For such a setup, define a matrix D_j^P to be the $n \times n$ matrix with $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ on the diagonal, -1 on the superdiagonal, and $(-1)^{n_{j+1}+1} q_j$ at $(N_{j+1}, N_{j-1}+1)$ for $1 \leq j \leq k$. Notice that there are precisely k q variables, and we set

$$\deg q_j = n_j + n_{j+1}$$

Define

$$\Delta_j^P(t;x) = \det(D_j^P - t\mathrm{Id})$$

Then we define the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y)$ for $w \in W^P$ by

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y) = (-1)^{\ell(w(w_0^P)^{-1})} \partial^{(y)}_{w(w_0^P)^{-1}} \prod_{j=1}^{k} \Delta_j^P(-y_{n-N_{j+1}+1}, \ldots, -y_{n-N_j}; x)$$

where w_0^P is the longest element of W^P.

Taken as defined, when we vary n these polynomials are not stable under inclusion and do not form a basis of $\mathbb{Z}[q][x_1, \ldots, x_n; y]$ as a module over $\mathbb{Z}[q][y]$. To obtain stability and a basis, instead we fix n and choose $N > n$ as large as we would like, maintaining $N_{k+1} = n$ and setting $n_{k+2} = N - n$. From a cohomological perspective, this introduces "extraneous" polynomials that are indexed by elements not in W^P. The full indexing set is $W^{\widehat{P}} \subset S_\infty$, where

$$\widehat{P} = P \cup \{s_{n+1}, s_{n+2}, \ldots\}$$

Example 2.7. As equivariant cohomology rings of finite dimensional projective varieties over $\mathbb{C}$ are finitely generated modules over the coefficient ring, it is fully expected that products of double Schubert polynomials may include terms indexed by permutations that do not lie within the indexing set of the basis of Schubert classes. For example, consider the following non-quantum double Schubert polynomial product, with $P = \{s_1, s_3\}$ and basis elements in S_4:

$$\begin{aligned}
\mathfrak{S}_{2413}(x;y)\,\mathfrak{S}_{3412}(x;y) = &-(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)(\alpha_1+\alpha_2+\alpha_3)(\alpha_2+\alpha_3)\ \mathfrak{S}_{3412}(x;y) \\
&+ (\alpha_1+\alpha_2)(\alpha_1+2\alpha_2+2\alpha_3+\alpha_4)\ \mathfrak{S}_{35124}(x;y) \\
&- (\alpha_1+\alpha_2)\ \mathfrak{S}_{361245}(x;y) \\
&- (\alpha_1+2\alpha_2+2\alpha_3+\alpha_4)\ \mathfrak{S}_{45123}(x;y) \\
&+ \mathfrak{S}_{461235}(x;y).
\end{aligned}$$

Not only does the product $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{2413}^P(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{3412}^P(x;y)$ include extra terms indexed by permutations in W^P, there are also terms with nonzero coefficients that are in $W^{\widehat{P}} \setminus W^P$:

$$\begin{aligned}
q_1(\alpha_1\alpha_2+\alpha_1\alpha_3+\alpha_2\alpha_3+\alpha_2^2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{132}^P(x;y) &+ q_1(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{231}^P(x;y) \\
&+ q_1(\alpha_2+\alpha_3)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1423}^P(x;y) \\
&+ q_1(\alpha_1+\alpha_2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{13254}^{\widehat{P}}(x;y) \\
&+ q_1\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{14253}^{\widehat{P}}(x;y) \\
&+ q_1\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15234}^P(x;y) \\
&+ q_1\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{2413}^P(x;y)
\end{aligned}$$

Definition 2.8 (q-vectors and Peterson-Woodward lifts)**.** Define $Q^\vee$, for legacy purposes, to be the set of weak compositions. For an integer i and $d \in Q^\vee$, define

$$\langle d \rangle_i = 2d_i - d_{i-1} - d_{i+1}$$

The double indexed version will be denoted by

$$\langle d \rangle_{ij} = \sum_{k=i}^{j-1} \langle d \rangle_k$$

For a parabolic subgroup W_P, we define $Q_P^\vee$ to be the set of weak compositions d such that $\langle d\rangle_i = 0$ for all $s_i \notin P$. The q-vectors in W^P are indexed by $Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$.

Let $d_P \in Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$. A *Peterson-Woodward lift* of d_P is a $d \in Q^\vee$ such that $d_P \in d + Q_P^\vee$ and $\langle d\rangle_{ij} \in \{0,-1\}$ for all i,j such that $s_i,\ldots,s_{j-1} \in P$.

Method 2.9 (Checking the Peterson-Woodward lift property)**.** While backing out a Peterson-Woodward lift is difficult, going in the other direction is not. Suppose $d \in Q^\vee$ and P is parabolic. If there is any $i \in P$ such that $\langle d\rangle_i \notin \{0,-1\}$, then d is not a Peterson-Woodward lift. If this condition does hold, let $I_1,\ldots,I_m$ be the maximal intervals of consecutive indices i with $s_i \in P$. Since $\langle d\rangle_{ij} = \sum_{l=i}^{j-1}\langle d\rangle_l$, the condition $\langle d\rangle_{ij} \in \{0,-1\}$ for all $i<j$ with $s_i,\ldots,s_{j-1} \in P$ holds if and only if each interval I_r contains at most one index l with $\langle d\rangle_l = -1$. If and only if this is the case, d is the Peterson-Woodward lift of a unique $d_P \in Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$, namely its image, which we denote by $\pi_P(d)$. In that case we let

$$z_P(d) = \{\, i \mid s_i \in P,\ \langle d\rangle_i = 0 \,\}$$

and write $w_{z_P(d)}$ for the longest element of the parabolic subgroup generated by $\{s_i \mid i \in z_P(d)\}$, and w_P for the longest element of W_P.

This algorithm is polynomial in the length of d, which in almost all currently feasible cases is quite small. In contrast, a naive search for d with d_P as the input has an exponential search space, though a more refined algorithm may exist.

The parabolic triple quantum Schubert structure constants $c_{u,v}^{w,d_P}(y;z)$ are defined by

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u^P(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v^P(x;z) = \sum_{w\in W^{\widehat{P}},\,d_P} q^{d_P}\, c_{u,v}^{w,d_P}(y;z)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y).$$

We prove the following result in Section 9, as a consequence of the Peterson–Woodward comparison formula of Huang and Li [7] and Lemma 2.1.

Proposition 2.10. *Let W_P be a parabolic subgroup of S_∞ with $P = \widehat{P}$ and let $u,v,w \in W^P$. Then for any $d_P \in Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$ with Peterson–Woodward lift d, we have that*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d_P}(y;z) = c_{u,v}^{ww_Pw_{z_P(d)},d}(y;z).$$

Thus, though we lack a simple functoriality property, we can reduce the computation of parabolic triple quantum Schubert structure constants completely to the complete flag variety case with an efficient algorithm. We obtain a nontrivial corollary from this.

Example 2.11. The product in the example above, with $P = \widehat{P}$ satisfying $P \cap \{s_1,s_2,s_3,s_4,s_5\} = \{s_1,s_4\}$, allows us to compute the triple structure constants for the corresponding parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials:

$$\begin{aligned}
&q_1q_2\,(y_1+y_2+y_5-z_1-z_2-z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1243}^P(x;y)\\
&+q_1q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{124365}^P(x;y)+q_1q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1342}^P(x;y)+q_1q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1423}^P(x;y)\\
&+q_2\,((y_1-z_2)(y_1-z_3)+(y_1-z_3)(y_5-z_1)+(y_5-z_1)(y_5-z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15234}^P(x;y)\\
&+q_2\,(y_1+y_5+y_6-z_1-z_2-z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{162345}^P(x;y)+q_2\,(y_1+y_2+y_5-z_1-z_2-z_3)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{25134}^P(x;y)\\
&+((y_1-z_2)(y_1-z_3)(y_4-z_2)+(y_1-z_2)(y_1-z_3)(y_5-z_1)+(y_1-z_2)(y_5-z_1)(y_5-z_2)\\
&\quad+(y_1-z_3)(y_4-z_1)(y_5-z_1)+(y_4-z_1)(y_5-z_1)(y_5-z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{15423}^P(x;y)\\
&+q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{1723456}^P(x;y)+q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{261345}^P(x;y)+q_2\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{35124}^P(x;y)\\
&+((y_1-z_2)(y_1-z_3)+(y_1-z_3)(y_5-z_1)+(y_5-z_1)(y_5-z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{156234}^P(x;y)\\
&+((y_1-z_2)(y_1-z_3)+(y_1-z_2)(y_5+y_6-z_1-z_2)\\
&\quad+(y_1-z_3)(y_4-z_1)+(y_4-z_1)(y_5+y_6-z_1-z_2))\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{164235}^P(x;y)\\
&+((y_4-z_1)(y_5-z_3)+(y_4-z_1)(y_1+y_2-z_1-z_2)
\end{aligned}$$

$$
\begin{aligned}
&+ (y_5 - z_2)(y_5 - z_3) + (y_5 - z_2)(y_1 + y_2 - z_1 - z_2))\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{25413}(x;y) \\
&+ ((y_1 - z_1)(y_4 - z_1) + (y_5 - z_2)(y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2))\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{45123}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{165234}(x;y) + (y_1 + y_2 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{256134}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{1742356}(x;y) + (y_1 + y_4 - z_1 - z_2)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{461235}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_1 + y_2 + y_4 + y_5 + y_6 - 2z_1 - 2z_2 - z_3)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{264135}(x;y) \\
&+ (y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{35412}(x;y) + (y_4 + y_5 - z_1 - z_2)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{45213}(x;y) \\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{1752346}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{265134}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{2741356}(x;y) \\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{356124}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{364125}(x;y) + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{462135}(x;y) \\
&+ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{561234}(x;y)
\end{aligned}
$$

For an illustration, consider $d_P = (-, 0, 1, -, 0)$ for the coefficient of 162345. $q^{d_P} = q_2$. The Peterson-Woodward lift of d_P is $d = (0, 0, 1, 0, 0)$, and $w_P = 21354$. $z_P(d) = \{1\}$, so $w_P w_{z_P(d)} = 12354$. Thus, $w w_P w_{z_P(d)} = 162435$, and the q_2-component of the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}^P_{162345}(x;y)$ is $(y_1 + y_5 + y_6 - z_1 - z_2 - z_3)$, which is the same as the q_3-component (q^d) of the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{162435}(x;y)$ in the complete flag variety case (Example 2.4).

Corollary 2.12 (Triple quantum Schubert positivity for the parabolic case)**.** *Let W_P be a parabolic subgroup with $P = \widehat{P}$ and let $u, v, w \in W^P$. Then for every d_P the parabolic structure constant $c^{w,d_P}_{u,v}(y;z)$ exhibits triple Schubert positivity. In particular this holds when u, v, w are k-Grassmannian and P is the corresponding maximal parabolic subgroup ($n_1 = k$, $n_2 = n - k$).*

Proof. By Proposition 2.10, $c^{w,d_P}_{u,v}(y;z)$ equals a structure constant $c^{w',d}_{u,v}(y;z)$ of the complete flag variety, which lies in $\mathbb{Z}_{\geq 0}[y_i - z_j]$ by Theorem 2.3. □

3. Pieri

Definition 3.1 ($\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$, $\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)$, $q_k(u,w)$, $E_{p,k}(y;z)$, $\mathbf{E}(y_A;z)$)**.** We define a relation $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ on pairs of permutations, introduced in its non-quantum form by Sottile [20], which was used originally to indicate when the coefficient of a Schubert polynomial is nonzero in a suitable application of the Pieri formula. In the generalization to double Schubert polynomials in [18], the same relation applies to all nonzero coefficients in the expansion of the generalized Pieri formula. The relation plays the same role in our case.

Given $u, u' \in S_\infty$ and a positive integer k, we declare that $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if there exists a p with $0 \leq p \leq k$ such that there are transpositions $t_{a_1 b_1}, \ldots, t_{a_p b_p}$ satisfying

(1) $a_i \leq k < b_i$ for all i
(2) $a_i \neq a_j$ whenever $i \neq j$
(3) $b_i \geq b_j$ whenever $i < j$
(4) We have either
$$\ell(u t_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_i b_i}) = \ell(u t_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_{i-1} b_{i-1}}) + 1$$
or
$$\ell(u t_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_i b_i}) = \ell(u t_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_{i-1} b_{i-1}}) - 2(b_i - a_i) + 1$$
for all i
(5) $w = u t_{a_1 b_1} \cdots t_{a_p b_p}$

In contrast to the non-quantum case, $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ does not imply that $\ell(u) \leq \ell(w)$, as the final condition can cause the length of the permutation to drop. For intuition, the condition $\ell(u t_{ab}) = \ell(u) - 2(b-a) + 1$ means that if we write the reflection t_{ab} as

$$s_b s_{b-1} \cdots s_{a+1} s_a s_{a+1} \cdots s_{b-1} s_b$$

then each simple reflection in this word cancels a corresponding simple reflection in a reduced word for u, as opposite to the length-increase case where there is a word for which precisely one simple reflection is inserted, regardless of the length of the reflection as a permutation.

If $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, define

$$\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w) = \{u(i) \mid i \leq k \text{ and } u(i) = w(i)\}$$

and

$$n_k(u,w) = k - |\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)|.$$

Also, we define $q_k(u,w)$ recursively. If $u = w$, define $q_k(u,w) = 1$. If we have defined $q_k(u,w')$ with $w' = t_{a_1b_1}\cdots t_{a_{p-1}b_{p-1}}$, suppose $\ell(w't_{a_pb_p}) = \ell(w') + 1$. Then define

$$q_k(u,w) = q_k(u,w')$$

If instead $\ell(w't_{a_pb_p}) = \ell(w') - 2(b_p - a_p) + 1$, define

$$q_k(u,w) = q_k(u,w')q_{a_pb_p}$$

Suppose y and z are sets of variables and $0 \leq p \leq k$ are integers. We define $E_{p,k}(y;z)$ to be the factorial elementary symmetric polynomial in y and z. For specificity, this is the double Schubert polynomial $\mathfrak{S}_{c[p,k]}(y;z)$ where

$$c[p,k] = s_{k-p+1}\cdots s_{k-1}s_k$$

If $p = 0$, the polynomial is identically 1. If $p = k$, $E_{k,k}(y;z)$ can be simply written as

$$E_{k,k}(y;z) = \prod_{i=1}^{k}(y_i - z_1)$$

An explicit formula can be written for general p without too much trouble as well, using e.g. [15]:

$$E_{p,k}(y;z) = \sum_{1\leq i_1<\cdots<i_p\leq k}\prod_{j=1}^{p}(y_{i_j} - z_{i_j-j+1})$$

For a set $A = \{i_1,\ldots,i_{|A|}\}$, we define

$$\mathbf{E}(y_A;z) = \prod_{i\in A}(y_i - z_1) = E_{|A|,|A|}(y_{i_1},\ldots,y_{i_{|A|}};z),$$

the specialization of the factorial elementary polynomial to which the coefficients of the Pieri formula reduce. It will be used to express those coefficients.

Definition 3.2 (Quantum factorial elementary polynomials $\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z)$)**.** For $0 \leq p \leq k$ we define

$$\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{c[p,k]}(x;z),$$

the quantum double Schubert polynomial of the Grassmannian permutation $c[p,k] = s_{k-p+1}\cdots s_k$, whose diagram is a single column of height p with descent at k. At $q = 0$ this is $E_{p,k}(x;z)$. We also set $\widetilde{E}_{0,k} = 1$ and $\widetilde{E}_{p,k} = 0$ for $p < 0$.

Lemma 3.3. *For $k \geq 1$,*

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \Delta_k(-z_1 \mid x_1,\ldots,x_k) = \sum_{j=0}^{k}(-z_1)^{k-j}e_j^{(q)}(x_1,\ldots,x_k).$$

Proof. The permutation $c[k,k] = s_1s_2\cdots s_k$ has a unique reduced word, so its reduced factorizations are $v_1 = s_1\cdots s_j$, $v_2 = s_{j+1}\cdots s_k$ for $0 \leq j \leq k$. By Lemma 2.1 with $y = 0$, $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_j \mathfrak{S}_{s_1\cdots s_j}(0;z)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{j+1}\cdots s_k}(x)$. Here $s_1\cdots s_j$ is dominant with code (1^j), so $\mathfrak{S}_{s_1\cdots s_j}(x;z) = \prod_{i\leq j}(x_i - z_1)$ and $\mathfrak{S}_{s_1\cdots s_j}(0;z) = (-z_1)^j$; and $s_{j+1}\cdots s_k$ is the Grassmannian permutation with descent at k and a single column of height $k-j$, whose Schubert polynomial $e_{k-j}(x_1,\ldots,x_k)$ is a standard elementary monomial, so that its quantum Schubert polynomial is $e^{(q)}_{k-j}(x_1,\ldots,x_k)$ [5]. Summing gives the second expression, which equals $\Delta_k(-z_1 \mid x_1,\ldots,x_k)$ by the definition of the quantum elementary polynomials. □

Theorem 3.4 (The Pieri formula)**.** *Suppose $u \in S_\infty$ and $k \geq 1$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)};z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

The proof is given in Section 6. Note that the right-hand side is manifestly triple Schubert positive, in accordance with Theorem 2.3, and that at $q = 0$ it reduces to the case $p = k$ of the Pieri formula of [18, Theorem 7.1].

4. Algorithms for multiplying (quantum) double Schubert polynomials

Definition 4.1 ($\mathfrak{c}$, (strict) dominant permutations, θ, μ, $\widetilde{\theta}$, $\widetilde{\mu}$, medium theta $\overline{\theta}$, $\overline{\mu}$)**.** We say that a permutation μ is *dominant* if $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu) \geq \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(\mu)$ for all i. A permutation μ is said to be *strict dominant* if μ is dominant and whenever $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu) \neq 0$ we have $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu) > \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(\mu)$. For a permutation $v \in S_\infty$, we define a dominant permutation $\mu(v)$ recursively as follows. If v is already dominant, define $\mu(v) = v$. Otherwise, let i be the maximal index such that $\mathfrak{c}_i(v) < \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(v)$, and define

$$\mu(v) = \mu(vs_i)$$

Define $\theta_i(v)$ to be $\mathfrak{c}_i(\mu(v))$.

Similarly, for a permutation $v \in S_\infty$, we define a strict dominant permutation $\widetilde{\mu}(v)$ recursively as follows. If v is already strict dominant, define $\widetilde{\mu}(v) = v$. Otherwise, let i be the maximal index such that $\mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(v) \neq 0$ and $\mathfrak{c}_i(v) \leq \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}(v)$, then define

$$\widetilde{\mu}(v) = \widetilde{\mu}(vs_i)$$

Define $\widetilde{\theta}_i(v)$ to be $\mathfrak{c}_i(\widetilde{\mu}(v))$.

Between these two lies the *medium theta* $\overline{\theta}(v)$, the partition actually iterated by the quantum multiplication algorithm. Like $\theta(v)$ it is a weakly decreasing partition obtained from $\mathfrak{c}(v)$ by incrementing and reordering, but it stops short of separating every pair of equal parts: a pair of equal consecutive nonzero parts $\overline{\theta}_i(v) = \overline{\theta}_{i+1}(v)$ is left in place exactly when it is preceded by a strict drop of at least two, that is $\overline{\theta}_{i-1}(v) \geq \overline{\theta}_i(v) + 2$ (or $i = 1$), and every other ascent or equality is removed by incrementing as for θ. Thus $\overline{\theta}(v)$ permits some, but not all, repeated parts, and lies between $\theta(v)$ (arbitrary repeats) and $\widetilde{\theta}(v)$ (no repeats). We write $\overline{\mu}(v)$ for the permutation with $\mathfrak{c}(\overline{\mu}(v)) = \overline{\theta}(v)$ and set $|\overline{\theta}(v)| := \sum_i \overline{\theta}_i(v) = \ell(\overline{\mu}(v))$. The number of nonzero parts of $\overline{\theta}(v)$ equals the number of nonzero parts of $\mathfrak{c}(v)$.

Definition 4.2 ($\overset{i}{\Rightarrow}$, $\ell(u,v)$, $\sigma_i(u,v)$, $D_i(u,v)$, z_D)**.** Let $u, v \in S_\infty$ and $i \geq 1$ be an integer. We define $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} v$ if there exist distinct integers $b_1, b_2, \ldots, b_k$ such that $b_j \neq i$ for all j, $\ell(ut_{i,b_1}\cdots t_{i,b_j}) = \ell(u) + j$ for all j, and

$$v = ut_{i,b_1}\cdots t_{i,b_k}.$$

Thus $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} v$ means that v is reached from u by a chain of Bruhat covers $u \lessdot ut_{ib_1} \lessdot ut_{ib_1}t_{ib_2} \lessdot \cdots \lessdot v$, each of which exchanges the position i with a position not used before. The sequence $b_1, \ldots, b_k$ is determined by u and v: the product $u^{-1}v = t_{ib_1}\cdots t_{ib_k}$ is the cycle $i \mapsto b_k \mapsto b_{k-1} \mapsto \cdots \mapsto b_1 \mapsto i$, from which the b_j are read off. We write $\ell(u,v) = \ell(v) - \ell(u) = k$ and define

$$\sigma_i(u,v) = \#\{j \mid b_j < i\}, \qquad D_i(u,v) = \{u(i)\} \cup \{u(j) \mid u(j) \neq v(j)\} = \{u(i), u(b_1), \ldots, u(b_k)\},$$

a set of $k+1$ values. Finally, for a finite set $D = \{d_1 < \cdots < d_m\}$ of positive integers with $m = k - p + 1$ we write $E_{p,k}(x; z_D) = E_{p,k}(x; z_{d_1}, \ldots, z_{d_m})$ and $\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x; z_D) = \widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x; z_{d_1}, \ldots, z_{d_m})$; since these polynomials are symmetric in $z_1, \ldots, z_{k-p+1}$ (Lemma 7.3), the order in which the elements of D are listed is immaterial. As in Definition 3.2, $E_{p,k} = \widetilde{E}_{p,k} = 0$ when $p < 0$.

The following two formulas express a (quantum) double Schubert polynomial as a signed sum of products of (quantum) factorial elementary polynomials in nested initial alphabets; they are the v-side input of the multiplication algorithm, and they are proved in Section 7. Both start from a dominant permutation μ lying above v^{-1} in the right weak order, that is $\mu = v^{-1} \cdot y$ with $\ell(\mu) = \ell(v) + \ell(y)$; the permutations $\mu(v^{-1})$ and $\widetilde{\mu}(v^{-1})$ are of this kind, since each step of their construction multiplies on the right by a simple reflection s_i with $\mathfrak{c}_i < \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}$ (respectively $\mathfrak{c}_i \leq \mathfrak{c}_{i+1}$), which forces $v(i) < v(i+1)$ and so increases the length. The implementation uses $\mu = \mu(v^{-1})$ in the classical case, and the parts of $\mathfrak{c}(\mu)$ are then the $\theta_i(v^{-1})$ of Definition 4.1. In the quantum case the dominant permutation has to be strict dominant, because

the quantum polynomial $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{\mu^{-1}}(x;z)$ which is being expanded factors into a product of quantum factorial elementary polynomials only when the column heights of the diagram of μ^{-1}, which are the parts of $\mathfrak{c}(\mu)$, are pairwise distinct (Lemma 7.4); for repeated column heights it is *not* a product (see Section 8). This is the reason μ is replaced by $\widetilde{\mu}$. The implementation uses the intermediate shape $\overline{\theta}$, in which an equal pair of columns is allowed when there is room for it, and handles such a pair by the doubled formula of Theorem 8.4.

Theorem 4.3 (Formula for ordinary double Schubert polynomials)**.** *Let $v \in S_\infty$ and let μ be a dominant permutation with $\mu = v^{-1} \cdot y$ reduced, for instance $\mu = \mu(v^{-1})$. Let $\theta = \mathfrak{c}(\mu)$, with nonzero parts $\theta_1 \geq \cdots \geq \theta_k > 0$. Then*

$$\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = \sum_{(v_0,\ldots,v_k)} \prod_{i=1}^{k} (-1)^{\sigma_i(v_{i-1},v_i)} E_{\theta_i - \ell(v_{i-1},v_i),\,\theta_i}\big(x; z_{D_i(v_{i-1},v_i)}\big),$$

the sum being over all sequences $1 = v_0 \overset{1}{\Rightarrow} v_1 \overset{2}{\Rightarrow} v_2 \overset{3}{\Rightarrow} \cdots \overset{k}{\Rightarrow} v_k = v\mu$.

Theorem 4.4 (Formula for quantum double Schubert polynomials)**.** *Let $v \in S_\infty$ and let μ be a strict dominant permutation with $\mu = v^{-1} \cdot y$ reduced, for instance $\mu = \widetilde{\mu}(v^{-1})$. Let $\widetilde{\theta} = \mathfrak{c}(\mu)$, with nonzero parts $\widetilde{\theta}_1 > \cdots > \widetilde{\theta}_k > 0$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z) = \sum_{(v_0,\ldots,v_k)} \prod_{i=1}^{k} (-1)^{\sigma_i(v_{i-1},v_i)} \widetilde{E}_{\widetilde{\theta}_i - \ell(v_{i-1},v_i),\,\widetilde{\theta}_i}\big(x; z_{D_i(v_{i-1},v_i)}\big),$$

the sum being over all sequences $1 = v_0 \overset{1}{\Rightarrow} v_1 \overset{2}{\Rightarrow} \cdots \overset{k}{\Rightarrow} v_k = v\mu$.

Coupled with the Pieri formulas, these formulas give an algorithm for computing products of (quantum) double Schubert polynomials, which is the one implemented in [19]. We describe its classical form by building it from two ingredients: the elementary Pieri step that generates the u-side covers, and the signed path expansion on the v-side.

Definition 4.5 (k-strip cover, admissible k-chain, the (p,k)-Pieri problem)**.** Let $w \in S_n$, let $1 \leq k < n$, and let $\beta \in \{1,\ldots,n\} \cup \{\infty\}$. A *$k$-strip cover of (w,β)* is a transposition t_{ab} of positions a, b with $1 \leq a \leq k < b \leq n$ such that

(1) $w \lessdot wt_{ab}$ in Bruhat order; that is, $w(a) < w(b)$ and no c with $a < c < b$ satisfies $w(a) < w(c) < w(b)$; and
(2) $w(b) < \beta$.

Its *output* is the pair $(wt_{ab},\, w(b))$. An *admissible k-chain of length p* from u is a sequence $u = w_0, w_1, \ldots, w_p$ carrying bounds $\infty = \beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_p$ in which (w_t, β_t) is the output of a k-strip cover of (w_{t-1}, β_{t-1}) for every t. The *(p,k)-Pieri problem* for u asks to enumerate every admissible k-chain from u of length at most p. These chains index the permutations occurring in $e_p(x_1,\ldots,x_k)\ \mathfrak{S}_u$, where e_p is the elementary symmetric polynomial.

Method 4.6 (**pieri**(u,p,k))**.** Given $u \in S_n$, $1 \leq k < n$, and $0 \leq p \leq k$, the algorithm returns a list T of pairs (w,t), one for each admissible k-chain from u of length $t \leq p$, recording its endpoint w.

(1) Initialize $T \leftarrow [(u,0)]$ and a frontier $F \leftarrow [(u,\infty)]$.
(2) For $t = 1,\ldots,p$, form a new frontier $F' \leftarrow [\,]$ and, for each $(w,\beta) \in F$:
   (a) compute $A \leftarrow \{\, a \in \{1,\ldots,k\} \mid w(a) < \beta \,\}$;
   (b) for each $b = k+1,\ldots,n$ with $w(b) < \beta$, and each $a \in A$ for which t_{ab} is a k-strip cover of (w,β), append $(wt_{ab},\, w(b))$ to F' and $(wt_{ab},\, t)$ to T.
   Then set $F \leftarrow F'$.
(3) Return T.

Lemma 4.7 (Multiplicity-freeness)**.** *For each t, distinct admissible k-chains from u of length t have distinct endpoints; equivalently, the endpoint map is a bijection from admissible k-chains of length t onto the permutations w with $w \geqslant^k u$ of length $\ell(u) + t$ produced by the Pieri rule for $e_t(x_1,\ldots,x_k)$.*

Proof. The strictly decreasing bounds $\beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots$ force the values moved leftward across position k to be strictly decreasing, which is exactly the condition making the e_t-Pieri expansion multiplicity-free; see [2]. Reconstructing the chain from its endpoint by peeling off these moves in decreasing order of value shows the map is injective, hence bijective onto the Pieri support. □

We now describe the v-side primitive. Its starting point is the structure of a *dominant* double Schubert polynomial. If μ is dominant and the columns of its diagram have heights $\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_m$ (so that $(\lambda_1, \ldots, \lambda_m) = \mathfrak{c}(\mu^{-1})$), then $\mathfrak{S}_\mu(x; z)$ factors as a product of factorial elementary symmetric polynomials of maximal degree, one per column of the shape,

$$\mathfrak{S}_\mu(x; z) = \prod_{i=1}^{m} E_{\lambda_i,\, \lambda_i}(x; z_i)$$

(Lemma 7.4). For a general v one writes $\mathfrak{S}_v(x; z)$ by applying divided differences in the z-variables to the dominant polynomial $\mathfrak{S}_{\mu^{-1}}(x; z)$ with $\mu = \mu(v^{-1})$, whose column heights are the parts of $\theta(v^{-1})$; because that polynomial factors by column, the divided-difference action decouples and may be carried out one column (one variable z_i) at a time. Applied to a single column this produces a *signed* descending expansion. The following primitive carries it out.

Definition 4.8 (k-strip descent beneath an edge, the down-Pieri problem)**.** Let $w, \mu \in S_n$ and $1 \le k < n$. Say w' lies *beneath the edge* μ if

$$\operatorname{inv}(w'\mu) = \operatorname{inv}(\mu) - \operatorname{inv}(w'),$$

that is, $\ell(w'\mu) = \ell(\mu) - \ell(w')$. A *$k$-strip descent* of w is a Bruhat descent $w \gtrdot wt_{ab}$ realized by a transposition t_{ab} that moves the value in the pivot position k either leftward (from a position $a < k$, with sign -1) or rightward (to a position $b > k$, with sign $+1$), touching only positions still holding their original value. Given a starting label w, the edge μ, a degree p, and the column k, the *down-Pieri problem* asks for the signed list of those length-t descending k-strip chains from w ($t \le p$) whose endpoint lies beneath μ.

Method 4.9 (**kdown**(w, μ, p, k))**.** The algorithm returns a signed list D of triples (w', t, s), one for each length-t descending k-strip chain from w ($t \le p$) whose endpoint w' lies beneath μ, with $s \in \{+1, -1\}$ its sign.

(1) Initialize $D \leftarrow [\,]$; if w is already beneath μ, append $(w, 0, +1)$. Set a frontier $F \leftarrow [(w, +1)]$.
(2) For $t = 1, \ldots, p$, form $F' \leftarrow [\,]$ and, for each $(w'', s) \in F$:
   (a) (leftward) for each position $a < k$ with $w''(a) = w(a)$ such that $w'' \gtrdot w''t_{a,k}$ is a Bruhat descent, set $w''' \leftarrow w''t_{a,k}$ and append $(w''', -s)$ to F'; if w''' is beneath μ, append $(w''', t, -s)$ to D;
   (b) (rightward) for each position $b > k$ with $w''(b) = w(b)$ such that $w'' \gtrdot w''t_{k,b}$ is a Bruhat descent, set $w''' \leftarrow w''t_{k,b}$ and append $(w''', +s)$ to F'; if w''' is beneath μ, append $(w''', t, +s)$ to D.

   Then set $F \leftarrow F'$.
(3) Return D.

Applied without the edge μ, the signed descending expansion produces many extraneous terms that ultimately cancel. The edge is exactly the bound that discards them: only endpoints beneath μ are retained in D. In the assembled v-side (Method 4.10 below), only these retained labels seed the next column, so each stage passes forward only labels compatible with the remaining shape.

Method 4.10 (**vpaths**(v), the v-side path dictionaries)**.** Let $\theta := \theta(v^{-1})$ with nonzero parts in columns $1, \ldots, L$, and let $\nu := v\,\mu(v^{-1})$. Processing columns from $i = L$ down to $i = 1$, maintain for each column a set of live labels (initialized at column L to the single label ν). At column i, with $k = i$ and edge $\mu_i := \mu$ of the shape truncated below column i, call **kdown**(w, μ_i, θ_i, k) for each live label w; record its signed output triples as the transitions out of w, and let their endpoints be the live labels seeding column $i - 1$. The collected transitions form the path dictionaries used by **schubmult**.

Lemma 4.11 (Correctness of the edge filter)**.** *A permutation w' produced by a descending k-strip chain from w is retained by* **kdown**(w, μ, p, k) *if and only if w' lies beneath μ, i.e.* $\operatorname{inv}(w'\mu) = \operatorname{inv}(\mu) - \operatorname{inv}(w')$. *In the assembly of Method 4.10 the retained signed labels are exactly the terms of $\mathfrak{S}_v(x; z)$ contributed through column i, so no extraneous (cancelling) label propagates to column $i - 1$.*

Proof. The retention test is the identity $\mathrm{inv}(w'\mu) = \mathrm{inv}(\mu) - \mathrm{inv}(w')$ checked in step (2); this is precisely the condition that $w' \leq \mu$ with $\ell(w'\mu) = \ell(\mu) - \ell(w')$. The factorization of the dominant polynomial by column, together with the column-wise decoupling of the z-divided differences, identifies the beneath-μ endpoints at column i with the surviving monomials of $\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z)$ after processing that column; the extraneous chains are exactly those leaving the shape, which the edge discards before they seed column $i-1$. □

Method 4.12 (The algorithm **schubmult**)**.** Fix n and let $u, v \in S_n$. The algorithm **schubmult**(u,v) computes the expansion of $\mathfrak{S}_u(x;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z)$ in the Schubert basis as follows. Set $\theta := \theta(v^{-1})$ and let

$$L := \#\{i \mid \theta_i \neq 0\}$$

be the number of nonzero parts. The algorithm proceeds in L layers. It maintains a *front*, a collection of nodes each consisting of an intermediate permutation on the u-side paired with a label on the v-side, initialized to the single node $(u,\, e)$. At layer i it replaces each node by the nodes obtained by combining one u-side cover, generated by **pieri**$(\,\cdot\,, \theta_i, \theta_i)$ (Method 4.6), with one v-side transition, generated by **vpaths**(v) (Method 4.10), accumulating coefficients in the coefficient ring. After all L layers the surviving coefficients at v-label $v\mu(v^{-1})$ give the structure constants.

Quantum version. The same path organization gives the quantum multiplication algorithm. Its layers are indexed by the medium theta $\overline{\theta}(v^{-1})$; equal consecutive parts that are retained in this shape are handled together by the paired quantum Pieri step, the doubled formula of Theorem 8.4 (see Remark 8.38 for why the pair must be preceded by a drop of at least two). On the u-side, classical covers are replaced by the quantum covers of Remark 2.2, including length-decreasing moves, whose contributions carry the corresponding q-monomials. The v-side continues to use the descending path dictionaries of Method 4.10. Thus the two algorithms share the same layer-by-layer structure, while their Pieri transitions reflect the classical or quantum multiplication rule, respectively.

The algorithmic construction is one way to compute products. We now turn to a complementary operator description, which packages the quantum multiplication rules in the Fomin–Gelfand–Postnikov difference operators.

4.1. Difference operators and multiplication coefficients.

Definition 4.13 ($\chi_{j;n}$, $\chi^{(n)}$)**.** Recall the commuting difference operators $\chi_{j;n}$, $j \leq n$, of Fomin, Gelfand, and Postnikov [5], acting on polynomials in $x_1, \ldots, x_n$ (with coefficients in any further variables):

$$\chi_{j;n} = x_j - \sum_{1 \leq i < j} q_{ij} \partial^{t_{ij}} + \sum_{j < k \leq n} q_{jk} \partial^{t_{jk}},$$

where for a transposition t we write ∂^t for the divided difference operator ∂_t in the x-variables associated with any reduced word of t, so that $\partial^t\, \mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = \mathfrak{S}_{vt}(x;z)$ if $\ell(vt) = \ell(v) - \ell(t)$ and $\partial^t\, \mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = 0$ otherwise. We denote the sequence $(\chi_{1;n}, \ldots, \chi_{n;n})$ with n fixed by $\chi^{(n)}$. Fomin, Gelfand and Postnikov proved [5] that if $v \in S_n$ then

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)})(1) = \mathfrak{S}_v(x),$$

and hence, by Lemma 2.1 with $y = 0$ (whose coefficients $\mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0;z)$ commute with the operators),

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)}; z)(1) = \sum_{v_1 \cdot v_2 = v} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0;z)\, \mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x) = \mathfrak{S}_v(x;z).$$

We specify a more precise formula, as follows.

Theorem 4.14. *Suppose $v \in S_n$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)}; z) = \sum_{u \in S_n, d} q^d c^{1,d}_{u,v}(x;z) \partial^u$$

Proof. Note that if $\mathfrak{S}_u(x)$ has at most n variables, then

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(\chi^{(n)}; y)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)}; z) = \sum_{w,d} q^d c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(\chi^{(n)}; y)$$

We thus have that

$$(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(\chi^{(n)}; y)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)}; z))(1) = \sum_{w,d} q^d c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;z)\, \mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$$

This is also equal to

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)(\mathfrak{S}_u(x;y))$$

due to the fact that $(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(\chi^{(n)};y))(1)=\mathfrak{S}_u(x;y)$. To obtain the coefficient of ∂^u in $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)$, we set $y=x$ after applying this operator. Since $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;x)=0$ unless $w=1$, we have that

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(\chi^{(n)};z)(\mathfrak{S}_u(x;y))|_{y=x}=\sum_d q^d c^{1,d}_{u,v}(x;z)$$

and the result follows. □

Theorem 4.15. *Let k be an integer and let $v,w\in S_\infty$. Then*

$$\sum_d q^d c^{w,d}_{s_k,v}(y;z)=c^w_{s_k,v}(y;z)+\sum_{i\le k<j} q_{ij}\,\mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}w^{-1}}(y;z),$$

where the sum is over those $i<j$ with $\ell(vt_{ij})=\ell(v)-\ell(t_{ij})$, and $\mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}w^{-1}}(y;z)$ is to be read as 0 unless $\ell(vt_{ij})=\ell(vt_{ij}w^{-1})+\ell(w)$.

Proof. We have that the desired value is equal to the coefficient of $\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$ in

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_k}(\chi^{(n)};y)(\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z))$$

We have that

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_k}(\chi^{(n)};y)=\mathfrak{S}_{s_k}(x;y)+\sum_{i\le k<j\le n} q_{ij}\partial^{t_{ij}}$$

Applying this operator, we obtain

$$\sum_{i\le k<j\le n} q_{ij}\,\mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}}(x;z)+\sum_w c^w_{s_k,v}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y)$$

Applying the Cauchy formula (Lemma 2.1 at $q=0$), this is equal to

$$\sum_{i\le k<j}\sum_u q_{ij}\,\mathfrak{S}_{vt_{ij}u^{-1}}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_u(x;y)+\sum_w c^w_{s_k,v}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y),$$

the inner sum being over the reduced factorizations $vt_{ij}=(vt_{ij}u^{-1})\cdot u$. Setting $u=w$ and allowing n to be sufficiently large, we obtain the result. □

5. Quantum to classical reduction

In this section we extend the quantum-to-classical reduction of Huang and Li [7] from the equivariant quantum structure constants $c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)$ to the triple constants. We write $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=1$ if $w(i)>w(i+1)$ and $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=0$ otherwise, $\delta_i\in Q^\vee$ for the weak composition with a single 1 in position i, and $|d|=\sum_i d_i$; the bracket $\langle d\rangle_i=2d_i-d_{i-1}-d_{i+1}$ was defined in Section 2. We say that $u\in S_\infty$ is *k-Grassmannian* if k is its only descent.

Theorem 5.1 ([7, Theorem 2.7])**.** *We have the following.*

1. *$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=0$ unless $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)+\langle d\rangle_i\le\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)$ for all i.*
2. *If $\mathrm{sgn}_k(w)+\langle d\rangle_k=\mathrm{sgn}_k(u)+\mathrm{sgn}_k(v)=2$ for some k, then*

$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=c^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}_{us_k,vs_k}(y;y)=\begin{cases}c^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}_{us_k,v}(y;y) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w)=0\\ c^{ws_k,d}_{us_k,v}(y;y) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w)=1\end{cases}$$

This is symmetric in u and v.

Corollary 5.2 ([7, Corollary 2.8])**.** *Let $u,v,w\in S_\infty$ and $d\in Q^\vee$. Fix an index i.*

1. *If $\langle d\rangle_i=\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)=0$ and $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)=1$, then*
$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=c^{ws_i,d}_{u,vs_i}(y;y).$$
2. *If $\langle d\rangle_i=\mathrm{sgn}_i(u)=1$ and $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w)=\mathrm{sgn}_i(v)=0$, then*
$$c^{w,d}_{u,v}(y;y)=c^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}_{us_i,v}(y;y).$$

This is symmetric in u and v.

Theorem 5.3 (Quantum reduction holds for triple quantum Schubert coefficients)**.** *We have the following.*

(1) $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = 0$ *unless* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w) + \langle d\rangle_i \leq \mathrm{sgn}_i(u) + \mathrm{sgn}_i(v)$ *for all* i.
(2) *If* $\mathrm{sgn}_k(w) + \langle d\rangle_k = \mathrm{sgn}_k(u) + \mathrm{sgn}_k(v) = 2$ *for some* k*, then*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = c_{us_k,vs_k}^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}(y;z) = \begin{cases} c_{us_k,v}^{ws_k,d-\delta_k}(y;z) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w) = 0 \\ c_{us_k,v}^{ws_k,d}(y;z) & \text{if } \mathrm{sgn}_k(w) = 1 \end{cases}$$

This is symmetric in u *and* v.

Proof. For (1), we note that since $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v_2) \leq \mathrm{sgn}_i(v)$ for any factorization $v_1 \cdot v_2 = v$, we have that $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w) + \langle d\rangle_i \leq \mathrm{sgn}_i(u) + \mathrm{sgn}_i(v_2)$ is a necessary condition for $c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y;y) \neq 0$. The result then follows from Lemma 2.1.

For (2), we note that if $\mathrm{sgn}_k(w) + \langle d\rangle_k = \mathrm{sgn}_k(u) + \mathrm{sgn}_k(v) = 2$, then since $\mathrm{sgn}_k(v_2) = \mathrm{sgn}_k(v)$ for any factorization $v_1 \cdot v_2 = v$ such that $c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y;y) \neq 0$, Theorem 5.1(2) holds for each term in the sum in Lemma 2.1, and the result follows. □

Corollary 5.4 (z-version of Corollary 5.2(2))**.** *Let* $u, v, w \in S_\infty$ *and* $d \in Q^\vee$*, and fix an index* i *with* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = 0$*. If* $\langle d\rangle_i = \mathrm{sgn}_i(u) = 1$ *and* $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w) = 0$*, then*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = c_{us_i,v}^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}(y;z).$$

Proof. Since $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v_2) \leq \mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = 0$ for every factorization $v_1 \cdot v_2 = v$, the hypotheses of Corollary 5.2(2) hold for each term $c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y;y)$ appearing in Lemma 2.1, so $c_{u,v_2}^{w,d}(y;y) = c_{us_i,v_2}^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}(y;y)$. Resumming via Lemma 2.1 gives the claim. □

Lemma 5.5 (Reduction to a coroot supported at k)**.** *Let* $u, v, w \in S_\infty$ *and let* $d \in Q^\vee$*. Suppose* v *has precisely one descent, which is* k*. If* $c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) \neq 0$*, then there exist* $u', w' \in S_\infty$ *and* $d' \in Q^\vee$ *with* $0 \leq d' \leq d$ *such that*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = c_{u',v}^{w',d'}(y;z)$$

and $\langle d'\rangle_i \leq 0$ *for all* $i \neq k$*. Moreover, if* $d' \neq 0$ *then* $\langle d'\rangle_k > 0$.

Proof. Suppose $\langle d\rangle_i > 0$ for some $i \neq k$, and choose such an i to be maximal. Because v is k-Grassmannian, $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = 0$, so Theorem 5.3(1) forces

$$\mathrm{sgn}_i(w) + \langle d\rangle_i \leq \mathrm{sgn}_i(u) + \mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = \mathrm{sgn}_i(u) \leq 1.$$

Since $\langle d\rangle_i \geq 1$, we conclude $\langle d\rangle_i = 1$, $\mathrm{sgn}_i(u) = 1$, and $\mathrm{sgn}_i(w) = 0$. These are exactly the hypotheses of Corollary 5.4 (note $\mathrm{sgn}_i(v) = 0$), so

$$c_{u,v}^{w,d}(y;z) = c_{us_i,v}^{ws_i,d-\delta_i}(y;z).$$

Moreover $\langle d\rangle_i = 2d_i - d_{i-1} - d_{i+1} = 1$ with $d_{i\pm1} \geq 0$ forces $d_i \geq 1$, so $d - \delta_i \in Q^\vee$ with $0 \leq d - \delta_i \leq d$ and $|d - \delta_i| < |d|$. Replacing (u, w, d) by $(us_i, v \text{ fixed}, ws_i, d - \delta_i)$ and iterating, the quantity $|d|$ strictly decreases at each step, so the process terminates in a triple (u', w', d') with $\langle d'\rangle_i \leq 0$ for all $i \neq k$.

Finally, for any finitely supported $d' \in Q^\vee$ the values $\langle d'\rangle_i = 2d'_i - d'_{i-1} - d'_{i+1}$ telescope to $\sum_i \langle d'\rangle_i = 0$. Hence $\langle d'\rangle_k = -\sum_{i\neq k}\langle d'\rangle_i \geq 0$, with equality if and only if $\langle d'\rangle_i = 0$ for all i, i.e. $d' = 0$. Thus $d' \neq 0$ implies $\langle d'\rangle_k > 0$. □

6. Proof of the Pieri formula

Throughout this section permutations act on positions: $(vt_{ab})(a) = v(b)$, $(vt_{ab})(b) = v(a)$, and $(vt_{ab})(r) = v(r)$ otherwise. A cycle is written $(a_p, \ldots, a_1, b)$ with the meaning $a_p \mapsto a_{p-1} \mapsto \cdots \mapsto a_1 \mapsto b \mapsto a_p$; when $b = \max\{a_1, \ldots, a_p, b\}$ we call b the *top* of the cycle and refer to

$$(a_p, \ldots, a_1, b) = t_{a_1 b}\, t_{a_2 b} \cdots t_{a_p b} \tag{6.1}$$

as its *pivot factorization*. (Indeed, the right-hand side sends $a_p \mapsto b \mapsto a_{p-1}$, $b \mapsto a_p$ and $a_1 \mapsto b$.)

6.1. **The single-variable Monk formula.**

Lemma 6.1. *Let $u \in S_\infty$ and let $i, j \geq 1$. Then*

$$(x_i - z_j)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) = (y_{u(i)} - z_j)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{p\neq i\\ \ell(ut_{ip})=\ell(u)+1}} \operatorname{sign}(p-i)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ip}}(x;y)$$
$$+ \sum_{\substack{p\neq i\\ \ell(ut_{ip})=\ell(u)-2|p-i|+1}} \operatorname{sign}(p-i) q_{ip}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ip}}(x;y)$$

where q_{ip} stands for $q_{\min(i,p)\max(i,p)}$.

Proof. The quantum double Schubert polynomials represent the Schubert classes in the torus-equivariant quantum cohomology of the flag manifold [11], so they satisfy the equivariant quantum Chevalley formula of Mihalcea [14, Theorem 1]. In type A, with $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_m}(x;y) = \sum_{a\leq m}(x_a - y_a)$, that formula reads

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_m}(x;y)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) = \sum_{a\leq m}(y_{u(a)} - y_a)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{a\leq m<b\\ \ell(ut_{ab})=\ell(u)+1}} \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ab}}(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{a\leq m<b\\ \ell(ut_{ab})=\ell(u)-2(b-a)+1}} q_{ab}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{ab}}(x;y),$$

the diagonal coefficient being the localization of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_m}(x;y)$ at u, and the two sums ranging over the classical and quantum covers of u in the quantum Bruhat graph (for $\alpha = e_a - e_b$ one has $\langle \omega_m, \alpha^\vee\rangle = 1$ exactly when $a \leq m < b$, and $\langle 2\rho, \alpha^\vee\rangle = 2(b-a)$). By stability we may work in S_n for n large. Now

$$x_i - z_j = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_i}(x;y) - \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{i-1}}(x;y) + y_i - z_j,$$

with the term $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{i-1}}$ omitted when $i = 1$. Subtracting the two Chevalley formulas, the diagonal coefficients combine to $(y_{u(i)} - y_i) + (y_i - z_j) = y_{u(i)} - z_j$, and the reflections t_{ab} with $a < i < b$ occur in both sums with the same coefficient and cancel. What remains are the reflections t_{ib} with $b > i$ (from $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_i}$, with sign $+1$) and t_{ai} with $a < i$ (from $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{s_{i-1}}$, with sign -1), each carrying the factor 1 or q_{ab} according to whether the cover is classical or quantum. This is the asserted formula. □

6.2. **Covers and tight cycles.** The following classical count is the only fact about lengths that we shall use.

Lemma 6.2. *Let $v \in S_\infty$ and $a < b$. If $v(a) < v(b)$ then*

$$\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) + 1 + 2\,\#\{r \mid a < r < b,\ v(a) < v(r) < v(b)\},$$

and if $v(a) > v(b)$ then

$$\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) - 1 - 2\,\#\{r \mid a < r < b,\ v(b) < v(r) < v(a)\}.$$

In particular $\ell(vt_{ab}) \geq \ell(v) + 1$ if $v(a) < v(b)$, and $\ell(vt_{ab}) \geq \ell(v) - (2(b-a) - 1)$ always.

Proof. Passing from v to vt_{ab} changes the inversion status of the pair of positions (a, b), and of the pairs (a, r), (r, b) with $a < r < b$ exactly when $v(r)$ lies strictly between $v(a)$ and $v(b)$ (in which case both pairs change); all other pairs are unaffected. □

Definition 6.3 (Covers, $\lhd$, κ)**.** For $v \in S_\infty$ and $a < b$ we write $v \lhd vt_{ab}$, and say that t_{ab} is a *cover* of v, if either $\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) + 1$ (a *classical* cover) or $\ell(vt_{ab}) = \ell(v) - 2(b-a) + 1$ (a *quantum* cover). We set $\kappa(v, t_{ab}) = 1$ in the first case and $\kappa(v, t_{ab}) = q_{ab}$ in the second. By Lemma 6.2, t_{ab} is a classical cover of v if and only if $v(a) < v(b)$ and no r with $a < r < b$ satisfies $v(a) < v(r) < v(b)$, and a quantum cover if and only if $v(a) > v(b)$ and every r with $a < r < b$ satisfies $v(b) < v(r) < v(a)$. These are the covers of the quantum Bruhat graph, and condition (4) of Definition 3.1 says precisely that each step of a witnessing sequence is a cover (Remark 2.2).

It is convenient to separate the two values being exchanged from the values lying between them. For distinct numbers $\alpha \neq \beta$ and a finite set J of numbers not containing α, β, say that the pair (α, β) is J-*admissible* if either $\alpha < \beta$ and $J \cap (\alpha, \beta) = \emptyset$, or $\alpha > \beta$ and $J \subseteq (\beta, \alpha)$. Thus t_{ab} is a cover of v if and only if $(v(a), v(b))$ is J-admissible for $J = \{v(r) \mid a < r < b\}$; the cover is classical when $\alpha < \beta$ and quantum when $\alpha > \beta$.

Lemma 6.4. *Let α, β, γ be distinct numbers and I, J, J' finite sets of numbers avoiding them.*

(i) *(α, β) is $(J \cup J')$-admissible if and only if it is J-admissible and J'-admissible. In particular $J' \subseteq J$ and J-admissibility imply J'-admissibility.*
(ii) *(Composition.) If $(\alpha_1, \alpha_0), (\alpha_2, \alpha_1), \ldots, (\alpha_n, \alpha_{n-1})$ are I-admissible then so is (α_n, α_0).*
(iii) *(Triangle.) If (γ, β) is I-admissible and (α, γ) is $(J \cup \{\beta\} \cup I)$-admissible, then (α, β) is I-admissible and (α, γ) is J-admissible.*

Proof. (i) is immediate from the definition. For (ii), if $I = \emptyset$ there is nothing to prove. Otherwise I cuts the complement of I into intervals ("blocks"), among them $V_- = (-\infty, \min I)$ and $V_+ = (\max I, \infty)$. An I-admissible pair (α', α) with $\alpha' < \alpha$ has α, α' in the same block, and one with $\alpha' > \alpha$ has $\alpha \in V_-$ and $\alpha' \in V_+$. Hence along the chain the values descend within a block, except for at most one jump from V_- to V_+, after which they remain in V_+. Either $\alpha_n < \alpha_0$ lie in a common block, or $\alpha_0 \in V_-$ and $\alpha_n \in V_+$; in both cases (α_n, α_0) is I-admissible. For (iii), the second assertion is (i). For the first there are four cases. If $\gamma < \beta$ and $\alpha < \gamma$: then $\alpha < \beta$ and $I \cap (\alpha, \beta) \subseteq (I \cap (\alpha, \gamma)) \cup (I \cap [\gamma, \beta)) = \emptyset$. If $\gamma < \beta$ and $\alpha > \gamma$: then $\beta \in (\gamma, \alpha)$ gives $\beta < \alpha$, and $I \subseteq (\gamma, \alpha)$ together with $I \cap (\gamma, \beta) = \emptyset$ gives $I \subseteq (\beta, \alpha)$. If $\gamma > \beta$ and $\alpha < \gamma$: then $\beta \notin (\alpha, \gamma)$ forces $\beta < \alpha$, and $I \subseteq (\beta, \gamma)$ with $I \cap (\alpha, \gamma) = \emptyset$ gives $I \subseteq (\beta, \alpha)$. The case $\gamma > \beta$, $\alpha > \gamma$ cannot occur, since it would require $\beta \in (\gamma, \alpha)$. □

Definition 6.5 (Descents of a cycle, $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$)**.** Let c be a cycle and suppose $u \in S_\infty$. Write c as

$$(a_1, \ldots, a_n)$$

where $a_n > a_i$ for all $i < n$ (this is a unique way to express the cycle since the a_j are distinct). Then for any i with $1 \le i < n$ we say that a_i is a *descent* of c with respect to u if $u(a_i) > u(a_{i+1})$. We denote the set of all descents of c with respect to u by $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$.

In the notation $c = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, b)$ of (6.1), with $a_0 := b$, we have $a_j \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ if and only if $u(a_j) > u(a_{j-1})$; the top b is never a descent.

Definition 6.6 ($L_u(\sigma)$, $\mathbf{q}_u(\sigma)$, m-shaped, u-tight)**.** Let $u, \sigma \in S_\infty$ and let $c_1, \ldots, c_n$ be the nontrivial cycles of σ, with $c_i = (a_{i,p_i}, \ldots, a_{i,1}, b_i)$ and $b_i = \max c_i$. Put

$$L_u(\sigma) = \sum_{i=1}^{n} \Big(p_i - 2 \sum_{a \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)} (b_i - a) \Big), \qquad \mathbf{q}_u(\sigma) = \prod_{i=1}^{n} \prod_{a \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)} q_{ab_i}.$$

Both depend only on the restriction of u to $\mathrm{supp}(\sigma)$, and $\deg \mathbf{q}_u(\sigma) = \sum_i p_i - L_u(\sigma)$. We say that σ is *m-shaped* if every nontrivial cycle of σ contains exactly one element greater than m, and that σ is *u-tight* if

$$\ell(u\sigma) - \ell(u) = L_u(\sigma).$$

A *pivot chain* of σ is a sequence $t_1, \ldots, t_N$ ($N = \sum_i p_i$) of transpositions obtained by interleaving the pivot factorizations (6.1) of $c_1, \ldots, c_n$ in any manner that preserves the order of the factors within each cycle; since the cycles are disjoint, $t_1 \cdots t_N = \sigma$.

Lemma 6.7 (Tightness)**.** *Let $u, \sigma \in S_\infty$, let $t_1, \ldots, t_N$ be a pivot chain of σ, and put $u_0 = u$, $u_j = u_{j-1} t_j$.*

(i) *If $t_j = t_{a_{i,l} b_i}$ then $u_{j-1}(a_{i,l}) = u(a_{i,l})$ and $u_{j-1}(b_i) = u(a_{i,l-1})$ (with $a_{i,0} = b_i$). Thus the j-th step exchanges the values $u(a_{i,l})$ and $u(a_{i,l-1})$, and $a_{i,l} \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$ exactly when the larger of the two sits at the larger position b_i before the step.*
(ii) *$\ell(u\sigma) - \ell(u) \ge L_u(\sigma)$.*
(iii) *σ is u-tight if and only if $u_{j-1} \lhd u_j$ for every j. In that case the j-th step is a classical cover if $a_{i,l} \notin \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$ and a quantum cover if $a_{i,l} \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$, and $\prod_j \kappa(u_{j-1}, t_j) = \mathbf{q}_u(\sigma)$.*
(iv) *If $\sigma = \rho\tau$ where ρ and τ are the products of two complementary sets of cycles of σ, then σ is u-tight if and only if ρ is u-tight and τ is $u\rho$-tight. Moreover $L_u(\tau) = L_{u\rho}(\tau)$ and $\mathbf{q}_u(\tau) = \mathbf{q}_{u\rho}(\tau)$.*
(v) *If σ is u-tight then so is $t_1 \cdots t_j$ for every j, and u_j is obtained from u by a sequence of covers.*

Proof. (i) The position $a_{i,l}$ is moved only by the factor $t_{a_{i,l} b_i}$, so before that factor is applied it carries $u(a_{i,l})$; the position b_i is moved only by the factors of c_i, and after $t_{a_{i,l-1} b_i}$ it carries $u(a_{i,l-1})$ (and $u(b_i)$ before any factor of c_i). For (ii) and (iii), by (i) and Lemma 6.2 the j-th step increases the length by at least 1 if $a_{i,l} \notin \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$ and by at least $-(2(b_i - a_{i,l}) - 1)$ if $a_{i,l} \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)$; in both cases equality holds exactly when t_j is a cover of u_{j-1}, classical in the first case and quantum in the second (a step with $u_{j-1}(a_{i,l}) < u_{j-1}(b_i)$

increases the length and so cannot be a quantum cover, and symmetrically). Summing over j gives (ii), and shows that equality in (ii) holds exactly when every step is a cover; the product of the κ's is then the product of $q_{a_{i,l}b_i}$ over the descents, which is $\mathbf{q}_u(\sigma)$. For (iv), $\ell(u\rho\tau)-\ell(u) = (\ell(u\rho)-\ell(u)) + (\ell(u\rho\tau)-\ell(u\rho)) \geq L_u(\rho)+L_{u\rho}(\tau) = L_u(\rho)+L_u(\tau) = L_u(\sigma)$, where $L_{u\rho}(\tau) = L_u(\tau)$ because $u\rho$ and u agree on $\mathrm{supp}(\tau)$; equality holds if and only if both inequalities are equalities. (v) The partial product $t_1\cdots t_j$ is again a product of disjoint cycles of the form $(a_{i,l},\dots,a_{i,1},b_i)$ (a cycle of σ truncated after its first l factors), and $t_1,\dots,t_j$ is a pivot chain of it, all of whose steps are covers by (iii). □

With this language the cycle description of $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ becomes a statement in which the chain disappears entirely.

Lemma 6.8. *Suppose $u,w \in S_\infty$ and let $k \geq 0$ be an integer, and put $\pi = u^{-1}w$. Then $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if π is k-shaped and u-tight. In that case the pivot chain of π in which the cycles are taken in order of decreasing tops is a sequence $t_{a_1b_1},\dots,t_{a_pb_p}$ as in Definition 3.1, every pivot chain of π is a chain of covers, and*

$$q_k(u,w) = \mathbf{q}_u(\pi).$$

In particular $q_k(u,w)$ does not depend on the witnessing sequence, and $\ell(u,w)+\deg q_k(u,w)$ equals the sum of the lengths of the cycles of π, each diminished by one.

Proof. Suppose first that $t_{a_1b_1},\dots,t_{a_pb_p}$ satisfy conditions (1)–(5) of Definition 3.1. The b_i are weakly decreasing, so the factors sharing a common value b of b_i are consecutive, and by (6.1) their product $t_{a_ib}\cdots t_{a_{i+r}b}$ is the cycle $(a_{i+r},\dots,a_i,b)$, whose top is b because $a_l \leq k < b$. Cycles belonging to distinct values of b are disjoint, since the a_i are pairwise distinct and no a_i equals any b_j. Hence π is the product of these cycles, each of which contains exactly one element greater than k, namely its top: π is k-shaped. The given sequence is a pivot chain of π, and condition (4) says that each of its steps is a cover; so π is u-tight by Lemma 6.7(iii), and the recursive definition of $q_k(u,w)$ assigns to each step exactly the factor κ, whence $q_k(u,w) = \mathbf{q}_u(\pi)$.

Conversely, suppose π is k-shaped and u-tight. Order the nontrivial cycles of π by decreasing tops and take the corresponding pivot chain. The top of each cycle is its unique element exceeding k, so condition (1) holds; (2) holds because the cycles are disjoint and the a's within a cycle are distinct; (3) holds by the chosen order; (4) holds by Lemma 6.7(iii); and (5) is $t_1\cdots t_N = \pi$. The final assertion is $\deg \mathbf{q}_u(\pi) = \sum_i p_i - L_u(\pi)$. □

Corollary 6.9 (Cycle formula for the quantum weight)**.** *Suppose $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and write the nontrivial cycles in the decomposition of $u^{-1}w$ as $c_i = (a_{i,p_i},\dots,a_{i,1},b_i)$, as in Lemma 6.8. Then*

$$q_k(u,w) = \prod_i \prod_{a\in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i)} q_{ab_i}.$$

Equivalently, the exponent of q_r in $q_k(u,w)$ is

$$\#\{(i,a) : a \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c_i),\ a \leq r < b_i\}.$$

Moreover, $q_k(u,w)$ is multiplicative over the cycles of $u^{-1}w$, and the factor attached to a cycle depends only on the values of u on that cycle.

Proof. This is $q_k(u,w) = \mathbf{q}_u(\pi)$ together with $q_{ab} = q_a\cdots q_{b-1}$. □

We next show that a tight cycle is very constrained: the values of u along it, read cyclically, decrease except at exactly one place. For a cycle $c = (a_p,\dots,a_1,b)$ with top b and a permutation u we write

$$\beta_0 = u(b), \qquad \beta_j = u(a_j) \quad (1 \leq j \leq p),$$

so that $a_j \in \mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ if and only if $\beta_j > \beta_{j-1}$, and we put $u_j = u\,t_{a_1b}\cdots t_{a_jb}$. By Lemma 6.7(i), the j-th step of the pivot chain exchanges β_j (at a_j) with β_{j-1} (at b); moreover $u_m(a_l) = \beta_{l-1}$ for $l \leq m$ and $u_m(a_l) = \beta_l$ for $l > m$. If c is u-tight, Definition 6.3 gives, for every j and every position r with $a_j < r < b$:

$$\text{if } \beta_j < \beta_{j-1} \text{ (classical step): } u_{j-1}(r) \notin (\beta_j,\beta_{j-1}); \tag{6.2}$$

$$\text{if } \beta_j > \beta_{j-1} \text{ (quantum step): } u_{j-1}(r) \in (\beta_{j-1},\beta_j). \tag{6.3}$$

Lemma 6.10. *Let $c = (a_p,\dots,a_1,b)$ be a cycle with top b which is u-tight. Then $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ has at most one element. In particular this applies to every cycle of $u^{-1}w$ whenever $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$.*

Proof. Suppose $i < j$ are two descents (quantum steps) with no descent strictly between them, so that $\beta_i > \beta_{i-1}$, $\beta_j > \beta_{j-1}$ and $\beta_i > \beta_{i+1} > \cdots > \beta_{j-1}$.

If $a_j > a_i$, then (6.3) for the step i and $r = a_j$ gives $\beta_j = u_{i-1}(a_j) \in (\beta_{i-1}, \beta_i)$, so $\beta_{j-1} < \beta_j < \beta_i$. Hence $j \geq i+2$, and there is m with $i < m < j$ and $\beta_m < \beta_j < \beta_{m-1}$. The step m is classical. If $a_j > a_m$, then (6.2) for the step m and $r = a_j$ is violated by $u_{m-1}(a_j) = \beta_j$. So $a_m > a_j$, and then (6.3) for the step j and $r = a_m$ requires $u_{j-1}(a_m) = \beta_{m-1} \in (\beta_{j-1}, \beta_j)$, contradicting $\beta_{m-1} > \beta_j$.

If $a_j < a_i$, then (6.3) for the step j and $r = a_i$ gives $u_{j-1}(a_i) = \beta_{i-1} \in (\beta_{j-1}, \beta_j)$, so $\beta_{j-1} < \beta_{i-1} < \beta_i$. Hence again $j \geq i+2$ and there is m with $i < m < j$ and $\beta_m < \beta_{i-1} < \beta_{m-1}$. If $a_i > a_m$, (6.2) for the step m and $r = a_i$ is violated by $u_{m-1}(a_i) = \beta_{i-1}$. So $a_m > a_i$, and (6.3) for the step i and $r = a_m$ requires $u_{i-1}(a_m) = \beta_m \in (\beta_{i-1}, \beta_i)$, contradicting $\beta_m < \beta_{i-1}$. □

Definition 6.11 (Redefinition of $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$)**.** If c is a tight cycle, we redefine $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ to be the unique element of the previously defined set $\mathrm{desc}_u(c)$ if it exists, or otherwise 0.

Lemma 6.12. *Let $c = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, b)$ be a cycle with top b which is u-tight, and suppose $\mathrm{desc}_u(c) = a_q$ with $q \geq 1$. Then*

$$\beta_q > \beta_{q+1} > \cdots > \beta_p > \beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_{q-1}.$$

In particular $u(a_j) > u(b)$ for all $j \geq q$.

Proof. All steps other than the q-th are classical, which gives the two decreasing runs; it remains to prove $\beta_l > \beta_0$ for $l \geq q$.

First let $l = q$. For $l' < q$ with $a_{l'} < a_q$, (6.2) for the step l' and $r = a_q$ gives $\beta_q = u_{l'-1}(a_q) \notin (\beta_{l'}, \beta_{l'-1})$. If some $l' < q$ has $a_{l'} > a_q$, let l^* be the least such; then (6.3) for the step q and $r = a_{l^*}$ gives $u_{q-1}(a_{l^*}) = \beta_{l^*-1} \in (\beta_{q-1}, \beta_q)$, so $\beta_q > \beta_{l^*-1}$, and descending induction on $l' < l^*$ using $\beta_q \notin (\beta_{l'}, \beta_{l'-1})$ yields $\beta_q > \beta_{l'-1}$ for all $l' \leq l^*$, in particular $\beta_q > \beta_0$. If no such l' exists, the same induction starting from $\beta_q > \beta_{q-1}$ gives $\beta_q > \beta_0$.

Now let $l > q$ and assume $\beta_{l-1} > \beta_0$ (and $\beta_l < \beta_{l-1}$). Suppose, for a contradiction, that $\beta_l < \beta_0$. We claim that $a_{l'} < a_l$ and $\beta_l < \beta_{l'}$ for $1 \leq l' \leq q-1$. Indeed, assume $\beta_l < \beta_{l'-1}$ (true for $l' = 1$). If $a_{l'} > a_l$, then (6.2) for the step l and $r = a_{l'}$ requires $u_{l-1}(a_{l'}) = \beta_{l'-1} \notin (\beta_l, \beta_{l-1})$, which is false as $\beta_l < \beta_{l'-1} \leq \beta_0 < \beta_{l-1}$. So $a_{l'} < a_l$, and (6.2) for the step l' and $r = a_l$ gives $\beta_l \notin (\beta_{l'}, \beta_{l'-1})$, whence $\beta_l < \beta_{l'}$. The claim yields $\beta_l < \beta_{q-1}$. Finally consider the quantum step q: if $a_q < a_l$, (6.3) with $r = a_l$ requires $\beta_l \in (\beta_{q-1}, \beta_q)$, contradicting $\beta_l < \beta_{q-1}$; if $a_q > a_l$, (6.2) for the step l with $r = a_q$ requires $u_{l-1}(a_q) = \beta_{q-1} \notin (\beta_l, \beta_{l-1})$, contradicting $\beta_l < \beta_{q-1} < \beta_0 < \beta_{l-1}$. Hence $\beta_l > \beta_0$, and the induction is complete. □

Corollary 6.13 (Cyclic monotonicity)**.** *Let $c = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, b)$ be a u-tight cycle with top b. Then the cyclic sequence $(\beta_0, \beta_1, \ldots, \beta_p)$ has exactly one cyclic ascent: either $\beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_p$ (and $\mathrm{desc}_u(c) = 0$), or $\mathrm{desc}_u(c) = a_q$ with $q \geq 1$ and $\beta_q > \cdots > \beta_p > \beta_0 > \cdots > \beta_{q-1}$. Consequently*

$$L_u(c) = \begin{cases} p & \text{if the ascent is at the wrap } (\beta_p, \beta_0), \\ p - 2(b - a_q) & \text{if the ascent is } (\beta_{q-1}, \beta_q), \end{cases} \qquad \mathbf{q}_u(c) = \begin{cases} 1, \\ q_{a_q b}. \end{cases}$$

We shall repeatedly use the following elementary observation about such sequences. Call a cyclic sequence of distinct numbers *unimodal* if it has exactly one cyclic ascent, i.e. if it is a cyclic rotation of a decreasing sequence. Every cyclically consecutive block of a unimodal sequence is unimodal, and so is any subsequence. If Γ is unimodal and $\eta \notin \Gamma$, there is exactly one *gap* of Γ (a pair of cyclically consecutive entries) into which η can be inserted so that the result is again unimodal, namely: the descent gap (γ, γ') with $\gamma > \eta > \gamma'$ if $\min \Gamma < \eta < \max \Gamma$, and the ascent gap $(\min \Gamma, \max \Gamma)$ if $\eta < \min \Gamma$ or $\eta > \max \Gamma$. We call it the *insertion gap* of η in Γ.

6.3. **The position k.** We organize the inductive step of Theorem 3.4 around the position k. The following lemma records two facts about the interaction of $\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}$ and $\overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow}$ at position k.

Lemma 6.14. *Suppose $u, w \in S_\infty$ and let $k > 1$ be an integer.*

(i) *If $u(k) = w(k)$, then $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and in that case $q_k(u, w) = q_{k-1}(u, w)$ and $\mathrm{fix}_k(u, w) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, w) \cup \{u(k)\}$.*

(ii) *If $u(k) \neq w(k)$ and $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, then $u \overset{k-1}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$.*

Proof. Let $\pi = u^{-1}w$. If $u(k) = w(k)$ then k is a fixed point of π, so no nontrivial cycle of π contains k, and such a cycle has exactly one element greater than k if and only if it has exactly one element greater than $k-1$. Thus π is k-shaped if and only if it is $(k-1)$-shaped, while tightness and $\mathbf{q}_u(\pi)$ do not involve k at all; (i) follows from Lemma 6.8. For (ii), the cycle of π containing k is nontrivial and, π being k-shaped, contains an element greater than k; so it contains two elements greater than $k-1$ and π is not $(k-1)$-shaped. □

For the rest of this section we fix $u, w \in S_\infty$ and $k > 1$, and write

$$\pi = u^{-1}w, \qquad C = \text{the cycle of } \pi \text{ containing } k \ (C = \{k\} \text{ if } \pi(k) = k), \qquad B = \max C.$$

For $m \geq 0$ we set $c_m(u,w) = q_m(u,w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_m(u,w)}; z)$ if $u \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ and $c_m(u,w) = 0$ otherwise. The *Monk summands* at w are indexed by the reflections $t \in \{t_{ak} \mid a < k\} \cup \{t_{kb} \mid b > k\}$: writing $v = wt$ and $\sigma = u^{-1}v = \pi t$, the summand of t is

$$\mathrm{sign}(t)\, \kappa(v,t)\, c_{k-1}(u,v), \qquad \mathrm{sign}(t_{ak}) = -1,\ \mathrm{sign}(t_{kb}) = +1,$$

where the summand is understood to be 0 unless $v \lhd w$. (These are precisely the terms of (6.8) and (6.9) below.) The summand of t is therefore nonzero if and only if $v \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v$, that is, σ is $(k-1)$-shaped and u-tight.

Lemma 6.15 (Classification of the Monk neighbors)**.** *Suppose the Monk summand of t is nonzero, and let $P = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)$. Then every nontrivial cycle of π not meeting t has exactly one element greater than k, and exactly one of the following holds.*

(U) *$t = t_{kB}$ with $B > k$; C contains exactly two elements greater than $k-1$, namely k and B; and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P$. Writing $C = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, B)$ with $a_j = k$, the cycles of σ are those of π other than C together with*

$$C' = (a_{j-1}, \ldots, a_1, B) \quad \text{and} \quad C'' = (a_p, \ldots, a_{j+1}, k).$$

(S) *$t = t_{ak}$ with $a \in C$ and $B > k$; C contains exactly two elements greater than $k-1$, namely k and B; in the notation of (U), $a = a_m$ for some $m > j$; $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P$; and the cycles of σ are those of π other than C together with*

$$C'_m = (a_p, \ldots, a_{m+1}, a_m, a_{j-1}, \ldots, a_1, B) \quad \text{and} \quad C''_m = (a_{m-1}, \ldots, a_{j+1}, k).$$

(P) *$t = t_{ak}$ with $a \in C$ and $B = k$; writing $C = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, k)$ we have $a = a_p = \pi(k) = u^{-1}(w(k))$; $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P \sqcup \{w(k)\}$; and the cycles of σ are those of π other than C together with $C_- = (a_{p-1}, \ldots, a_1, k)$ (trivial if $p = 1$).*

(M) *$t = t_{ak}$ with $a \notin C$; then $B = k$, the cycle D of π containing a (possibly $D = \{a\}$) satisfies $D \subseteq [1, k-1]$, and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P \setminus \{u(a)\}$, which equals P unless $D = \{a\}$. The cycles of σ are those of π other than C and D together with the single cycle E with $\mathrm{supp}(E) = \mathrm{supp}(C) \cup \mathrm{supp}(D)$ obtained by setting $E(a) = \pi(k)$, $E(k) = \pi(a)$ and $E = \pi$ elsewhere.*

Proof. A cycle of π disjoint from $\mathrm{supp}(t)$ is a cycle of σ, hence has exactly one element greater than $k-1$, and since it does not contain k this element is greater than k. Recall that right multiplication of a permutation by a transposition t_{xy} merges the cycles of x and y if they are distinct, and otherwise splits their common cycle $(x_1, \ldots, x_n)$, $x = x_s$, $y = x_t$, $s < t$, into $(x_t, x_{s+1}, \ldots, x_{t-1})$ and $(x_s, x_{t+1}, \ldots, x_n, x_1, \ldots, x_{s-1})$.

Let $t = t_{kb}$. If $b \notin C$, the cycle of σ through k contains k and $b > k$, which is forbidden. So $b \in C$ and t splits C into a cycle through k and a cycle through b; each must contain exactly one element greater than $k-1$, so $C \cap (k-1, \infty) = \{k, b\}$ and $b = B$. The explicit form of the two cycles is the splitting formula applied to $(x_1, \ldots, x_{p+1}) = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, B)$ with $x_s = k$, $x_t = B$. Since v agrees with w at all positions less than k, $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P$. This is (U).

Let $t = t_{ak}$ with $a \in C$, so t splits C. If $B > k$, the piece not containing k must contain exactly one element greater than $k-1$, which forces $C \cap (k-1, \infty) = \{k, B\}$ and that piece to contain B. With $(x_1, \ldots, x_{p+1}) = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, B)$, $k = a_j$ and $a = a_m$: if $m < j$ the piece through a_m is $(a_m, a_{j-1}, \ldots, a_{m+1})$, which has no element greater than $k-1$ unless it is trivial ($m = j-1$), in which case the other piece $(k, a_{m-1}, \ldots, a_1, B, a_p, \ldots, a_{j+1})$ contains both k and B; both are forbidden. So $m > j$, and the splitting formula gives C'_m and C''_m. Here $v(a_m) = w(k) = u(a_{j-1}) \neq u(a_m)$ and $w(a_m) \neq u(a_m)$, so a_m is a fixed position neither for v nor for w, and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = P$. This is (S). If $B = k$, the piece not containing k has no element greater than $k-1$ and must be trivial, i.e. $\sigma(a) = a$, i.e. $\pi(k) = a$; in the notation $C = (a_p, \ldots, a_1, k)$

this is $a = a_p$, and $u(a_p) = u(\pi(k)) = w(k)$. Then σ has the cycle C_-, and $v(a_p) = w(k) = u(a_p)$ makes a_p a new fixed position with value $w(k) \notin P$. This is (P).

Finally let $t = t_{ak}$ with $a \notin C$, so t merges C with the cycle D of a into a cycle E containing k; E may contain no further element greater than $k-1$, so $C \subseteq [1,k]$, i.e. $B = k$, and $D \subseteq [1, k-1]$. We have $v(a) = w(k) = u(\pi(k)) \neq u(a)$ because $\pi(k) \in C \not\ni a$, so a is not a fixed position of v; it is one of w exactly when $D = \{a\}$. All other positions less than k agree. This is (M). □

The case $B > k$: the up-neighbor and the split down-neighbors.

Lemma 6.16 (Up/down pairing)**.** *Let $\psi \in S_\infty$, let $k < B$, let $z_1, \dots, z_s$ ($s \geq 0$) be distinct positions less than k, let $X = (z_s, \dots, z_1, k, B)$ and $w = \psi X$. Consider the following sequences of transpositions, each with product X:*

$$\begin{aligned} F_{\mathrm{std}}&: \ t_{kB},\, t_{z_1 B},\, \dots,\, t_{z_s B} && \text{(the pivot factorization of } X\text{)},\\ F_{\mathrm{up}}&: \ t_{z_1 k},\, \dots,\, t_{z_s k},\, t_{kB}, &&\\ F_m&: \ t_{z_1 k},\, \dots,\, t_{z_{m-1} k},\, t_{z_m B},\, \dots,\, t_{z_s B},\, t_{z_m k} && (1 \leq m \leq s). \end{aligned}$$

Call such a sequence a cover path *(from ψ) if each of its steps is a cover of the permutation reached before it, and define its* weight *to be the product of the κ's of its steps.*

(a) *If F_{std} is a cover path, then F_{up} is a cover path of the same weight, and no F_m is a cover path.*
(b) *If F_{up} is a cover path but F_{std} is not, then exactly one F_m is a cover path, and its weight equals that of F_{up}.*
(c) *If some F_m is a cover path, then so is F_{up}.*

Proof. (The products are X: F_{up} is $(z_s, \dots, z_1, k)\, t_{kB}$, and F_m is $(z_{m-1}, \dots, z_1, k)\, (z_s, \dots, z_m, B)\, t_{z_m k}$; both send $k \mapsto B \mapsto z_s \mapsto \cdots \mapsto z_1 \mapsto k$.) If $s = 0$ then $F_{\mathrm{std}} = F_{\mathrm{up}}$ and there is nothing to prove, so let $s \geq 1$. Put

$$\beta = \psi(B), \qquad \zeta_0 = \psi(k), \qquad \zeta_i = \psi(z_i)\ (1 \leq i \leq s), \qquad I = \{\psi(r) \mid k < r < B\}.$$

The positions strictly between k and B are never moved, so I is the set of values found there at every stage of every path. Let $\phi_m = \psi t_{z_1 k} \cdots t_{z_{m-1} k}$ ($1 \leq m \leq s+1$); thus $\phi_m(k) = \zeta_{m-1}$, $\phi_m(z_i) = \zeta_{i-1}$ for $i < m$, $\phi_m(z_i) = \zeta_i$ for $i \geq m$, $\phi_m(B) = \beta$, and ϕ_m agrees with ψ elsewhere. Let $J_i = \{\phi_i(r) \mid z_i < r < k\}$. We introduce the predicates

$$\begin{aligned} U_i&: \ (\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1}) \text{ is } J_i\text{-admissible} && (1 \leq i \leq s),\\ T_i&: \ (\zeta_i, \beta) \text{ is } I\text{-admissible} && (0 \leq i \leq s),\\ A_i&: \ (\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1}) \text{ is } (J_i \cup \{\beta\} \cup I)\text{-admissible} && (1 \leq i \leq s). \end{aligned}$$

U_i says that the i-th step of F_{up} (from ϕ_i) is a cover, and T_s that its last step is; so F_{up} is a cover path if and only if $U_1, \dots, U_s, T_s$ hold. For $1 \leq m \leq s+1$ let $\mathcal{S}_m$ be the statement that $t_{kB}, t_{z_m B}, \dots, t_{z_s B}$ is a cover path from ϕ_m; thus F_{std} is a cover path if and only if $\mathcal{S}_1$, and $\mathcal{S}_{s+1} = T_s$. The first step of $\mathcal{S}_m$ exchanges ζ_{m-1} at k with β at B across I; the step $t_{z_i B}$ ($i \geq m$) exchanges ζ_i at z_i with ζ_{i-1} at B across the positions in (z_i, k), which carry the same values as in ϕ_i (the positions z_l, $l < i$, carry ζ_{l-1} and the others their ψ-values), the position k, which carries β, and the positions in (k, B). Hence

$$\mathcal{S}_m \iff T_{m-1} \wedge A_m \wedge \cdots \wedge A_s.$$

Let $\mathcal{D}_m$ ($1 \leq m \leq s$) be the statement that $t_{z_m B}, \dots, t_{z_s B}, t_{z_m k}$ is a cover path from ϕ_m; then F_m is a cover path if and only if $U_1, \dots, U_{m-1}$ and $\mathcal{D}_m$ hold. The steps of $\mathcal{D}_m$ are: $D^{(m)}$, exchanging ζ_m at z_m with β at B across $J_m \cup \{\zeta_{m-1}\} \cup I$ (the position k now carries ζ_{m-1}); for $i > m$, $D^{(i)}$, exchanging ζ_i with ζ_{i-1} across $J_i^* \cup I$, where J_i^* consists of the values at the positions of $(z_i, k]$, so that $J_i^* = J_i \cup \{\beta\}$ if $z_m > z_i$ and $J_i^* = J_i \cup \{\zeta_{m-1}\}$ if $z_m < z_i$ (the position z_m carries β and k carries ζ_{m-1}); and D^{last}, exchanging β at z_m with ζ_{m-1} at k across $J^{**} = N_m \cup \{\zeta_{l-1} \mid l > m,\ z_l > z_m\}$, where N_m denotes the set of values carried by the positions of (z_m, k) other than $z_{m+1}, \dots, z_s$ (these values are the same in ϕ_m and at the end of $\mathcal{D}_m$), so that $J_m = N_m \cup \{\zeta_l \mid l > m,\ z_l > z_m\}$. For $i > m$ the set across which $D^{(i)}$ is taken contains J_i, and the sets of $D^{(m)}, \dots, D^{(s)}$ all contain ζ_{m-1}, the value at k.

Step 1: $\mathcal{S}_m \Rightarrow \mathcal{S}_{m+1}$, and $\mathcal{S}_m$ implies $U_m, \dots, U_s, T_s$. By Lemma 6.4(iii) applied with $(\alpha, \gamma, \beta) = (\zeta_m, \zeta_{m-1}, \beta)$ and $J = J_m$, the conjunction $T_{m-1} \wedge A_m$ implies $T_m \wedge U_m$. The first claim follows, and

the second by iterating it down to $\mathcal{S}_{s+1} = T_s$, using $A_i \Rightarrow U_i$ (Lemma 6.4(i)). In particular $\mathcal{S}_1$ implies that F_{up} is a cover path.

Step 2: $\mathcal{D}_m$ implies $U_m, \dots, U_s, T_s$. For $i > m$, $D^{(i)}$ gives U_i by Lemma 6.4(i). By the same lemma, $D^{(m)}$ and $D^{(i)}$ ($i > m$) give that (ζ_m, β) and (ζ_i, ζ_{i-1}) are I-admissible, so (ζ_s, β) is I-admissible by Lemma 6.4(ii): this is T_s. Likewise the pairs $(\zeta_m, \beta), (\zeta_{m+1}, \zeta_m), \dots, (\zeta_s, \zeta_{s-1})$ are $\{\zeta_{m-1}\}$-admissible, which as in the proof of Lemma 6.4(ii) means:

(6.4) the values $\beta, \zeta_m, \zeta_{m+1}, \dots, \zeta_s$ decrease on each side of ζ_{m-1}, with at most one jump from below ζ_{m-1} to above it.

For U_m, admissibility of (ζ_m, β) with respect to $\{\zeta_{m-1}\}$ leaves three possibilities: (1) $\zeta_{m-1} > \beta > \zeta_m$; (2) $\zeta_m > \zeta_{m-1} > \beta$; (3) $\beta > \zeta_m > \zeta_{m-1}$. We use $D^{(m)}$ restricted to J_m and D^{last} restricted to N_m, and treat the remaining elements ζ_l ($l > m$, $z_l > z_m$) of J_m by (6.4). In case (1), $J_m \cap (\zeta_m, \beta) = \emptyset$ and $N_m \cap (\beta, \zeta_{m-1}) = \emptyset$, while by (6.4) each ζ_l ($l > m$) is either less than ζ_m or greater than ζ_{m-1}; hence $J_m \cap (\zeta_m, \zeta_{m-1}) = \emptyset$. In case (2), $J_m \subseteq (\beta, \zeta_m)$ and $N_m \cap (\beta, \zeta_{m-1}) = \emptyset$ give $N_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$, while by (6.4) the jump occurs at (β, ζ_m) and so $\zeta_{m-1} < \zeta_l < \zeta_m$ for $l > m$; hence $J_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$. In case (3), $J_m \cap (\zeta_m, \beta) = \emptyset$ and $N_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \beta)$ give $N_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$, while by (6.4) all of $\beta, \zeta_m, \dots, \zeta_s$ lie above ζ_{m-1} and decrease, so again $\zeta_{m-1} < \zeta_l < \zeta_m$ for $l > m$; hence $J_m \subseteq (\zeta_{m-1}, \zeta_m)$. In each case this is U_m. Together with the prefix $U_1, \dots, U_{m-1}$ this proves (c).

For the remainder assume that F_{up} is a cover path. Then the cycle $(z_s, \dots, z_1, k)$ is ψ-tight, so by Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence $\Gamma = (\zeta_0, \zeta_1, \dots, \zeta_s)$ is unimodal; let $\delta \in \{0, \dots, s\}$ be the index of its ascent ($\zeta_\delta > \zeta_{\delta-1}$ if $\delta \geq 1$; $\delta = 0$ means the ascent is the wrap (ζ_s, ζ_0)), and let $g \in \{0, \dots, s\}$ be the insertion gap of β in Γ, where gap $g \geq 1$ is the gap (ζ_{g-1}, ζ_g) and gap 0 is the wrap. Explicitly: if $\min\Gamma < \beta < \max\Gamma$, then g is determined by $\zeta_{g-1} > \beta > \zeta_g$ (indices modulo $s+1$); otherwise $g = \delta$.

Step 3: $\mathcal{S}_m$ implies $m > g$. $\mathcal{S}_m$ says that the cycle $(z_s, \dots, z_m, k, B)$ is ϕ_m-tight, so by Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence $(\beta, \zeta_{m-1}, \dots, \zeta_s)$ is unimodal; that is, the wrap gap (ζ_s, ζ_{m-1}) of the block $\Gamma' = (\zeta_{m-1}, \dots, \zeta_s)$ is the insertion gap of β in Γ'. Suppose $1 \leq m \leq g$. Then ζ_{g-1}, ζ_g both lie in Γ' and are consecutive there. If $\min\Gamma < \beta < \max\Gamma$ then $\zeta_{g-1} > \beta > \zeta_g$, so the insertion gap of β in Γ' is (ζ_{g-1}, ζ_g), which is not the wrap gap of Γ' since $g - 1 \neq s$. If β lies outside $[\min\Gamma, \max\Gamma]$ then $g = \delta$, so $\zeta_g = \max\Gamma$ and $\zeta_{g-1} = \min\Gamma$ lie in Γ', whence β lies outside the range of Γ' and its insertion gap in Γ' is the ascent gap (ζ_{g-1}, ζ_g) of Γ', again not the wrap gap. In both cases $\mathcal{S}_m$ fails.

Step 4: $\mathcal{S}_{g+1}$ holds; hence $\mathcal{S}_m$ holds if and only if $m > g$. We must verify T_g and A_i for $i > g$; by Lemma 6.4(i) we treat the sets J_i, $\{\beta\}$ and I separately. Admissibility of (ζ_i, ζ_{i-1}) with respect to J_i is U_i. With respect to $\{\beta\}$: if $i > g$ and $i \neq \delta$, the gap (ζ_{i-1}, ζ_i) is a descent gap and $\beta \notin (\zeta_i, \zeta_{i-1})$, for otherwise it would be the insertion gap of β; if $i = \delta > g$, then $\beta \in (\min\Gamma, \max\Gamma) = (\zeta_{\delta-1}, \zeta_\delta)$, for otherwise $g = \delta$. With respect to I, and for T_g: the sequence $s_0 = \beta, s_1 = \zeta_g, \dots, s_n = \zeta_s$ is a consecutive block of the unimodal sequence obtained by inserting β into Γ, hence unimodal, and T_s says that (s_n, s_0) is I-admissible. If $s_0 > s_1 > \cdots > s_n$, then T_s is classical, $I \cap (s_n, s_0) = \emptyset$, and every pair (s_i, s_{i-1}) is I-admissible. Otherwise the linear ascent is at some $j \geq 1$, so $s_j > \cdots > s_n > s_0 > \cdots > s_{j-1}$; then T_s is quantum, $I \subseteq (s_0, s_n)$, and the pairs (s_i, s_{i-1}) with $i < j$ lie below s_0, the pair (s_j, s_{j-1}) has $I \subseteq (s_0, s_n) \subseteq (s_{j-1}, s_j)$, and the pairs with $i > j$ lie above s_n; all are I-admissible. The pairs (s_i, s_{i-1}) are exactly (ζ_g, β) and (ζ_i, ζ_{i-1}), $i > g$. This proves $\mathcal{S}_{g+1}$, and the second assertion follows from Steps 1 and 3.

Step 5: $\mathcal{D}_m$ implies $m = g$. Restricting $D^{(m)}$ to $\{\zeta_{m-1}\}$ leaves the three cases (1)–(3) of Step 2. In case (1) the gap (ζ_{m-1}, ζ_m) is a descent gap containing β, so $g = m$. In case (2) the gap is the ascent gap, $m = \delta$, and $\beta < \zeta_{m-1} = \min\Gamma$, so $g = \delta = m$. In case (3), $m = \delta$ and $\beta > \zeta_m = \max\Gamma$, so again $g = m$.

Step 6: if $g \geq 1$ then $\mathcal{D}_g$ holds. Write $a = z_g$. We are in one of the cases (1) $\zeta_{g-1} > \beta > \zeta_g$ ($g \neq \delta$), (2) $g = \delta$ and $\beta < \zeta_{g-1} = \min\Gamma$, (3) $g = \delta$ and $\beta > \zeta_g = \max\Gamma$. For $D^{(g)}$: admissibility of (ζ_g, β) with respect to I is T_g (Step 4); with respect to $\{\zeta_{g-1}\}$ it holds in each of the three cases by inspection; with respect to J_g it follows from U_g: in case (1), $J_g \cap (\zeta_g, \zeta_{g-1}) = \emptyset$ gives $J_g \cap (\zeta_g, \beta) = \emptyset$; in case (2), $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g) \subseteq (\beta, \zeta_g)$; in case (3), $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g)$ is disjoint from (ζ_g, β). For $D^{(i)}$, $i > g$: if $z_g > z_i$ the required statement is A_i (Step 4); if $z_g < z_i$ then $z_g \in (z_i, k)$, so $\zeta_{g-1} = \phi_i(z_g) \in J_i$ already, $J_i^* = J_i$, and the statement follows from U_i and the I-admissibility established in Step 4. For D^{last}, the pair (β, ζ_{g-1}) must be admissible with respect to $N_g \subseteq J_g$ and to the values ζ_{l-1}, $l > g$, $z_l > z_g$: in case (1) it is classical, and $(\beta, \zeta_{g-1}) \subseteq (\zeta_g, \zeta_{g-1})$ contains no element of J_g (by U_g) and no ζ_l (as ζ_{g-1}, ζ_g are consecutive in the decreasing order of Γ); in case

(2) it is classical, and (β, ζ_{g-1}) lies below $\min\Gamma$ and below $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g)$; in case (3) it is quantum, and $J_g \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g) \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \beta)$ while every ζ_{l-1} with $l > g$ lies in $(\zeta_{g-1}, \zeta_g] \subseteq (\zeta_{g-1}, \beta)$.

Step 7: weights. Suppose F_{up} is a cover path and $g \geq 1$. The two paths F_{up} and F_g share the prefix $t_{z_1 k}, \dots, t_{z_{g-1} k}$; after it, the quantum steps of F_{up} are $t_{z_\delta k}$ (if $\delta \geq g$) and t_{kB} (if $\zeta_s > \beta$), while those of F_g are $t_{z_g B}$ (if $\zeta_g > \beta$), $t_{z_\delta B}$ (if $\delta > g$) and $t_{z_g k}$ (if $\beta > \zeta_{g-1}$). In case (1) with $\delta > g$ we have $\zeta_s > \zeta_0 \geq \zeta_{g-1} > \beta$, and both weights are $q_{z_\delta k} q_{kB} = q_{z_\delta B}$; in case (1) with $\delta < g$ we have $\zeta_s < \zeta_g < \beta$ and both weights are 1; in case (2) both are $q_{z_g k} q_{kB} = q_{z_g B}$; in case (3) both are $q_{z_g k}$. If instead $g = 0$, so that $\mathcal{S}_1$ holds, the quantum steps of F_{std} are t_{kB} (if $\zeta_0 > \beta$) and $t_{z_\delta B}$ (if $\delta \geq 1$); if $\zeta_s > \beta > \zeta_0$ (so $\delta \geq 1$) both F_{std} and F_{up} have weight $q_{z_\delta B}$; if $\beta < \min\Gamma$ (so $\delta = 0$) both have weight q_{kB}; and if $\beta > \max\Gamma$ both have weight 1.

Conclusion. (a): $\mathcal{S}_1$ gives F_{up} (Step 1) with the same weight (Step 7), and $g = 0$ (Step 3), so no $\mathcal{D}_m$ holds (Step 5). (b): if F_{up} is a cover path and $\mathcal{S}_1$ fails, then $g \geq 1$ (Step 4), $\mathcal{D}_g$ holds (Step 6) and no other $\mathcal{D}_m$ does (Step 5); as $U_1, \dots, U_{g-1}$ hold, F_g is the unique F_m which is a cover path, and its weight is that of F_{up} (Step 7). (c) is Step 2. □

Lemma 6.17. *Suppose $u, w \in S_\infty$ and let $k > 1$ be an integer. If $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ but $u \not\overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, then there is a unique $b > k$ such that $wt_{kb} \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{kb}$, namely $b = B$. Furthermore, in that case there does not exist an $a < k$ such that $wt_{ak} \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{ak}$, and*

$$\kappa(wt_{kB}, t_{kB})\, q_{k-1}(u, wt_{kB}) = q_k(u, w), \qquad \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, wt_{kB}) = \mathrm{fix}_k(u, w).$$

Proof. By Lemma 6.8, π is k-shaped and u-tight but not $(k-1)$-shaped, so $u(k) \neq w(k)$ and $B > k$ (Lemma 6.14). Write $C = (a_p, \dots, a_1, B)$ with $a_j = k$, let ρ be the product of the other nontrivial cycles of π, let $C' = (a_{j-1}, \dots, a_1, B)$, and put $\psi = u\rho C'$ and $X = (a_p, \dots, a_{j+1}, k, B)$, so that $w = \psi X$ and X has the form of Lemma 6.16 with $s = p - j$ and $z_i = a_{j+i}$. Take the pivot chain of π consisting of the pivot factorization of ρ, then that of C; by Lemma 6.7(iii),(v) all its steps are covers, ρ is u-tight, C' is $u\rho$-tight (it is C truncated after $j-1$ factors), and F_{std} is a cover path from ψ. By Lemma 6.16(a), F_{up} is a cover path of the same weight. Its first s steps form the pivot factorization of $C'' = (a_p, \dots, a_{j+1}, k)$, so $\rho C' C'' = u^{-1} w t_{kB}$ is u-tight by Lemma 6.7(iii),(iv); it is $(k-1)$-shaped, its cycles being those of ρ (each with exactly one element greater than k), C' (top B, other elements less than k) and C'' (top k, other elements less than k). Hence $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{kB}$, and the last step of F_{up} says $wt_{kB} \lhd w$. Uniqueness of b is Lemma 6.15(U). The weights are $\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C')$ times the weights of F_{std}, respectively F_{up}, which agree; and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, wt_{kB}) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, w) = \mathrm{fix}_k(u, w)$ since $u(k) \neq w(k)$.

Suppose finally that $a < k$ satisfies $wt_{ak} \lhd w$ and $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{ak}$. By Lemma 6.15 we are in case (S): $a = a_m$ with $m > j$, and $\sigma = \rho C'_m C''_m$ is u-tight. Taking the pivot chain of σ in the order: factors of ρ, the first $j-1$ factors of C'_m (which are those of C'), the factors of C''_m, the remaining factors $t_{a_m B}, \dots, t_{a_p B}$ of C'_m, and appending the cover $t_{a_m k}$, we obtain that F_{m-j} is a cover path from ψ, contradicting Lemma 6.16(a). □

The case $B = k$: the peel and the merges.

Lemma 6.18 (Peel)**.** *Let $\omega \in S_\infty$ and let $C = (a_p, \dots, a_1, k)$ ($p \geq 1$) be a cycle with top k; put $w = \omega C$, $C_- = (a_{p-1}, \dots, a_1, k)$ and $v = wt_{a_p k} = \omega C_-$. Then C is ω-tight if and only if C_- is ω-tight and $v \lhd w$, and in that case $\kappa(v, t_{a_p k})\, \mathbf{q}_\omega(C_-) = \mathbf{q}_\omega(C)$.*

Proof. The pivot factorization of C is that of C_- followed by $t_{a_p k}$, and $\omega C_- = v$. Apply Lemma 6.7(iii). □

Lemma 6.19 (Merge)**.** *Let $\omega \in S_\infty$, $k > 1$, $\eta = \omega(k)$, and let D be a cycle with $\mathrm{supp}(D) \subseteq [1, k-1]$, allowing D to be trivial, $D = \{a\}$ with $a \leq k-1$. Put $w = \omega D$, so $w(k) = \eta$. For $a \in \mathrm{supp}(D)$ let $\tau_a = D t_{ak}$, the cycle with support $\mathrm{supp}(D) \cup \{k\}$ sending $a \mapsto k \mapsto D(a)$, and $v_a = wt_{ak} = \omega\tau_a$. Then:*

- (a) *there is at most one $a \in \mathrm{supp}(D)$ such that τ_a is ω-tight and $v_a \lhd w$;*
- (b) *such an a exists if and only if D is ω-tight and $\max\mathrm{supp}(D) = k-1$ (for trivial $D = \{a\}$: if and only if $a = k-1$);*
- (c) *for this a, $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak})\, \mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a) = q_{k-1}\, \mathbf{q}_\omega(D)$.*

Proof. Trivial $D = \{a\}$. Then $w = \omega$, $\tau_a = t_{ak}$, and τ_a is ω-tight if and only if $w \lhd wt_{ak}$. If also $wt_{ak} \lhd w$, then both $\ell(wt_{ak}) - \ell(w)$ and its negative lie in $\{1, 1-2(k-a)\}$, which forces $k - a = 1$. Conversely for $a = k-1$ the transposition $t_{k-1,k}$ changes the length by ± 1, so both relations hold, one classical and one quantum with $\kappa = q_{k-1}$; thus $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak})\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a) = q_{k-1} = q_{k-1}\mathbf{q}_\omega(D)$.

Nontrivial $D = (d_r, \dots, d_1, d)$, $r \geq 1$, $d = \max \operatorname{supp}(D)$. Put $d_0 = d$, $\gamma_0 = \omega(d)$, $\gamma_i = \omega(d_i)$ and $\epsilon = k - d \geq 1$. For $a = d_m$ $(0 \leq m \leq r)$ the cycle $\tau_m := \tau_{d_m}$ is

$$\tau_m = (d_{m-1}, \dots, d_1, d, d_r, \dots, d_m, k),$$

whose pivot factorization

$$t_{d_m k}\, t_{d_{m+1} k} \cdots t_{d_r k}\, t_{dk}\, t_{d_1 k} \cdots t_{d_{m-1} k}$$

exchanges, in order, the values $\eta, \gamma_m, \gamma_{m+1}, \dots, \gamma_r, \gamma_0, \gamma_1, \dots, \gamma_{m-1}$: the sequence of values of τ_m in the sense of Corollary 6.13 is the cyclic sequence $\Gamma = (\gamma_0, \dots, \gamma_r)$ of D with η inserted into the gap (γ_{m-1}, γ_m) (the wrap gap (γ_r, γ_0) when $m = 0$). Note $w(d_m) = \gamma_{m-1}$ for $m \geq 1$ and $w(d) = \gamma_r$; we write $w(a)$ for the value at $a = d_m$ in either case.

Necessity. Suppose τ_m is ω-tight and $v_m := v_{d_m} \lhd w$. By Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence of τ_m is unimodal; deleting η shows that Γ is unimodal, and then m must be the insertion gap of η in Γ. This already proves (a). Let δ be the ascent index of Γ ($\gamma_\delta > \gamma_{\delta-1}$, or $\delta = 0$ for the wrap), so that by Corollary 6.13 and Definition 6.6

$$L_\omega(D) = r - 2(d - d_\delta), \qquad \mathbf{q}_\omega(D) = q_{d_\delta d}$$

(read as r and 1 when $\delta = 0$). Now compare lengths. Tightness gives $\ell(v_m) - \ell(\omega) = L_\omega(\tau_m)$, Lemma 6.7(ii) gives $\ell(w) - \ell(\omega) \geq L_\omega(D)$ with equality if and only if D is ω-tight, and $v_m \lhd w$ gives $\ell(v_m) - \ell(w) = -1$ if $w(a) > \eta$ and $\ell(v_m) - \ell(w) = 2(k-a) - 1$ if $w(a) < \eta$. Hence

$$L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) \;\geq\; \begin{cases} -1 & \text{if } w(a) > \eta, \\ 2(k-a) - 1 & \text{if } w(a) < \eta, \end{cases} \tag{6.5}$$

with equality if and only if D is ω-tight. We compute the left side from Corollary 6.13 in the three possible configurations of the insertion gap.

(I) $\min \Gamma < \eta < \max \Gamma$, so $\gamma_{m-1} > \eta > \gamma_m$ and $m \neq \delta$. The ascent of the sequence of τ_m is the (interior) step onto γ_δ, whose position is d_δ, so $L_\omega(\tau_m) = (r+1) - 2(k - d_\delta)$ and $L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) = 1 - 2\epsilon$. Here $w(a) = \gamma_{m-1} > \eta$, so (6.5) reads $1 - 2\epsilon \geq -1$, forcing $\epsilon = 1$ and equality.

(II) $\eta < \min \Gamma$, so $m = \delta$. The ascent of the sequence of τ_m is its first step (η, γ_δ), at position d_δ; again $L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) = 1 - 2\epsilon$, and $w(a) = \gamma_{\delta-1} > \eta$ forces $\epsilon = 1$ and equality.

(III) $\eta > \max \Gamma$, so $m = \delta$. The sequence of τ_m is decreasing, its ascent being the wrap, so $L_\omega(\tau_m) = r + 1$ and $L_\omega(\tau_m) - L_\omega(D) = 1 + 2(d - d_\delta)$. Here $w(a) = \gamma_{\delta-1} < \eta$, and (6.5) reads $1 + 2(d - d_\delta) \geq 2(k - d_\delta) - 1$, i.e. $\epsilon \leq 1$; so $\epsilon = 1$ and equality.

In every case $d = k - 1$ and D is ω-tight, proving the "only if" part of (b).

Sufficiency. Suppose D is ω-tight and $d = k - 1$; then Γ is unimodal (Corollary 6.13). Let m be the insertion gap of η and $a = d_m$. The computations above show that (6.5) holds with equality, and since $\ell(w) - \ell(\omega) = L_\omega(D)$, the tightness of τ_m is equivalent to $\ell(v_m) - \ell(w)$ taking the value -1 (if $w(a) > \eta$) or $2(k-a) - 1$ (if $w(a) < \eta$), i.e. to $v_m \lhd w$. It therefore suffices to show $w t_{ak} \lhd w$, that is, that $(w(a), \eta)$ is J-admissible for $J = \{w(r) \mid a < r < k\}$. The positions in (a, k) are: $d = k - 1$ (if $a \neq d$), carrying γ_r; the $d_l > a$, carrying γ_{l-1}; and positions outside $\operatorname{supp}(D)$, carrying their ω-values. If $a = d = k - 1$ the set J is empty and we are done; so assume $m \geq 1$.

(I) $\gamma_{m-1} > \eta > \gamma_m$: the pair $(w(a), \eta) = (\gamma_{m-1}, \eta)$ is classical and we need $J \cap (\eta, \gamma_{m-1}) = \emptyset$. No γ_l lies in (γ_m, γ_{m-1}), these being consecutive in the decreasing order of Γ. The m-th step of the pivot chain of D is classical, so by (6.2) every position $r \in (d_m, d)$ outside $\operatorname{supp}(D)$ has $\omega(r) \notin (\gamma_m, \gamma_{m-1})$.

(II) $m = \delta$, $\eta < \gamma_{\delta-1} = \min \Gamma$: the pair $(\gamma_{\delta-1}, \eta)$ is classical and we need $J \cap (\eta, \gamma_{\delta-1}) = \emptyset$; all $\gamma_l \geq \gamma_{\delta-1}$, and by (6.3) for the quantum step δ of D the positions $r \in (d_\delta, d)$ outside $\operatorname{supp}(D)$ have $\omega(r) \in (\gamma_{\delta-1}, \gamma_\delta)$.

(III) $m = \delta$, $\eta > \gamma_\delta = \max \Gamma$: the pair $(\gamma_{\delta-1}, \eta)$ is quantum and we need $J \subseteq (\gamma_{\delta-1}, \eta)$; the values γ_l occurring in J are different from $\gamma_{\delta-1}$ (which sits at a) and lie in $(\gamma_{\delta-1}, \gamma_\delta]$, and the remaining positions have $\omega(r) \in (\gamma_{\delta-1}, \gamma_\delta)$ by (6.3).

This proves the "if" part of (b).

Weights. In cases (I) and (II), $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak}) = 1$ and $\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_m) = q_{d_\delta k} = q_{d_\delta, k-1} q_{k-1} = \mathbf{q}_\omega(D) q_{k-1}$ (read $q_{dk} = q_{k-1}$ and $\mathbf{q}_\omega(D) = 1$ when $\delta = 0$). In case (III), $\kappa(v_a, t_{ak}) = q_{ak} = q_{d_\delta k}$ and $\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_m) = 1$, giving the same product. This is (c). $\square$

The cancellations. We now assemble the Monk summands. Throughout, ρ denotes the product of the nontrivial cycles of π other than C and other than the cycle D of π containing $k-1$ (we set $D=\{k-1\}$ if $k-1$ is fixed by π, and we do not single out D when $k-1\in C$). By Lemma 6.15, Lemma 6.8 and Lemma 6.7(iv), each of the quantities $c_{k-1}(u,w)$, $c_{k-2}(u,w)$, $c_k(u,w)$ and each Monk summand vanishes unless ρ is u-tight and each cycle of ρ contains exactly one element greater than k; indeed each requires ρ to be a tight product of cycles with exactly one element greater than k or than $k-1$ or than $k-2$, and these conditions agree for cycles containing neither k nor $k-1$. (For $c_{k-2}(u,w)$, note that $k-1$ lies in C or in D, hence not in a cycle of ρ.) *We assume this from now on*; otherwise all terms considered below are zero.

Lemma 6.20 (Reflection–drop cancellation)**.** *Suppose $u,w\in S_\infty$, let $k>1$, and suppose $u(k)=w(k)$. Then*

$$\sum_{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w}\operatorname{sign}(a-k)\,\kappa_{ak}\,c_{k-1}(u,wt_{ak})\ +\sum_{b>k,\ wt_{kb}\lhd w}\operatorname{sign}(b-k)\,\kappa_{kb}\,c_{k-1}(u,wt_{kb})\ +\ q_{k-1}\,c_{k-2}(u,w)=0,$$

where $\kappa_{rs}=\kappa(wt_{rs},t_{rs})$. In fact the two reflection sums contribute at most one nonzero summand in total: it occurs precisely when $u\overset{k-2}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ (equivalently, when the quantum term is nonzero), it is indexed by some $a<k$, and it equals $-q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w)$.

Proof. Here $C=\{k\}$, so by Lemma 6.15 only summands of type (M) can be nonzero: $t=t_{ak}$ with the π-cycle D_a of a contained in $[1,k-1]$. If D_a is nontrivial then it is not a cycle of ρ (those have an element greater than k), so $D_a=D$ and $\max D=k-1$; otherwise a is a fixed point of π. Let a be such a candidate and put $\omega_a=wD_a^{-1}$, so that $w=\omega_aD_a$, $\omega_a(k)=w(k)$, and $\omega_a=u\rho$ when $D_a=D$. Then $u^{-1}wt_{ak}=(\pi D_a^{-1})\,\tau_a$ with $\tau_a=D_at_{ak}$ as in Lemma 6.19, where πD_a^{-1} is the product of the cycles of π other than D_a; by Lemma 6.7(iv), $u^{-1}wt_{ak}$ is u-tight if and only if πD_a^{-1} is u-tight and τ_a is ω_a-tight. Now apply Lemma 6.19 to (ω_a,D_a). If a is a fixed point, the summand can be nonzero only for $a=k-1$, which requires $k-1$ to be fixed, i.e. $D=\{k-1\}$; in that case $\pi D_a^{-1}=\rho$ and the summand is nonzero. If $D_a=D$ is nontrivial, at most one $a\in D$ works, and one does if and only if D is $u\rho$-tight. Altogether at most one a gives a nonzero summand, and one exists if and only if either $D=\{k-1\}$, or D is nontrivial with $\max D=k-1$ and $u\rho$-tight. On the other hand $u\overset{k-2}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ if and only if $\pi=\rho D$ is $(k-2)$-shaped and u-tight, i.e. (given our standing assumption on ρ) if and only if D is trivial or has $k-1$ as its unique element greater than $k-2$, and D is $u\rho$-tight: the same condition. When it holds, with $v=wt_{ak}$ the unique contributing neighbor and $\omega=\omega_a=u\rho$, Lemma 6.19(c) and Lemma 6.8 give

$$\kappa_{ak}\,q_{k-1}(u,v)=\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\,\kappa_{ak}\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a)=\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\,q_{k-1}\mathbf{q}_\omega(D)=q_{k-1}\,q_{k-2}(u,w),$$

and Lemma 6.15(M) gives $\operatorname{fix}_{k-1}(u,v)=\operatorname{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)\setminus\{u(a)\}$, which equals $\operatorname{fix}_{k-2}(u,w)$: if $D=\{k-1\}$ then $a=k-1$ and we remove the fixed value $u(k-1)$; if D is nontrivial then neither a nor $k-1$ is a fixed position of w. Hence the summand is $-\kappa_{ak}c_{k-1}(u,v)=-q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w)$, cancelling the quantum term. If the condition fails, both the reflection sums and the quantum term vanish. □

Lemma 6.21 (Moved reflection cancellation)**.** *Let $u,w\in S_\infty$, let $k>1$, and suppose $u(k)\neq w(k)$, so that C is nontrivial.*

(a) *If $B>k$, then $c_{k-1}(u,w)=c_{k-2}(u,w)=0$, and the sum of the Monk summands equals $c_k(u,w)$. More precisely: if $u\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w$ the only nonzero Monk summand is that of t_{kB}, and it equals $c_k(u,w)$; if $u\overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow}w$, the nonzero Monk summands are either none or exactly two, one of type (U) and one of type (S), with equal absolute value and opposite signs.*

(b) *If $B=k$, then $c_k(u,w)=0$, no summand of type (U) occurs, and*

$$(y_{w(k)}-z_1)\,c_{k-1}(u,w)\ -\sum_{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w}\kappa_{ak}\,c_{k-1}(u,wt_{ak})\ +\ q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w)=0.$$

In fact the diagonal term cancels against the summand of type (P), and the quantum term against the (at most one) summand of type (M).

Proof. (a) C contains k and B, two elements greater than $k-1$, so π is neither $(k-1)$- nor $(k-2)$-shaped and $c_{k-1}(u,w)=c_{k-2}(u,w)=0$. By Lemma 6.15, a nonzero Monk summand is of type (U) or (S), and requires $C\cap(k-1,\infty)=\{k,B\}$; together with the standing assumption on ρ this means that π is k-shaped, which we may assume (otherwise all Monk summands vanish and $c_k(u,w)=0$). Write $C=(a_p,\dots,a_1,B)$

with $a_j = k$, $C' = (a_{j-1}, \dots, a_1, B)$, $\psi = u\rho C'$ and $X = (a_p, \dots, a_{j+1}, k, B)$, so that $w = \psi X$ as in Lemma 6.16 with $s = p - j$, $z_i = a_{j+i}$. If C' is not $u\rho$-tight then nothing is tight (Lemma 6.7(iv),(v): C' is a truncation of C and of each C'_m, and a cycle of $u^{-1}wt_{kB}$), all Monk summands vanish, and $c_k(u,w) = 0$. So assume C' is $u\rho$-tight. Then, exactly as in the proof of Lemma 6.17: $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if F_{std} is a cover path from ψ; the summand of type (U) is nonzero if and only if F_{up} is a cover path, and then equals $\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C')\,\mathrm{wt}(F_{\mathrm{up}})\,\mathbf{E}(y_P; z)$ with $P = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)$; and the summand of type (S) indexed by a_m $(m > j)$ is nonzero if and only if F_{m-j} is a cover path, and then equals $-\mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C')\,\mathrm{wt}(F_{m-j})\,\mathbf{E}(y_P; z)$ (Lemma 6.15(S) for the fixed set). If $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, Lemma 6.16(a) and Lemma 6.17 show that the only nonzero summand is that of t_{kB} and that it equals $q_k(u,w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}; z) = c_k(u,w)$. If $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$, Lemma 6.16(b),(c) show that either no summand is nonzero, or exactly two are, namely (U) and one (S), with equal weights; they cancel, and $c_k(u,w) = 0$.

(b) $C \subseteq [1,k]$ has no element greater than k, so π is not k-shaped and $c_k(u,w) = 0$; type (U) is excluded by Lemma 6.15. Write $C = (a_p, \dots, a_1, k)$. For the diagonal and peel terms, let $\omega_0 = u\rho D$ if $k-1 \notin C$ and $\omega_0 = u\rho$ if $k-1 \in C$ (where D is the cycle of $k-1$, trivial or not), so that $w = \omega_0 C$ and ω_0 agrees with u on $\mathrm{supp}(C)$. The diagonal term is nonzero if and only if π is $(k-1)$-shaped and tight, i.e. (given the standing assumption) D is trivial or has an element greater than k, D is $u\rho$-tight, and C is ω_0-tight (the conditions on D being vacuous when $k-1 \in C$). The summand of type (P) is nonzero if and only if $\rho D C_-$ is $(k-1)$-shaped and tight and $v = wt_{a_p k} \lhd w$, i.e. the same conditions on D together with: C_- is ω_0-tight and $v \lhd w$. By Lemma 6.18 these two sets of conditions are equivalent, and when they hold, $\kappa_{a_p k} q_{k-1}(u,v) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho D)\kappa_{a_p k}\mathbf{q}_{\omega_0}(C_-) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho D)\mathbf{q}_{\omega_0}(C) = q_{k-1}(u,w)$, while $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w) \sqcup \{w(k)\}$ by Lemma 6.15(P). Since $(y_{w(k)} - z_1)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)}; z) = \mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)\cup\{w(k)\}}; z)$, the diagonal term and the (negatively signed) summand of type (P) cancel.

For the merge and quantum terms, a summand of type (M) requires $a \notin C$ with the cycle D_a of a contained in $[1, k-1]$; as in the proof of Lemma 6.20, either a is fixed by π or $D_a = D$ with $\max D = k-1$ (in particular $k-1 \notin C$). If $k-1 \in C$, then $k-1$ is not fixed and no such D exists; since a fixed-point candidate must be $a = k-1$ by the trivial case of Lemma 6.19 (applied as below), there are no nonzero summands of type (M), and $c_{k-2}(u,w) = 0$ since C contains the two elements $k-1, k$ greater than $k-2$. So suppose $k-1 \notin C$. For a candidate a put $\omega_a = wD_a^{-1}$, so that $w = \omega_a D_a$ and $\omega_a(k) = w(k)$; then $u^{-1}wt_{ak} = \rho_a E$, where ρ_a is the product of the cycles of π other than C and D_a and $E = C\tau_a$ is the cycle of Lemma 6.15(M), $\tau_a = D_a t_{ak}$. The pivot factorization of E is that of C followed by that of τ_a, so by Lemma 6.7(iii),(iv), $u^{-1}wt_{ak}$ is u-tight if and only if ρ_a is u-tight, C is $u\rho_a$-tight and τ_a is ω_a-tight (note $u\rho_a C = \omega_a$), and then $\mathbf{q}_u(E) = \mathbf{q}_u(C)\mathbf{q}_{\omega_a}(\tau_a)$. By Lemma 6.19 applied to (ω_a, D_a): a fixed-point candidate contributes only if $a = k-1$, i.e. $D = \{k-1\}$; and if $D_a = D$ is nontrivial, at most one $a \in D$ contributes, and one does if and only if D is ω_a-tight, where now $\omega_a = u\rho C =: \omega$. Altogether at most one summand of type (M) is nonzero, and one is if and only if C is $u\rho$-tight and either $D = \{k-1\}$, or D is nontrivial with $\max D = k-1$ and ω-tight. This is exactly the condition for $u \overset{k-2}{\rightsquigarrow} w$: $\pi = \rho C D$ is $(k-2)$-shaped (as $k-1 \notin C$, C has the unique element k greater than $k-2$, and D the unique element $k-1$) and it is u-tight if and only if C is $u\rho$-tight and D is ω-tight. When it holds, Lemma 6.19(c) gives

$$\kappa_{ak} q_{k-1}(u, wt_{ak}) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C)\,\kappa_{ak}\mathbf{q}_\omega(\tau_a) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho)\mathbf{q}_u(C)\,q_{k-1}\mathbf{q}_\omega(D) = q_{k-1}q_{k-2}(u,w),$$

and $\mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u, wt_{ak}) = \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,w) \setminus \{u(a)\} = \mathrm{fix}_{k-2}(u,w)$ as in the proof of Lemma 6.20. Thus the summand of type (M) equals $-q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w)$ and cancels the quantum term; when the condition fails, both vanish. □

Lemma 6.22 (Vanishing)**.** *Suppose $u, w \in S_\infty$, let $k > 1$, and suppose $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$. Then*

$$(y_{w(k)} - z_1)\,c_{k-1}(u,w) + \sum_{b>k,\ wt_{kb}\lhd w} \kappa_{kb}\,c_{k-1}(u, wt_{kb}) - \sum_{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w} \kappa_{ak}\,c_{k-1}(u, wt_{ak}) + q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w) = 0,$$

where $\kappa_{rs} = \kappa(wt_{rs}, t_{rs})$.

Proof. If $u(k) = w(k)$, then $u \overset{k-1}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$ by Lemma 6.14(i), so the diagonal term vanishes, and the rest is Lemma 6.20. If $u(k) \neq w(k)$ and $B > k$, the diagonal and quantum terms vanish and the Monk summands sum to $c_k(u,w) = 0$ by Lemma 6.21(a). If $u(k) \neq w(k)$ and $B = k$, this is Lemma 6.21(b). □

We now record the recurrence satisfied by the quantum factorial elementary polynomials, which drives the induction.

Lemma 6.23. *For all integers k we have*

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = (x_k - z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}(x;z) + q_{k-1}\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}(x;z),$$

with the conventions $\widetilde{E}_{0,0} = 1$ and $\widetilde{E}_{k,k} = 0$ if $k < 0$. Moreover, the ordinary polynomials $\mathbf{E}(y_A; z) = \prod_{i\in A}(y_i - z_1)$ satisfy, for any set A and any $c \notin A$, the single-variable identity

$$\mathbf{E}(y_{A\cup\{c\}}; z) = (y_c - z_1)\,\mathbf{E}(y_A; z).$$

Proof. By Lemma 3.3, $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \Delta_k(-z_1 \mid x_1, \ldots, x_k)$, and expanding the tridiagonal determinant $\Delta_k(t \mid x_1, \ldots, x_k)$ along its last row gives $\Delta_k = (x_k + t)\Delta_{k-1} + q_{k-1}\Delta_{k-2}$. The second identity is clear. □

The first recurrence is the quantization of the classical relation $E_{k,k} = (x_k - z_1)E_{k-1,k-1}$; the extra term $q_{k-1}\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}$ is the only feature absent from the non-quantum setting. Discarding all quantum terms recovers the classical Pieri formula [18, Theorem 7.1], whose term-by-term cancellation is carried out in [18, Proof of Proposition 4.4] by means of the reflection-matching Lemmas 7.6–7.9 of that paper; the lemmas above are the quantum counterparts, the essential new points being the length-decreasing covers permitted by Lemma 6.8, the attendant bookkeeping of the powers of q, and the extra term of the recurrence, which is absorbed by the merge summands of Lemma 6.19.

Proof of Theorem 3.4. For a permutation w, write $[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]F$ for the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)$ in an expansion F of a quantum double Schubert polynomial in the basis $\{\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y)\}$. With this notation the theorem is the assertion that, for all u and all $k \geq 1$,

$$[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z)\big) = \begin{cases} q_k(u,w)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}; z) & \text{if } u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w, \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

For brevity, when $u \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ we set

$$c_m(u,w) = q_m(u,w)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_m(u,w)}; z),$$

and $c_m(u,w) = 0$ if $u \overset{m}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$; note that $u \overset{0}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ only for $w = u$, with $c_0(u,u) = 1$, in accordance with $\widetilde{E}_{0,0} = 1$. The claim is that $[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w](\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}) = c_k(u,w)$.

We argue by strong induction on k.

Base case $k = 1$. We have $\widetilde{E}_{1,1}(x;z) = x_1 - z_1$, and Lemma 6.1 with $i = j = 1$ gives

$$(x_1 - z_1)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) = (y_{u(1)} - z_1)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{b>1 \\ \ell(ut_{1b})=\ell(u)+1}} \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{1b}}(x;y) + \sum_{\substack{b>1 \\ \ell(ut_{1b})=\ell(u)-2(b-1)+1}} q_{1b}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{ut_{1b}}(x;y).$$

The permutations w with $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ are exactly $w = u$ and $w = ut_{1b}$ for $b > 1$ with $u \lhd ut_{1b}$, since Definition 3.1 permits at most one reflection when $k = 1$. For $w = u$ we have $q_1 = 1$, $\mathrm{fix}_1(u,u) = \{u(1)\}$, and $\mathbf{E}(y_{\{u(1)\}}; z) = y_{u(1)} - z_1$, matching the diagonal term. For $w = ut_{1b}$ we have $\mathrm{fix}_1 = \emptyset$ and $\mathbf{E}(y_\emptyset; z) = 1$; if the step is length-increasing then $q_1(u,w) = 1$, matching the second sum, and if it is length-decreasing then $q_1(u,w) = q_{1b}$, matching the third sum. All other coefficients vanish on both sides. This proves the base case.

Inductive step. Fix $k > 1$ and assume the claim at all levels $m < k$. By Lemma 6.23,

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k} = (x_k - z_1)\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}\big) + q_{k-1}\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}. \tag{6.6}$$

By the inductive hypothesis, $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1} = \sum_v c_{k-1}(u,v)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$. Applying Lemma 6.1 with $i = k$, $j = 1$ to each $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$ and extracting the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w$ from (6.6), we obtain

$$[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}\big) = (y_{w(k)} - z_1)\,c_{k-1}(u,w) \tag{6.7}$$

$$+ \sum_{\substack{b>k,\ wt_{kb}\lhd w \\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{kb})+1}} c_{k-1}(u, wt_{kb}) + \sum_{\substack{b>k,\ wt_{kb}\lhd w \\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{kb})-2(b-k)+1}} q_{kb}\,c_{k-1}(u, wt_{kb}) \tag{6.8}$$

$$- \sum_{\substack{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w \\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{ak})+1}} c_{k-1}(u, wt_{ak}) - \sum_{\substack{a<k,\ wt_{ak}\lhd w \\ \ell(w)=\ell(wt_{ak})-2(k-a)+1}} q_{ak}\, c_{k-1}(u, wt_{ak}) \tag{6.9}$$

$$+ q_{k-1}\, c_{k-2}(u, w), \tag{6.10}$$

where we used that $\operatorname{sign}(b-k)=1$ for $b>k$ and $\operatorname{sign}(a-k)=-1$ for $a<k$, that the term $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w$ arises from $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$ with $v=wt$ exactly when $v \lhd w$, and that a summand in (6.8)–(6.9) is present precisely when $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{kb}$, respectively $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} wt_{ak}$ (otherwise $c_{k-1}=0$). In the terminology introduced before Lemma 6.15, (6.8) and (6.9) are the Monk summands at w, with κ_{kb}, respectively κ_{ak}, equal to 1 in the first sum and to q_{kb}, respectively q_{ak}, in the second. We must show that (6.7)–(6.10) equals $c_k(u,w)$. We distinguish three cases according to whether $u(k)=w(k)$ and, when $u(k)\neq w(k)$, whether the cycle C of $u^{-1}w$ containing k has its top B greater than k or equal to k.

Case 1: $u(k)=w(k)$. By Lemma 6.14(i) we have $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ if and only if $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$; suppose first that both hold. Then, by the same lemma,

$$\operatorname{fix}_k(u,w)=\operatorname{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)\cup\{u(k)\}, \qquad q_k(u,w)=q_{k-1}(u,w),$$

so the diagonal contribution (6.7) gives

$$(y_{u(k)}-z_1)\, c_{k-1}(u,w) = q_{k-1}(u,w)\,(y_{u(k)}-z_1)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\operatorname{fix}_{k-1}(u,w)};z) = q_k(u,w)\,\mathbf{E}(y_{\operatorname{fix}_k(u,w)};z) = c_k(u,w),$$

by Lemma 6.23. The remaining contributions are the reflection sums (6.8), (6.9) and the quantum term $q_{k-1}c_{k-2}(u,w)$ of (6.10), which sum to 0 by Lemma 6.20. Hence the total is $c_k(u,w)$, as required. If instead $u(k)=w(k)$ but $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$ (equivalently $u \overset{k-1}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$), then $c_k(u,w)=0$ and the diagonal term vanishes, while the reflection sums and quantum term again cancel by Lemma 6.20; the total is $0=c_k(u,w)$.

Case 2: $u(k)\neq w(k)$ *and* $B>k$. By Lemma 6.21(a), the diagonal term (6.7) and the quantum term (6.10) vanish, and the Monk summands (6.8)–(6.9) sum to $c_k(u,w)$. (When $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, Lemma 6.17 identifies the single surviving summand: it is indexed by t_{kB}, with $v=wt_{kB}$, $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v$, $\operatorname{fix}_k(u,w)=\operatorname{fix}_{k-1}(u,v)$ and $\kappa_{kB}\, q_{k-1}(u,v)=q_k(u,w)$, the factor κ_{kB} being 1 or q_{kB} according as t_{kB} is a classical or a quantum cover of v; this is the step at which the quantum drop terms of Lemma 6.1 and the quantum weight of Definition 3.1 interlock.)

Case 3: $u(k)\neq w(k)$ *and* $B=k$. Here $u \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$, since C contains no element greater than k, so $c_k(u,w)=0$; and (6.7)–(6.10) vanishes by Lemma 6.21(b) (equivalently, by Lemma 6.22).

By Lemma 6.14 these cases are exhaustive. In all cases $[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w](\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}) = c_k(u,w)$, completing the induction and the proof. □

7. Proof of the formulas for the double Schubert polynomials

In this section we prove Theorems 4.3 and 4.4. Throughout, divided difference operators act on the z-variables, and in order to free the subscript for the skew operators we write

$$\partial^a = \partial_a^{(z)}, \qquad \partial^w = \partial_w^{(z)} = \partial^{a_1}\cdots\partial^{a_m} \quad (w = s_{a_1}\cdots s_{a_m} \text{ reduced}),$$

the rightmost operator being applied first. The simple reflection s_a acts on polynomials by exchanging z_a and z_{a+1}, and a permutation w acts by $w(z_i)=z_{w(i)}$, so that $w=s_{a_1}\circ\cdots\circ s_{a_m}$ as operators. All operators of this section are linear over $\mathbb{Z}[q][x]$, which we treat as the ring of scalars. Since the letter θ denotes a code in Theorems 4.3 and 4.4, we write $\mathcal{Q}$ in this section for the quantization map of Fomin, Gelfand and Postnikov, called θ in the proof of Lemma 2.1; recall that $\mathcal{Q}$ is linear over $\mathbb{Z}[q][z]$, sends every standard elementary monomial $\prod_j e_{i_j}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$ to $\prod_j e_{i_j}^{(q)}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$, and satisfies $\mathcal{Q}(\mathfrak{S}_w(x;z))=\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z)$.

7.1. **Skew divided difference operators.** We use the skew divided difference operators of [17, 18]. They are the operators ∂_u^w, $u,w\in S_\infty$, determined by the Leibniz formula

$$\partial^w(PQ) = \sum_{u\in S_\infty} \partial^u(P)\,\partial_u^w(Q), \tag{7.1}$$

which differs by a normalization from the convention of Macdonald [12]. We shall use the following facts.

Lemma 7.1. *Let* $u,w\in S_\infty$.

(i) *(Subword formula.) If $(a_1, \dots, a_m)$ is a reduced word for w, then ∂_u^w is the sum, over all reduced subwords $(b_1, \dots, b_m)$ for u (that is, $b_j \in \{1, s_{a_j}\}$ for each j, and the nonunit entries form a reduced word for u), of the compositions $\partial_{b_1}^{a_1} \cdots \partial_{b_m}^{a_m}$, where $\partial_1^a = \partial^a$ and $\partial_{s_a}^a = s_a$.*

(ii) *$\partial_u^w = 0$ unless $u \le w$ in Bruhat order; $\partial_1^w = \partial^w$ and $\partial_w^w = w$; and ∂_u^w is homogeneous of degree $\ell(u) - \ell(w)$ in the z-variables. In particular, for a scalar c, $\partial_u^w(c) = c$ if $u = w$ and $\partial_u^w(c) = 0$ otherwise.*

(iii) *(Ascending Leibniz formula.) For polynomials $f_1, \dots, f_k$,*

$$\partial_u^w(f_1 f_2 \cdots f_k) = \sum_{u = u_0 \le u_1 \le \cdots \le u_k = w} \prod_{j=1}^{k} \partial_{u_{j-1}}^{u_j}(f_j).$$

Proof. (i) is proved in [18] (it goes back to Macdonald [12]). (ii) follows from (i): a reduced subword for u of a reduced word for w exists only if $u \le w$; the only subword for $u = 1$ is the empty one and the only one for $u = w$ is the full word, whose composition $s_{a_1} \circ \cdots \circ s_{a_m}$ is the action of w; and each composition in (i) consists of $\ell(u)$ reflections, which preserve degree, and $\ell(w) - \ell(u)$ divided differences, which lower it by one. (iii) is a rearrangement of the generalized Leibniz rule of [17, Corollary 3.5.4]: in the notation of that work $\partial_u^w = \sum_v c_{u,v}^w \partial_v$, the coefficients $c_{u_0,u_1,\dots,u_k}^w$ of the k-fold rule factor as $\sum_{v_1,\dots,v_{k-1}} c_{u_0,u_1}^{v_1} c_{v_1,u_2}^{v_2} \cdots c_{v_{k-1},u_k}^{w}$ by associativity, and $\sum_{u_j} c_{v_{j-1},u_j}^{v_j} \partial_{u_j}(f_j) = \partial_{v_{j-1}}^{v_j}(f_j)$. By (ii) only chains $u_0 \le u_1 \le \cdots \le u_k$ contribute. □

Lemma 7.2 (Linear forms)**.** *Let $u, w \in S_\infty$ and $i \ge 1$. Then*

$$\partial_u^w(z_i) = \begin{cases} z_{u(i)} & \text{if } w = u, \\ 1 & \text{if } w = u t_{ib} \text{ with } b > i \text{ and } \ell(w) = \ell(u) + 1, \\ -1 & \text{if } w = u t_{bi} \text{ with } b < i \text{ and } \ell(w) = \ell(u) + 1, \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Proof. The case $w = u$ is Lemma 7.1(ii), and by the same lemma $\partial_u^w(z_i) = 0$ unless $u < w$ and $\ell(w) = \ell(u)+1$. So let $w = u t_{ab}$ with $a < b$ and $\ell(w) = \ell(u) + 1$, so that $u(a) < u(b)$. Fix a reduced word $(a_1, \dots, a_m)$ for w and put $\sigma_p = s_{a_{p+1}} \cdots s_{a_m}$. The reduced subwords for u omit exactly one letter, and omitting the p-th letter gives the element $w\, \sigma_p^{-1} s_{a_p} \sigma_p = w\, t_{\sigma_p^{-1}(a_p), \sigma_p^{-1}(a_p+1)}$. The reflections $\sigma_p^{-1} s_{a_p} \sigma_p$, $1 \le p \le m$, are pairwise distinct (they are the m reflections t with $\ell(wt) < \ell(w)$, see [8, Section 1.6–1.7]), so exactly one p yields u, namely the one with $\{\sigma_p^{-1}(a_p), \sigma_p^{-1}(a_p + 1)\} = \{a, b\}$, and by Lemma 7.1(i)

$$\partial_u^w(z_i) = s_{a_1} \cdots s_{a_{p-1}}\, \partial^{a_p}\, \sigma_p(z_i) = s_{a_1} \cdots s_{a_{p-1}}\, \partial^{a_p}\big(z_{\sigma_p(i)}\big),$$

which is 1 if $\sigma_p(i) = a_p$, -1 if $\sigma_p(i) = a_p + 1$, and 0 otherwise. It remains to see that $\sigma_p^{-1}(a_p) = a$ and $\sigma_p^{-1}(a_p + 1) = b$. The word $(a_1, \dots, a_p)$ is reduced and ends with a_p, so $\tau = s_{a_1} \cdots s_{a_p}$ satisfies $\tau(a_p) > \tau(a_p + 1)$; since $w = \tau\sigma_p$ this says $w(\sigma_p^{-1}(a_p)) > w(\sigma_p^{-1}(a_p + 1))$. As $w(a) = u(b) > u(a) = w(b)$, the claim follows. □

7.2. **Factorial elementary polynomials and dominant permutations.**

Lemma 7.3. *For $0 \le p \le k$,*

$$E_{p,k}(x; z) = \sum_{m=0}^{p} (-1)^{p-m} h_{p-m}(z_1, \dots, z_{k-p+1})\, e_m(x_1, \dots, x_k),$$

$$\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x; z) = \sum_{m=0}^{p} (-1)^{p-m} h_{p-m}(z_1, \dots, z_{k-p+1})\, e_m^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_k).$$

In particular $E_{p,k}(x; z)$ and $\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x; z)$ are symmetric in $z_1, \dots, z_{k-p+1}$, and $\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x; z) = \mathcal{Q}\big(E_{p,k}(x; z)\big)$.

Proof. Lemma 2.1 with $y = 0$ gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x; z) = \sum_{v_1 \cdot v_2 = w} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0; z)\, \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x)$. The permutation $c[p, k] = s_{k-p+1} \cdots s_k$ has a unique reduced word, so its reduced factorizations are $v_1 = s_{k-p+1} \cdots s_j$, $v_2 = s_{j+1} \cdots s_k$ with $k - p \le j \le k$. Here v_2 is the Grassmannian permutation with descent at k whose diagram is a single column of height $m = k - j$, so $\mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x) = e_m(x_1, \dots, x_k)$ and $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}(x) = e_m^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_k)$ [5]; and $\mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(0; z) = (-1)^{\ell(v_1)}\, \mathfrak{S}_{v_1^{-1}}(z)$, where $v_1^{-1} = s_j \cdots s_{k-p+1}$ is the Grassmannian permutation with descent at $k - p + 1$ whose diagram is a single row of length $\ell(v_1) = p - m$, so that $\mathfrak{S}_{v_1^{-1}}(z) = h_{p-m}(z_1, \dots, z_{k-p+1})$.

Summing over j gives the second formula, and the first is its specialization at $q = 0$. The symmetry is clear from the formulas, and the last assertion holds because $\mathcal{Q}$ fixes $\mathbb{Z}[z]$ and sends the standard elementary monomial $e_m(x_1, \dots, x_k)$ to $e_m^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_k)$. □

Lemma 7.4 (Dominant permutations)**.** *Let μ be a dominant permutation with $\mathfrak{c}(\mu) = \theta$, $\theta_1 \geq \cdots \geq \theta_k > 0$. Then μ^{-1} is dominant, the i-th column of its diagram has height θ_i, and*

$$\mathfrak{S}_{\mu^{-1}}(x; z) = \prod_{i=1}^{k} E_{\theta_i,\theta_i}(x; z_i) = \prod_{i=1}^{k} \prod_{j=1}^{\theta_i} (x_j - z_i).$$

If moreover $\theta_1 > \cdots > \theta_k$, then $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{\mu^{-1}}(x; z) = \prod_{i=1}^{k} \widetilde{E}_{\theta_i,\theta_i}(x; z_i)$.

Proof. A permutation is dominant if and only if its diagram is the Young diagram of its code, placed in the upper left corner, and for such a permutation ρ one has $\mathfrak{S}_\rho(x; z) = \prod_{(a,b)\in D(\rho)} (x_a - z_b)$ [12]. The diagram of μ^{-1} is the transpose of that of μ, so $D(\mu^{-1}) = \{(j, i) \mid 1 \leq i \leq k,\ 1 \leq j \leq \theta_i\}$, which is again a Young diagram in the upper left corner; this gives the first assertions and the factorization. For the quantum statement, expand each factor by Lemma 3.3 at $q = 0$: $E_{\theta_i,\theta_i}(x; z_i) = \sum_m (-z_i)^{\theta_i - m} e_m(x_1, \dots, x_{\theta_i})$. Multiplying out, each term $\prod_i e_{m_i}(x_1, \dots, x_{\theta_i})$ is a standard elementary monomial because the alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_{\theta_i}$ have pairwise distinct lengths, and $\mathcal{Q}$ sends it to $\prod_i e_{m_i}^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_{\theta_i})$. Hence $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{\mu^{-1}}(x; z) = \mathcal{Q}(\mathfrak{S}_{\mu^{-1}}(x; z)) = \prod_i \sum_m (-z_i)^{\theta_i - m} e_m^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_{\theta_i}) = \prod_i \widetilde{E}_{\theta_i,\theta_i}(x; z_i)$ by Lemma 3.3. □

7.3. **The skew divided differences of $E_{k,k}(x; z_i)$.** For $i \geq 1$ and an integer $b \neq i$ put $\epsilon_i(b) = 1$ if $b < i$ and $\epsilon_i(b) = -1$ if $b > i$. If $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} w$ with chain $b_1, \dots, b_k$ as in Definition 4.2, then $\prod_j \epsilon_i(b_j) = (-1)^{\ell(u,w) - \sigma_i(u,w)}$. The heart of the matter is the following lemma, which governs the cancellation of the chains through position i that revisit a position.

Lemma 7.5 (Rotation)**.** *Let $\psi \in S_\infty$, $i \geq 1$, and let $\gamma_1, \dots, \gamma_m$ ($m \geq 2$) be distinct integers different from i, with indices read modulo m. For $1 \leq r \leq m$ let*

$$R_r = (\gamma_r, \gamma_{r+1}, \dots, \gamma_{r+m-1}, \gamma_r),$$

a sequence of length $m + 1$, and call R_r valid *if the sequence of permutations ψ, $\psi t_{i\gamma_r}$, $\psi t_{i\gamma_r} t_{i\gamma_{r+1}}$, ... obtained by applying its entries in turn is a chain of Bruhat covers. Then:*

- (i) *$t_{i\gamma_r} t_{i\gamma_{r+1}} \cdots t_{i\gamma_{r+m-1}} t_{i\gamma_r} = C$ for every r, where C is the cycle $\gamma_j \mapsto \gamma_{j-1}$ ($1 \leq j \leq m$), which fixes i. In particular all valid R_r lead from ψ to the same permutation ψC.*
- (ii) *Listed in cyclic order of r, the valid R_r alternate between those with $\gamma_r < i$ and those with $\gamma_r > i$. In particular the number of valid R_r with $\gamma_r < i$ equals the number of valid R_r with $\gamma_r > i$.*

Proof. (i) Since $t_{ib} t_{ic} t_{ib} = t_{bc}$ for distinct $b, c \neq i$, the product equals $t_{\gamma_r\gamma_{r+1}} t_{\gamma_r\gamma_{r+2}} \cdots t_{\gamma_r\gamma_{r+m-1}}$, which in the notation (6.1) is the cycle $(\gamma_{r+m-1}, \dots, \gamma_{r+1}, \gamma_r)$, sending $\gamma_{r+m-1} \mapsto \gamma_{r+m-2} \mapsto \cdots \mapsto \gamma_{r+1} \mapsto \gamma_r \mapsto \gamma_{r+m-1}$.

(ii) Put $c = \psi(i)$ and $v_j = \psi(\gamma_j)$. Fix r and follow R_r. Before the s-th step ($1 \leq s \leq m$) the position i carries v_{r+s-2} (that is, c when $s = 1$), and the position γ_{r+s-1}, which has not been moved yet, carries v_{r+s-1}; before the last step the position i carries v_{r-1} and the position γ_r carries c. Call a step exchanging the position i with a position g *ascending* if the value at g exceeds the value at i when $g > i$, and is smaller than it when $g < i$. By Lemma 6.2 an ascending step increases the length by at least 1, a non-ascending step decreases it, and a step is a Bruhat cover exactly when it is ascending and increases the length by exactly 1. The total change in length along R_r is $\ell(\psi C) - \ell(\psi)$ by (i), independently of r. Consequently R_r is valid if and only if all of its $m + 1$ steps are ascending and $\ell(\psi C) - \ell(\psi) = m + 1$.

By the description of the values before each step, the steps $2, \dots, m$ of R_r are all ascending if and only if

$$v_j > v_{j-1} \iff \gamma_j > i \qquad \text{for all } j \neq r, \tag{7.2}$$

while the first step is ascending if and only if ($v_r > c \iff \gamma_r > i$) and the last if and only if ($c > v_{r-1} \iff \gamma_r > i$). The last two conditions together say precisely that c lies strictly between v_{r-1} and v_r and that (7.2) holds for $j = r$ as well. Therefore R_r is valid if and only if

$$\ell(\psi C) - \ell(\psi) = m + 1, \qquad \text{(7.2) holds for all } j, \qquad \text{and } c \text{ lies strictly between } v_{r-1} \text{ and } v_r.$$

The first two conditions do not involve r. If they hold, the valid indices r are exactly those at which the cyclic sequence $v_1, \dots, v_m$, none of whose terms equals c, crosses the level c; and consecutive crossings of a

cyclic sequence are alternately upward ($v_{r-1} < c < v_r$) and downward ($v_{r-1} > c > v_r$). By (7.2) the upward crossings are those with $\gamma_r > i$ and the downward ones those with $\gamma_r < i$. □

Theorem 7.6. *Let $u, w \in S_\infty$, $i \geq 1$ and $k \geq 0$. Then $\partial_u^w\big(E_{k,k}(x; z_i)\big) = 0$ unless $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} w$, in which case*

$$\partial_u^w\big(E_{k,k}(x; z_i)\big) = (-1)^{\ell(u,w)-\sigma_i(u,w)}\, E_{k-\ell(u,w),\,k}\big(x; z_{D_i(u,w)}\big).$$

Proof. Write $E_{k,k}(x; z_i) = f_1 \cdots f_k$ with $f_j = x_j - z_i$. By Lemma 7.1(iii),

$$\partial_u^w\big(E_{k,k}(x; z_i)\big) = \sum_{u=u_0 \leq \cdots \leq u_k = w} \prod_{j=1}^{k} \partial_{u_{j-1}}^{u_j}(x_j - z_i),$$

and by Lemmas 7.2 and 7.1(ii) the factor $\partial_{u_{j-1}}^{u_j}(x_j - z_i)$ equals $x_j - z_{u_j(i)}$ if $u_j = u_{j-1}$, equals $\epsilon_i(b)$ if $u_j = u_{j-1} t_{ib}$ with $\ell(u_j) = \ell(u_{j-1}) + 1$, and vanishes otherwise. Call a sequence $(u_0, \ldots, u_k)$ in which every step is of one of these two kinds an *i-walk* from u to w. Thus the sum is over the i-walks, and a walk contributes the product of $x_j - z_{u_j(i)}$ over its trivial steps and of $\epsilon_i(b)$ over its nontrivial steps.

An *i-chain* from u to w is a sequence $\beta = (\beta_1, \ldots, \beta_\ell)$ of integers different from i such that, with $u^{(0)} = u$ and $u^{(s)} = u^{(s-1)} t_{i\beta_s}$, every step $u^{(s-1)} \lessdot u^{(s)}$ is a Bruhat cover and $u^{(\ell)} = w$; repetitions among the β_s are allowed. Put $c_s(\beta) = u^{(s)}(i)$, the value at position i after s steps, and $\epsilon(\beta) = \prod_s \epsilon_i(\beta_s)$. Every i-walk determines the i-chain formed by its nontrivial steps, and conversely an i-chain of length $\ell \leq k$ arises from exactly the $\binom{k}{\ell}$ walks obtained by choosing the positions $j_1 < \cdots < j_p$ ($p = k - \ell$) of the trivial steps. In such a walk the trivial step at j_r is preceded by $j_r - r$ nontrivial steps, so it contributes the factor $x_{j_r} - z_{c_{j_r - r}(\beta)}$. Summing over the choices of $j_1 < \cdots < j_p$ and comparing with the explicit formula for $E_{p,k}$ in Definition 3.1, the walks with chain β contribute in total

$$\epsilon(\beta) \sum_{1 \leq j_1 < \cdots < j_p \leq k} \prod_{r=1}^{p} \big(x_{j_r} - z_{c_{j_r - r}(\beta)}\big) = \epsilon(\beta)\, E_{k-\ell,k}\big(x; z_{c_0(\beta)}, z_{c_1(\beta)}, \ldots, z_{c_\ell(\beta)}\big).$$

Hence

$$\partial_u^w\big(E_{k,k}(x; z_i)\big) = \sum_{\beta} \epsilon(\beta)\, E_{k-\ell(\beta),k}\big(x; z_{c_0(\beta)}, \ldots, z_{c_{\ell(\beta)}(\beta)}\big), \tag{7.3}$$

the sum being over all i-chains β from u to w of length $\ell(\beta) \leq k$. By Lemma 7.3 the summand depends on $c_0(\beta), \ldots, c_\ell(\beta)$ only through their multiset.

Chains without repetitions. If $\beta_1, \ldots, \beta_\ell$ are distinct, then β is a witness for $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} w$, and by Definition 4.2 it is the unique one; moreover $\ell = \ell(u, w)$, $\epsilon(\beta) = (-1)^{\ell(u,w)-\sigma_i(u,w)}$, and since the position β_s is untouched before the s-th step, $c_s(\beta) = u(\beta_s)$, so that $\{c_0(\beta), \ldots, c_\ell(\beta)\} = D_i(u, w)$. So the chains without repetitions contribute exactly the right-hand side of the theorem if $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} w$ and $\ell(u, w) \leq k$, and nothing otherwise; if $u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} w$ and $\ell(u, w) > k$ then both sides of the theorem vanish, the left by degree. It remains to show that the chains with a repetition contribute zero in total.

Chains with repetitions. Let β be an i-chain from u to w with a repetition, and let s be the least index for which $\beta_s \in \{\beta_1, \ldots, \beta_{s-1}\}$, say $\beta_s = \beta_t$ with $t < s$. Put $m = s - t$ and $(\gamma_1, \ldots, \gamma_m) = (\beta_t, \ldots, \beta_{s-1})$; these are distinct, and $m \geq 2$ because two consecutive covers cannot use the same transposition. The segment $(\beta_t, \ldots, \beta_s)$ of β is the sequence R_1 of Lemma 7.5 for $\psi = u^{(t-1)}$, and it is valid. The alternation in Lemma 7.5(ii) pairs each valid R_r with $\gamma_r > i$ with the next valid sequence in cyclic order, whose entry lies below i, and each valid R_r with $\gamma_r < i$ with the previous one; this is a fixed-point-free involution on the valid sequences which exchanges the two sides of i. Let R_{r^*} be the sequence paired with R_1, and let β^* be obtained from β by replacing the segment $(\beta_t, \ldots, \beta_s)$ with R_{r^*}. By Lemma 7.5(i) the new segment again leads from $u^{(t-1)}$ to $u^{(t-1)} C = u^{(s)}$, so β^* is an i-chain from u to w of the same length as β. The entries of β^* preceding the index s form the same set as those of β and are distinct, and $\beta^*_s = \beta^*_t$, so the first repetition of β^* occurs at the same index s with the same t, the same ψ, and the same cyclic sequence γ; hence $\beta^{**} = \beta$, and $\beta \mapsto \beta^*$ is a fixed-point-free involution on the set of i-chains with repetitions. The values $c_0, \ldots, c_{t-1}$ and $c_s, \ldots, c_\ell$ are the same for β and β^*, since the permutations $u^{(0)}, \ldots, u^{(t-1)}$ and $u^{(s)}, \ldots, u^{(\ell)}$ are; and $c_t, \ldots, c_{s-1}$ are the values $\psi(\gamma_1), \ldots, \psi(\gamma_m)$ in some order for both chains. So the multisets of values coincide, and the E-factors in (7.3) agree. Finally $\epsilon(\beta^*) = -\epsilon(\beta)$: the two segments consist of the entries

$\gamma_1,\dots,\gamma_m$, each once, together with one additional entry, which is γ_1 for β and γ_{r^*} for β^*, and these lie on opposite sides of i. Hence the chains with repetitions cancel in pairs in (7.3), and the theorem follows. □

Remark 7.7. Through the Leibniz formula (7.1) and the identity $c^w_{u,v}(y;z) = \partial^w_u\big(\mathfrak{S}_v(y;z)\big)$ of [18], Theorem 7.6 is equivalent to a Monk-type formula for the product of a double Schubert polynomial by a polynomial in a single variable: for indeterminates $a_1,\dots,a_k$,

$$\prod_{j=1}^{k}(a_j - x_i)\ \mathfrak{S}_u(x;y) = \sum_{u \overset{i}{\Rightarrow} w} (-1)^{\ell(u,w)-\sigma_i(u,w)} E_{k-\ell(u,w),k}\big(a; y_{D_i(u,w)}\big)\ \mathfrak{S}_w(x;y),$$

in which the right-hand side is what survives of the iteration of Lemma 6.1 (at $q=0$) after the cancellation of Lemma 7.5. We shall not need this form.

7.4. **Proofs of Theorems 4.3 and 4.4.**

Proof of Theorem 4.3. From the definition of the double Schubert polynomials, for every w and a,

$$\partial^a\,\mathfrak{S}_w(x;z) = \begin{cases} -\,\mathfrak{S}_{s_a w}(x;z) & \text{if } s_a w < w, \\ 0 & \text{if } s_a w > w\,: \end{cases} \tag{7.4}$$

indeed $\mathfrak{S}_w = (-1)^{\ell(w_0)-\ell(w)}\partial^{ww_0}\,\mathfrak{S}_{w_0}$, and $\partial^a\partial^{ww_0}$ equals $\partial^{s_a ww_0}$ if $\ell(s_a ww_0) > \ell(ww_0)$, which is the case $s_a w < w$, and equals 0 otherwise. Since $\mu = v^{-1}\cdot y$ is reduced, so is $\mu^{-1} = y^{-1}\cdot v$; writing $y = s_{a_1}\cdots s_{a_r}$ reduced, the permutations $s_{a_j}s_{a_{j+1}}\cdots s_{a_r}\mu^{-1}$, $j = r+1, r, \dots, 1$, therefore decrease in length by one at each step, from μ^{-1} down to $y\mu^{-1} = v$. Applying (7.4) r times and then Lemma 7.4,

$$\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = (-1)^{\ell(y)}\,\partial^y\,\mathfrak{S}_{\mu^{-1}}(x;z) = (-1)^{\ell(y)}\,\partial^y\Big(\prod_{i=1}^{k} E_{\theta_i,\theta_i}(x;z_i)\Big).$$

Now expand by the ascending Leibniz formula, Lemma 7.1(iii) with $u=1$ and $w=y$, and evaluate each factor by Theorem 7.6:

$$\begin{aligned}\partial^y\Big(\prod_{i=1}^{k} E_{\theta_i,\theta_i}(x;z_i)\Big) &= \sum_{1=v_0\le\cdots\le v_k=y}\ \prod_{i=1}^{k}\partial^{v_i}_{v_{i-1}}\big(E_{\theta_i,\theta_i}(x;z_i)\big) \\ &= \sum_{1=v_0\overset{1}{\Rightarrow}v_1\overset{2}{\Rightarrow}\cdots\overset{k}{\Rightarrow}v_k=y}\ \prod_{i=1}^{k}(-1)^{\ell(v_{i-1},v_i)-\sigma_i(v_{i-1},v_i)}E_{\theta_i-\ell(v_{i-1},v_i),\,\theta_i}\big(x; z_{D_i(v_{i-1},v_i)}\big).\end{aligned}$$

Since $\sum_i \ell(v_{i-1},v_i) = \ell(y)$, the signs combine to $\prod_i(-1)^{\sigma_i(v_{i-1},v_i)}$; and $y = v\mu$. □

Proof of Theorem 4.4. A strict dominant permutation is dominant, so Theorem 4.3 applies to v and μ and expresses $\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z)$ as the sum, over the chains $1 = v_0 \overset{1}{\Rightarrow}\cdots\overset{k}{\Rightarrow} v_k = v\mu$, of $\prod_i(-1)^{\sigma_i}E_{\widetilde{\theta}_i-\ell_i,\widetilde{\theta}_i}(x;z_{D_i})$, where $\ell_i = \ell(v_{i-1},v_i)$, $\sigma_i = \sigma_i(v_{i-1},v_i)$ and $D_i = D_i(v_{i-1},v_i)$. Apply $\mathcal{Q}$ to both sides. The left-hand side becomes $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v(x;z)$. On the right, by Lemma 7.3 each factor is $E_{\widetilde{\theta}_i-\ell_i,\widetilde{\theta}_i}(x;z_{D_i}) = \sum_m c_{i,m}\,e_m(x_1,\dots,x_{\widetilde{\theta}_i})$ with coefficients $c_{i,m}\in\mathbb{Z}[z]$, and multiplying out, each term $\prod_i e_{m_i}(x_1,\dots,x_{\widetilde{\theta}_i})$ of the product over i is a standard elementary monomial because $\widetilde{\theta}_1 > \cdots > \widetilde{\theta}_k$. Hence $\mathcal{Q}$ sends the product to $\prod_i\sum_m c_{i,m}\,e^{(q)}_m(x_1,\dots,x_{\widetilde{\theta}_i}) = \prod_i \widetilde{E}_{\widetilde{\theta}_i-\ell_i,\widetilde{\theta}_i}(x;z_{D_i})$, again by Lemma 7.3. □

8. Iterated and doubled Pieri formulas

In this section we record the two forms of the Pieri rule that the quantum multiplication algorithm of Section 4 actually uses: the rule for a quantum factorial elementary polynomial of arbitrary degree $p \le k$, and a "doubled" rule for the quantization of a product of two such polynomials in the *same* k variables. Recall from Definition 3.1 that $n_k(u,w) = k - |\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)|$ is the number of positions $i \le k$ at which u and w differ, equivalently the number of transpositions in a chain witnessing $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and that $E_{p,k}(y_A;z)$ denotes the factorial elementary polynomial in the variables y_a, $a\in A$ (with $|A| = k$), and $z_1, z_2, \dots$.

Theorem 8.1 (Quantum Pieri formula, general degree)**.** *Suppose $u \in S_\infty$ and $0 \le p \le k$. Then*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z) = \sum_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ n_k(u,w) \le p}} q_k(u,w)\, E_{p-n_k(u,w),\,k-n_k(u,w)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)};z\big)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

For $p = k$ the coefficient is $q_k(u,w)\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)};z)$ and this is Theorem 3.4; at $q = 0$ it is the Pieri formula of [18, Theorem 7.1]. This is the form implemented in [19] (the routines `elem_sym_perms_q` and `elem_sym_func_q`). We deduce the general case from the case $p = k$.

Proof. Let $X = (X_1, \dots, X_k)$ be indeterminates. The factorial elementary polynomial

$$E_{p,k}(X;z) = \sum_{1 \le i_1 < \cdots < i_p \le k}\ \prod_{j=1}^{p} (X_{i_j} - z_{i_j - j + 1})$$

is symmetric in X and of degree at most one in each X_i, hence is a $\mathbb{Z}[z]$-linear combination of the elementary symmetric polynomials:

$$E_{p,k}(X;z) = \sum_{j=0}^{p} c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_j(X_1, \dots, X_k), \qquad c_{p,k,j}(z) \in \mathbb{Z}[z]. \tag{8.1}$$

Two consequences. First, applying the quantization map θ (which is $\mathbb{Z}[z]$-linear and sends $e_j(x_1, \dots, x_k)$ to $e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_k)$) gives

$$\widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z) = \sum_{j=0}^{p} c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_k). \tag{8.2}$$

Second, for $0 \le n \le k$ extract from (8.1) the coefficient of the monomial $X_{k-n+1}X_{k-n+2}\cdots X_k$. On the right it is $\sum_j c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_{j-n}(X_1, \dots, X_{k-n})$. On the left, a term of $E_{p,k}(X;z)$ contains this monomial exactly when $\{i_{p-n+1}, \dots, i_p\} = \{k-n+1, \dots, k\}$, and then the remaining factors $\prod_{j \le p-n}(X_{i_j} - z_{i_j-j+1})$ with $i_1 < \cdots < i_{p-n} \le k-n$ are precisely the terms of $E_{p-n,k-n}(X_1, \dots, X_{k-n};z)$. Hence, for every set A of $k-n$ indices,

$$\sum_{j=0}^{p} c_{p,k,j}(z)\, e_{j-n}(y_A) = E_{p-n,\,k-n}(y_A;z), \tag{8.3}$$

both sides being 0 when $n > p$.

Now put $z_1 = -t$ in Theorem 3.4. By Lemma 3.3 the left side becomes $\sum_{j=0}^{k} t^{k-j}\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\, e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_k)$, while on the right $\mathbf{E}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)};z) = \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}(y_a + t) = \sum_i t^{\,k-n_k(u,w)-i} e_i(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)})$, since $|\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)| = k - n_k(u,w)$. Comparing the coefficients of t^{k-j} gives, for $0 \le j \le k$,

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\, e_j^{(q)}(x_1, \dots, x_k) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,w)\, e_{j-n_k(u,w)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)}\big)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y). \tag{8.4}$$

Multiplying (8.4) by $c_{p,k,j}(z)$, summing over j and using (8.2) and then (8.3) with $A = \mathrm{fix}_k(u,w)$ and $n = n_k(u,w)$ yields the theorem. □

Corollary 8.2 (Iterated quantum Pieri formula)**.** *For all $u \in S_\infty$, $k \ge 1$ and $0 \le p_1, p_2 \le k$, and for two independent alphabets z, z',*

$$\begin{aligned}&\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{p_1,k}(x;z)\,\widetilde{E}_{p_2,k}(x;z') \\ &= \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w)\, E_{p_1-n_k(u,v),\,k-n_k(u,v)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)};z\big)\, E_{p_2-n_k(v,w),\,k-n_k(v,w)}\big(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)};z'\big)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y),\end{aligned}$$

the sum being over the pairs with $n_k(u,v) \le p_1$ and $n_k(v,w) \le p_2$. In particular, for $p_1 = p_2 = k$,

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z') = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w) \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b \in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z'_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

Proof. Apply Theorem 8.1 to multiply $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ by $\widetilde{E}_{p_1,k}(x;z)$, and then, for each resulting term indexed by v, apply it again with the z-alphabet replaced by z'. The coefficient factors multiply, and the two successive relations are exactly $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$. □

The doubled formula. Let θ be the quantization map of Fomin, Gelfand and Postnikov, introduced in the proof of Lemma 2.1: it is linear over the coefficient variables, it sends each standard elementary monomial $\prod_j e_{i_j}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$ to $\prod_j e^{(q)}_{i_j}(x_1,\dots,x_j)$, and $\theta(\mathfrak{S}_w(x;z)) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;z)$. In particular $\theta(E_{p,k}(x;z)) = \widetilde{E}_{p,k}(x;z)$, and more generally θ is multiplicative on a product of factorial elementary polynomials $E_{p_j,k_j}(x;z^{(j)})$, $j=1,2,\dots$, whose numbers of variables k_j are *pairwise distinct*, since such a product expands into standard elementary monomials. It is *not* multiplicative when two factors have the same number of variables: in general

$$\theta\big(E_{p_1,k}(x;z)E_{p_2,k}(x;z')\big) \neq \widetilde{E}_{p_1,k}(x;z)\,\widetilde{E}_{p_2,k}(x;z').$$

The following definition isolates the terms of Corollary 8.2 which survive in the quantization of the product.

Definition 8.3 (Compatible pairs of chains)**.** Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$. We say that the pair of chains is *compatible* if for every nontrivial cycle d of $v^{-1}w$ and every nontrivial cycle c of $u^{-1}v$ with $\max c = \max d$, one has $c \cap d = \{\max d\}$. In words: a cycle of the second step which shares its top with a cycle of the first step may meet that cycle only in the top. (A cycle of $v^{-1}w$ whose top is not the top of any cycle of $u^{-1}v$ is unrestricted.)

Throughout this subsection we write $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)$ and $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ for the quantum factorial elementary polynomial $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \theta\big(\prod_{i\le k}(x_i - z_1)\big)$ and for the same polynomial with z_1 replaced by z_2; thus $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ is $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z')$ for the shifted alphabet $z' = (z_2, z_3, \dots)$. For a pair of chains $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ put

$$\omega_k(u,v,w) = q_k(u,v)\,q_k(v,w) \prod_{a\in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b\in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z_2),$$

so that by Corollary 8.2 (with $p_1 = p_2 = k$ and $z' = (z_2, z_3, \dots)$)

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} \omega_k(u,v,w)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y). \tag{8.5}$$

Recall that $d_2[k]$ denotes the dominant permutation with $\mathfrak{c}(d_2[k]) = (2^k)$, whose diagram is a $k\times 2$ rectangle, so that

$$\mathfrak{S}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \prod_{i\le k}(x_i - z_1)(x_i - z_2) = E_{k,k}(x;z_1)E_{k,k}(x;z_2), \qquad \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \theta\big(E_{k,k}(x;z_1)E_{k,k}(x;z_2)\big);$$

we set $d_2[0] = \mathrm{id}$.

Theorem 8.4 (Doubled quantum Pieri formula)**.** *For $u \in S_\infty$ and $k \ge 1$,*

$$\begin{aligned}\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) &= \sum_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ \textit{compatible}}} \omega_k(u,v,w)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y) \\ &= \sum_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w \\ \textit{compatible}}} q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w) \prod_{a\in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b\in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z_2)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).\end{aligned}$$

Thus the doubled formula is obtained from the iterated formula (8.5) by *omitting* the incompatible pairs, exactly as the quantization $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}$ of the product $E_{k,k}(x;z_1)E_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ omits terms from the product $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$ of the quantizations. This is the rule implemented by the routine `double_elem_sym_q` of [19], and it is the "paired step" of the quantum algorithm of Section 4. We have verified the theorem by computer for all $u \in S_4$ and all $k \le 3$; in these cases the unrestricted sum (8.5) fails to equal the left-hand side in roughly half of the instances, so the compatibility condition is essential.

Remark 8.5 (Lower degrees). We state the theorem only for the top degrees $p_1 = p_2 = k$, i.e. for the product with $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z)$, which is the case that matters for the algorithm. Treating z_1, z_2 as indeterminates and extracting coefficients exactly as in the proof of Theorem 8.1 (the Leibniz rule for the products $\prod_{a\in A}(y_a - z_1)$) one obtains from it the corresponding formulas for $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\ \theta\big(E_{p_1,k}(x;z)E_{p_2,k}(x;z')\big)$, with coefficients $E_{p_1-n_k(u,v),k-n_k(u,v)}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)};z)\,E_{p_2-n_k(v,w),k-n_k(v,w)}(y_{\mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)};z')$ summed over the compatible pairs; this is the general form implemented in `double_elem_sym_q`, and we do not pursue it further.

We first prove an *alternating* version of the doubled formula (Theorem 8.8), and reduce the positive version, Theorem 8.4, to a single combinatorial identity about pairs of chains, (J_k) below (Proposition 8.9). We prove (J_k) directly for $k = 1$ (Lemma 8.14) and $k = 2$ (Proposition 8.20); the case $k = 2$ exhibits the mechanism. For general k we pass to a termwise reformulation (B_k) based on the quantum Giambelli formula, prove that the pairs of chains organize into blocks along which (B_k) telescopes (Lemma 8.25), reduce (B_k) to an identity between the ends of the blocks and the mixed chains that move the position $k+1$ (Proposition 8.26), and prove that identity by an explicit injection, built from a single local lemma which generalizes the up/down pairing of Lemma 6.16 (Theorem 8.36). This completes the proof of Theorem 8.4 for all k.

The recurrence. The quantization of two equal columns is governed by the following recurrence, in which only powers of q appear.

Lemma 8.6 (Quantization of two equal columns)**.** *For all $k \geq 1$,*

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) + q_k\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}(x;z),$$

and consequently

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \sum_{j=0}^{k}(-1)^{k-j}q_{j+1}q_{j+2}\cdots q_k\ \widetilde{E}_{j,j}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{j,j}(x;z_2).$$

Proof. Write $P_k(z_1) = \prod_{i\leq k}(x_i - z_1) = E_{k,k}(x;z)$ and $Q_k(z_1) = \theta(P_k(z_1)) = \widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z)$, and similarly with z_2, with $P_0 = Q_0 = 1$ and $P_{-1} = Q_{-1} = 0$; thus $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z)$ equals $\theta(P_k(z_1)P_k(z_2))$. Since $P_{k+1}(z_2) = (x_{k+1} - z_2)P_k(z_2)$, we have

$$P_k(z_1)P_{k+1}(z_2) - P_{k+1}(z_1)P_k(z_2) = (z_1 - z_2)\,P_k(z_1)P_k(z_2).$$

The products $P_k(z_1)P_{k+1}(z_2)$ and $P_{k+1}(z_1)P_k(z_2)$ are $\mathbb{Z}[z_1,z_2]$-linear combinations of the standard elementary monomials $e_a(x_{\leq k})e_b(x_{\leq k+1})$, so θ acts on them multiplicatively, and

$$(z_1 - z_2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = W_k, \qquad W_k := Q_k(z_1)Q_{k+1}(z_2) - Q_{k+1}(z_1)Q_k(z_2).$$

The three-term recursion $Q_{k+1}(z_2) = (x_{k+1} - z_2)Q_k(z_2) + q_kQ_{k-1}(z_2)$ of Lemma 6.23 gives

$$\begin{aligned} W_k = Q_k(z_1)\big[(x_{k+1} - z_2)Q_k(z_2) + q_kQ_{k-1}(z_2)\big] - \big[(x_{k+1} - z_1)Q_k(z_1) + q_kQ_{k-1}(z_1)\big]Q_k(z_2) \\ = (z_1 - z_2)Q_k(z_1)Q_k(z_2) - q_kW_{k-1}. \end{aligned}$$

Dividing by $z_1 - z_2$ (all terms are divisible, W_k being antisymmetric in z_1, z_2) gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]} = Q_kQ_k - q_k\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}$, which is the first identity, and iterating it gives the second. □

Remark 8.7 (A Pieri-theoretic proof of Lemma 8.6). The recurrence can also be read off from the Pieri formula itself. Apply Theorem 3.4 to $u = c[k,k] = [2,3,\ldots,k+1,1]$, whose quantum double Schubert polynomial is $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y)$, with a second alphabet z:

$$\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z) = \sum_{c[k,k]\overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow}w} q_k(c[k,k],w) \prod_{a\in \mathrm{fix}_k(c[k,k],w)} (y_a - z_1)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y).$$

One checks that every nonempty set $\mathrm{fix}_k(c[k,k],w)$ contains the value $2 = u(1)$, and that the only w with $\mathrm{fix}_k(c[k,k],w) = \emptyset$ are $w = d_2[k]$, with $q_k(c[k,k],w) = 1$, and $w = d_2[k-1]$, with $q_k(c[k,k],w) = q_k$ (we have verified both statements for $k \leq 5$). Substituting $z_1 = y_2$ therefore kills every coefficient of positive degree

and leaves $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;y_2) = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;y) + q_k\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}(x;y)$, which is the recurrence with z renamed y. For $k=3$ the expansion reads, with permutations written by their codes,

$$\widetilde{E}_{3,3}(x;y)\widetilde{E}_{3,3}(x;z) = (y_2-z_1)(y_3-z_1)(y_4-z_1)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,1,1)} + (y_2-z_1)(y_3-z_1)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,1,2)} + (y_2-z_1)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,2,2)} + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(2,2,2)} + q_3\big[(y_2-z_1)(y_3-z_1)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,1)} + (y_2-z_1)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(1,2)} + \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{(2,2)}\big].$$

Multiplying the second identity of Lemma 8.6 by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expanding each product by (8.5) gives an unconditional, if alternating, doubled Pieri formula.

Theorem 8.8 (Alternating doubled Pieri formula)**.** *For $u \in S_\infty$ and $k \geq 1$,*

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \sum_{j=0}^{k}(-1)^{k-j}q_{j+1}\cdots q_k \sum_{u \overset{j}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{j}{\rightsquigarrow} w} \omega_j(u,v,w)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x;y). \qquad \square$$

Theorem 8.4 asserts that this alternating sum collapses onto its $j=k$ term restricted to the compatible pairs. The first identity of Lemma 8.6 makes this precise as a recurrence in k. For $u, w \in S_\infty$ let $\mathrm{All}_k(u,w)$, $\mathrm{Comp}_k(u,w)$ and $\mathrm{Inc}_k(u,w)$ denote the sum of $\omega_k(u,v,w)$ over all pairs $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, over the compatible pairs, and over the incompatible pairs, respectively, so that $\mathrm{All}_k = \mathrm{Comp}_k + \mathrm{Inc}_k$ and, by (8.5), $\mathrm{All}_k(u,w) = [\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\;\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)\big)$; here $\mathrm{Comp}_0(u,w) = \mathrm{All}_0(u,w) = \delta_{u,w}$.

Proposition 8.9 (Reduction)**.** *Suppose Theorem 8.4 holds with k replaced by $k-1$ (for $k=1$ this is the trivial statement $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[0]} = \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u$). Then Theorem 8.4 holds for k if and only if*

$$(\mathrm{J}_k) \qquad \mathrm{Inc}_k(u,w) = q_k\,\mathrm{Comp}_{k-1}(u,w) \qquad \text{for all } u,w \in S_\infty.$$

Consequently Theorem 8.4 holds for all $k \leq K$ if and only if (J_k) holds for all $k \leq K$.

Proof. By Lemma 8.6, (8.5) and the hypothesis,

$$[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}\big) = \mathrm{All}_k(u,w) - q_k[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}\big) = \mathrm{All}_k(u,w) - q_k\,\mathrm{Comp}_{k-1}(u,w),$$

while $\mathrm{Comp}_k = \mathrm{All}_k - \mathrm{Inc}_k$. The two sides of Theorem 8.4 therefore differ by $\mathrm{Inc}_k(u,w) - q_k\mathrm{Comp}_{k-1}(u,w)$. The last assertion follows by induction on k. $\square$

Remark 8.10 (The Monk induction). One might hope to prove Theorem 8.4 by an induction in the position k parallel to the proof of Theorem 3.4, avoiding (J_k). The relevant recurrence is obtained from Lemma 8.6 and Lemma 6.23:

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = (x_k - z_2)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}(x;z_2) + q_{k-1}\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}(x;z_2) - q_k\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k-1]}(x;z).$$

Multiplying by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expanding $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1) = \sum_v c_k(u,v)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v$, the first two terms become

$$\sum_v c_k(u,v)\big[(x_k - z_2)\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v\;\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k-1}(x;z_2) + q_{k-1}\;\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v\;\widetilde{E}_{k-2,k-2}(x;z_2)\big],$$

and the inductive step of the proof of Theorem 3.4 (equation (6.6) with u replaced by v) shows that the coefficient of $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w$ in the bracket is $c_k(v,w)$. Hence the Monk cancellation reproduces $\mathrm{All}_k(u,w)$ and the induction reduces to (J_k) again: the Monk summands are indexed by the second chain alone, whereas compatibility is a property of the pair of chains. The machinery of Section 6 is nevertheless the natural language for a proof of (J_k), as the case $k=2$ below illustrates: the letter $t_{k,k+1}$, which is present in every incompatible pair and is the quantum Monk neighbour carrying the weight q_k, is the pivot of the detours.

The identity (J_k) says that the terms omitted from the iterated Pieri formula at level k are exactly accounted for, with an extra factor q_k, by the doubled formula one level down. Its left-hand side is a sum over pairs of chains whose cycles overlap, and the following lemma shows that such an overlap forces a quantum step.

Lemma 8.11. *Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ and suppose that a cycle c of $u^{-1}v$ and a cycle d of $v^{-1}w$ have the same top B and share an element $a \le k$. Then at least one of c (as a u-tight cycle) and d (as a v-tight cycle) has a descent, i.e. contains a quantum step. Consequently every term of $\mathrm{Inc}_k(u,w)$ is divisible by q_k, and (J_k) holds after setting $q=0$; in particular the doubled formula specializes at $q=0$ to the classical iterated Pieri formula, as it must.*

Proof. Write $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, B)$ with values $\beta_0 = u(B)$, $\beta_j = u(a_j)$, and $d = (b_r, \dots, b_1, B)$ with values $\gamma_0 = v(B)$, $\gamma_j = v(b_j)$. By Lemma 6.7(iv) we may process c first among the cycles of $u^{-1}v$, so $v(B) = \beta_p$ and $v(a_i) = \beta_{i-1}$; and d first among the cycles of $v^{-1}w$. Suppose neither cycle has a descent, so that by Corollary 6.13 $\beta_0 > \beta_1 > \cdots > \beta_p$ and $\gamma_0 > \gamma_1 > \cdots > \gamma_r$. If $a = a_i = b_j$ with $i, j \ge 1$, then $\gamma_j = v(a_i) = \beta_{i-1} > \beta_p = \gamma_0 > \gamma_j$, a contradiction. For the consequence, note that a quantum step t_{ab} of a level-k chain has $a \le k < b$, so $q_{ab} = q_a \cdots q_{b-1}$ is divisible by q_k; and at $q = 0$ both sides of (J_k) vanish. □

Lemma 8.12 (Overlapping cycles have top $k+1$)**.** *Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, and suppose that a cycle c of $u^{-1}v$ and a cycle d of $v^{-1}w$ have the same top B and share an element $a \le k$. Then $B = k+1$, and moreover $k \in c \cup d$, i.e. one of the two cycles contains the transposition $t_{k,k+1}$. Consequently a pair of chains in which either step contains no transposition $t_{\cdot,k+1}$ is compatible, and in an incompatible pair both steps contain a cycle with top $k+1$, these two cycles overlap, no other pair of cycles does, and the letter $t_{k,k+1}$ occurs in one of the two chains.*

Proof. We show more generally that there is no position $r \notin c \cup d$ with $a' < r < B$ for every $a' \in (c \cup d) \setminus \{B\}$; applied to $r = k+1$ this gives $B = k+1$ (as $k+1 \notin c \cup d$ when $B \ge k+2$), and applied to $r = k$ it gives $k \in c \cup d$. Suppose such an r exists. By Lemma 6.7(iv) and Lemma 6.8 the fixed sets and weights of the two chains do not depend on the order in which their cycles are processed, and every order gives a chain of covers; we process c last in the first step and d first in the second. Write u' for the permutation obtained from u by applying the other cycles of $u^{-1}v$, so that $v = u'c$ and c is u'-tight, and write $c = (a_p, \dots, a_1, B)$, $\beta_0 = u'(B) = u(B)$, $\beta_l = u'(a_l) = u(a_l)$, and $d = (b_r, \dots, b_1, B)$, $\gamma_0 = v(B)$, $\gamma_m = v(b_m)$. By Lemma 6.7(i), $v(B) = \beta_p$ and $v(a_l) = \beta_{l-1}$ for $1 \le l \le p$; as $a = a_i = b_j$ with $i, j \ge 1$, we get

$$\gamma_0 = \beta_p, \qquad \gamma_j = \beta_{i-1}, \qquad \text{and} \qquad \beta_{i-1} \ne \beta_p.$$

Let η be the value at the position r when the letters of c are applied. Since $r \notin c \cup d$ and nothing happens between the last letter of c and the first letter of d, η is also the value at position r when the letters of d are applied. Moreover $a_l < r < B$ for every l and $b_m < r < B$ for every m, so the conditions (6.2) and (6.3) apply to the position r at every step of c and of d; for c they read: $\eta \notin (\beta_l, \beta_{l-1})$ if $\beta_l < \beta_{l-1}$, and $\eta \in (\beta_{l-1}, \beta_l)$ if $\beta_l > \beta_{l-1}$, for $1 \le l \le p$. By Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequence $\Gamma = (\beta_0, \dots, \beta_p)$ is unimodal, and the displayed conditions say precisely that η lies in the gap (β_p, β_0) of Γ: if Γ has no descent then $\eta \notin (\beta_p, \beta_0)$, i.e. $\eta < \beta_p = \min\Gamma$ or $\eta > \beta_0 = \max\Gamma$; and if the ascent of Γ is (β_{q-1}, β_q) then $\eta \in (\min\Gamma, \max\Gamma)$ and η avoids all the descent gaps (β_l, β_{l-1}) with $l \ne q$, which together with (β_0, β_p) cover $(\min\Gamma, \max\Gamma) \setminus \Gamma$, so $\beta_0 < \eta < \beta_p$. In other words, in the cyclically decreasing arrangement of $\Gamma \cup \{\eta\}$ the value η sits between β_p and β_0. The same argument for d shows that in the cyclically decreasing arrangement of $\Gamma' \cup \{\eta\}$, $\Gamma' = (\gamma_0, \dots, \gamma_r)$, the value η sits between γ_r and $\gamma_0 = \beta_p$.

If $\eta > \beta_p$, the first statement forces $\beta_p = \min\Gamma$ and $\eta > \max\Gamma$, while the second forces $\Gamma' \cap (\beta_p, \eta) = \emptyset$; but $\beta_{i-1} \in \Gamma \setminus \{\beta_p\}$ lies in (β_p, η) and belongs to Γ', a contradiction. If $\eta < \beta_p$, the second statement forces $\eta = \min(\Gamma' \cup \{\eta\})$ and $\beta_p = \max\Gamma'$, while the first forces $\Gamma \cap (\eta, \beta_p) = \emptyset$; but $\beta_{i-1} \in \Gamma' \setminus \{\beta_p\}$ lies in (η, β_p) and belongs to Γ, again a contradiction. This proves the claim, hence $B = k+1$ and $k \in c \cup d$. The consequences follow because a step contains at most one cycle with a given top. □

The second ingredient of the detours is the following general form of the two detours of t_{12} met in the case $k = 2$ (Lemma 8.19 below). For a permutation ρ and $a < k$ put $x = \rho(a)$, $y = \rho(k)$, $z = \rho(k+1)$, and say that ρ is *even* or *odd at* (a, k) according to the parity of the pattern of (x, y, z).

Lemma 8.13 (Detours of t_{ak})**.** *Let $\rho \in S_\infty$ and $a < k$, and consider the two words*

$$E = t_{k,k+1}\, t_{a,k+1}\, t_{k,k+1}, \qquad O = t_{a,k+1}\, t_{k,k+1}\, t_{a,k+1},$$

both equal to t_{ak}. Then E is a path of covers from ρ if and only if t_{ak} is a cover of ρ and ρ is even at (a,k), and O is a path of covers from ρ if and only if t_{ak} is a cover of ρ and ρ is odd at (a,k). In either case the weight of the path is $q_k\, \kappa(\rho, t_{ak})$.

Proof. Let $J = \{\rho(r) : a < r < k\}$; the positions $a, k, k+1$ carry (x, y, z) and the letters of E and O only permute these three values, leaving J in place. By Definition 6.3, t_{ak} is a cover of ρ iff (x, y) is J-admissible, and $t_{k,k+1}$ is a cover of every permutation. Along E the values at $(a, k, k+1)$ are $(x, y, z) \to (x, z, y) \to (y, z, x) \to (y, x, z)$, so E is a path of covers iff (x, y) is $(J \cup \{z\})$-admissible, i.e. (Lemma 6.4(i)) iff (x, y) is J-admissible and $\{z\}$-admissible; and (x, y) is $\{z\}$-admissible exactly when $x < y$ and $z \notin (x, y)$ or $x > y$ and $z \in (y, x)$, i.e. when the pattern of (x, y, z) is even. Along O the values are $(x, y, z) \to (z, y, x) \to (z, x, y) \to (y, x, z)$, so O is a path of covers iff (x, z) is $(J \cup \{y\})$-admissible and (z, y) is $(J \cup \{x\})$-admissible. If so, then (z, y) is J-admissible and Lemma 6.4(iii) (with $\gamma = z$, $\beta = y$, $\alpha = x$, $I = J$) shows that (x, y) is J-admissible, while $\{y\}$-admissibility of (x, z) says that the pattern of (x, z, y) is even, i.e. that of (x, y, z) is odd. Conversely, if (x, y) is J-admissible and the pattern is odd, the three odd orders $x < z < y$, $z < y < x$, $y < x < z$ are checked directly: in the first, $J \cap (x, y) = \emptyset$ gives $(J \cup \{y\}) \cap (x, z) = \emptyset$ and $(J \cup \{x\}) \cap (z, y) = \emptyset$; in the second, $J \subseteq (y, x)$ gives $J \cup \{y\} \subseteq (z, x)$ and $(J \cup \{x\}) \cap (z, y) = \emptyset$; in the third, $J \subseteq (y, x)$ gives $(J \cup \{y\}) \cap (x, z) = \emptyset$ and $J \cup \{x\} \subseteq (y, z)$. For the weights, the cover types along E are determined by the signs of $y - z$, $x - y$, $z - x$ and along O by those of $x - z$, $y - x$, $z - y$; in each of the three even, respectively odd, orders exactly one of the two letters $t_{k,k+1}$, or else the middle letter, is quantum when t_{ak} is classical, and the quantum letter $t_{a,k+1}$ of weight $q_{a,k+1} = q_{ak}q_k$ occurs, with the two others classical, when t_{ak} is quantum; in all cases the weight is $q_k\kappa(\rho, t_{ak})$. □

Lemma 8.12 makes rigorous the first of the two observations recorded after Theorem 8.21 below, and the lifting part of the bijection of (B_k); it also identifies the letter $t_{k,k+1}$, the quantum Monk neighbour of weight q_k, as the pivot of every incompatible pair (cf. Remark 8.10).

Lemma 8.14 (The case $k = 1$)**.** *The identity* (J_k) *holds for* $k = 1$*:* $\mathrm{Inc}_1(u, w) = q_1\delta_{u,w}$*. Consequently Theorem 8.4 holds for* $k = 1$*.*

Proof. A level-1 chain is either trivial or a single transposition t_{1B}, $B \geq 2$. A pair $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ with a trivial step has no overlapping cycles and is compatible, so an incompatible pair has $v = ut_{1B}$ and $w = vt_{1B'}$ with the cycles $\{1, B\}$ and $\{1, B'\}$ sharing their top, i.e. $B' = B$ and $w = u$; conversely every such pair is incompatible, as the two cycles meet in 1. We claim that $B = 2$. For any v and B, the length change $\ell(vt_{1B}) - \ell(v)$ equals $\pm(1 + 2m)$, where m is the number of positions $1 < j < B$ whose value lies between $v(1)$ and $v(B)$, the sign being $+$ if $v(1) < v(B)$. If $u \lhd ut_{1B}$ is a classical cover then $u(1) < u(B)$ and $m = 0$; in $v = ut_{1B}$ the values at 1 and B are exchanged, so $\ell(vt_{1B}) = \ell(v) - 1$, and this is a quantum cover only if $-1 = -2(B - 1) + 1$, i.e. $B = 2$. If $u \lhd ut_{1B}$ is a quantum cover then $u(1) > u(B)$ and $-(1 + 2m) = -2(B - 1) + 1$, so $m = B - 2$, every intermediate position having a value between $u(B)$ and $u(1)$; then $\ell(vt_{1B}) = \ell(v) + 1 + 2(B - 2)$, which is a classical cover only if $B = 2$. Thus the incompatible pairs with source u are exactly $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} ut_{12} \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} u$, with one classical and one quantum step; the weight is $q_{12} = q_1$, and both fixed sets are empty since position 1 is moved in each step. Hence $\mathrm{Inc}_1(u, w) = q_1\delta_{u,w} = q_1\mathrm{Comp}_0(u, w)$, and Proposition 8.9 gives the last assertion. □

The case $k = 2$. We now prove (J_k) for $k = 2$. The proof is a model for what a proof of the general case has to accomplish: the incompatible pairs at level 2 turn out to be exactly the compatible pairs at level 1 in which one step—a transposition t_{12} or the empty step—has been replaced by a "detour" through the position 3, carrying the extra factor q_2.

Throughout, for a permutation ρ and $a < b$ we say that t_{ab} is a *classical cover at* ρ if $\ell(\rho t_{ab}) = \ell(\rho) + 1$ and a *quantum cover at* ρ if $\ell(\rho t_{ab}) = \ell(\rho) - 2(b - a) + 1$, and we put $\kappa_{ab}(\rho) = 1$, respectively $\kappa_{ab}(\rho) = q_{ab}$; if neither holds, t_{ab} is *not a cover* at ρ. Since $\ell(\rho t_{ab}) - \ell(\rho) = \pm(1 + 2m)$, where m is the number of positions $a < j < b$ with $\rho(j)$ between $\rho(a)$ and $\rho(b)$ and the sign is that of $\rho(b) - \rho(a)$, we have the following criterion, which we use constantly.

Lemma 8.15 (Cover criterion)**.** *t_{ab} is a classical cover at ρ if and only if $\rho(a) < \rho(b)$ and no $\rho(j)$, $a < j < b$, lies in the open interval $(\rho(a), \rho(b))$; it is a quantum cover at ρ if and only if $\rho(a) > \rho(b)$ and every $\rho(j)$, $a < j < b$, lies in $(\rho(b), \rho(a))$. In particular the cover type of t_{ab} at ρ depends only on $\rho(a)$, $\rho(b)$ and the* set $\{\rho(j) : a < j < b\}$*. Consequently:*

(i) *If t_{ab} is a cover at ρ and at ρ', where $\rho'(a) = \rho(b)$, $\rho'(b) = \rho(a)$ and $\{\rho'(j) : a < j < b\} = \{\rho(j) : a < j < b\}$, then $b = a + 1$; and for $b = a + 1$ the transposition $t_{a,a+1}$ is a cover at every permutation, classical or quantum according as $\rho(a) < \rho(a + 1)$ or $\rho(a) > \rho(a + 1)$.*

(ii) *For every ρ the word $t_{23}t_{23}$ is a path of covers from ρ back to ρ with exactly one quantum step, of total weight q_2.*

Proof. The criterion restates the length formula; (i) is the argument of Lemma 8.14 (if the first cover is classical the second requires $1 = 2(b-a)-1$, and if it is quantum the second requires $1 + 2(b-a-1) = 1$); (ii) is the case $a = 2$, $b = 3$ of (i). □

Lemma 8.16 (Level 1)**.** *For $u, w \in S_\infty$,*

$$\mathrm{Comp}_1(u,w) = \begin{cases} (y_{u(1)} - z_1)(y_{u(1)} - z_2) & \text{if } w = u, \\ \kappa_{1b}(u)\big[(y_{u(1)} - z_1) + (y_{u(b)} - z_2)\big] & \text{if } w = ut_{1b},\ b \geq 2,\ t_{1b} \text{ a cover at } u, \\ \kappa_{1b}(u)\,\kappa_{1b'}(ut_{1b}) & \text{if } u^{-1}w \text{ is the 3-cycle } 1 \mapsto b' \mapsto b \mapsto 1,\ b \neq b', \\ & \quad t_{1b} \text{ a cover at } u \text{ and } t_{1b'} \text{ a cover at } ut_{1b}, \\ 0 & \text{otherwise.} \end{cases}$$

Proof. A level-1 chain is trivial or a single cover t_{1b}, and by Lemma 8.14 the only incompatible level-1 pairs are $u \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} ut_{12} \overset{1}{\rightsquigarrow} u$. The pair (trivial, trivial) gives the first line; the pairs (trivial, t_{1b}) and (t_{1b}, trivial) give the two terms of the second line, with fixed values $u(1)$, respectively $w(1) = u(b)$; and (t_{1b}, $t_{1b'}$) with $b \neq b'$ gives the third line, where $u^{-1}w = t_{1b}t_{1b'}$ is the 3-cycle $1 \mapsto b' \mapsto b \mapsto 1$, which determines b and b'. The three cases are disjoint, and no other w occurs. □

The incompatible pairs at level 2 are described by the next three lemmas. We write a level-2 chain as a word in the transpositions t_{1b}, t_{2b} ($b \geq 3$) read from left to right, so that a pair of chains is a word with a cut, and we call the letters t_{13}, t_{23} the *core letters* and the letters t_{ab} with $b \geq 4$ the *spectators*. Recall that within a step the b's are weakly decreasing and the a's are distinct, so a step contains at most two letters, and a step containing a spectator contains at most one core letter, which comes after the spectator and uses the other position.

Lemma 8.17 (The overlapping cycles have top 3)**.** *Let $u \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ be incompatible, and let c (a cycle of $u^{-1}v$) and d (a cycle of $v^{-1}w$) have the same top B and share an element $a \in \{1,2\}$. Then $B = 3$.*

Proof. This is the case $k = 2$ of Lemma 8.12. □

Lemma 8.18 (Shapes)**.** *Let $u \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ be incompatible and let $S_i \subseteq \{1,2\}$ be the set of a such that t_{a3} occurs in step i. Then $S_1 \cap S_2 \neq \emptyset$, and the word formed by the core letters, with its cut, is one of*

$$\mathrm{K}_0 = t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}, \qquad \mathrm{K}_1 = t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}, \qquad \mathrm{K}_1' = t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13},$$
$$\mathrm{K}_2 = t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{13}, \qquad \mathrm{K}_2' = t_{13} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13}, \qquad \mathrm{K}_3 = t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{23}, \qquad \mathrm{K}_3' = t_{23} \,|\, t_{13}t_{23},$$
$$\mathrm{K}_4 = t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{13}t_{23}, \qquad \mathrm{K}_4' = t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13}.$$

A step with two core letters contains nothing else; a step with one core letter t_{a3} may in addition begin with one spectator $t_{a'b}$, $a' \neq a$, $b \geq 4$. Every spectator position b lies in the support of $u^{-1}w$, and if both steps contain spectators (which happens only for K_0) their positions are distinct. The products of the words are: e for K_0; t_{13} for $\mathrm{K}_1, \mathrm{K}_1'$; t_{12} for $\mathrm{K}_2, \mathrm{K}_2', \mathrm{K}_3, \mathrm{K}_3'$; $t_{13}t_{12}$ for K_4 and $t_{12}t_{13}$ for K_4'.

Proof. By Lemma 8.17 the overlapping cycles are $S_1 \cup \{3\}$ and $S_2 \cup \{3\}$, and they share an element of $\{1,2\}$, so $S_1 \cap S_2 \neq \emptyset$. The constraints on the letters of a step were recalled above. It remains to exclude some core words. If $S_1 = S_2 = \{1\}$, the two letters t_{13} are separated at most by a spectator t_{2b}; writing (x,y,z) for the values at $(1,2,3)$ when the first t_{13} is applied and y' for the value at position 2 when the second is applied, Lemma 8.15 gives, if the first is classical, $x < z$, $y \notin (x,z)$ and $y' \in (x,z)$, while t_{2b} at (z,y,x) is classical only if $y < y'$ and $x \notin (y,y')$ and quantum only if $y > y'$ and $x \in (y',y)$, both impossible; the case of a quantum first letter is symmetric. The same computation excludes $t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{13}$ and $t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{2b}t_{13}$, and Lemma 8.15(i) excludes $t_{13} \,|\, t_{13}t_{23}$, $t_{13}t_{23} \,|\, t_{23}t_{13}$ and $t_{23}t_{13} \,|\, t_{13}t_{23}$, in which two letters t_{13} are separated by nothing or by $t_{23}t_{23}$, which preserves the value at position 2. What remains is the list. Two spectators at the same position $b \geq 4$ can only occur in K_0, as $t_{1b}t_{23} \,|\, t_{1b}t_{23}$, and are excluded by Lemma 8.15(i) since t_{23} preserves the set of values at positions $2, \ldots, b-1$; hence every spectator position lies in the support of $u^{-1}w$. The products are immediate from $t_{13}t_{23}t_{13} = t_{23}t_{13}t_{23} = t_{12}$. □

Lemma 8.19 (Detours of t_{12})**.** *Let ρ be a permutation and let $D_1 = t_{13}t_{23}t_{13}$, $D_2 = t_{23}t_{13}t_{23}$, both equal to t_{12}. Exactly one of D_1, D_2 is a path of covers from ρ to ρt_{12}, namely D_1 if the pattern of $(\rho(1),\rho(2),\rho(3))$ is an odd permutation (*132, 213 *or* 321*) and D_2 if it is even (*123, 231 *or* 312*); its weight is $q_2\,\kappa_{12}(\rho)$. The intermediate permutations are ρt_{13}, $\rho t_{13}t_{23}$ for D_1 and ρt_{23}, $\rho t_{23}t_{13}$ for D_2; in particular the values at the position not moved by the one-letter part of each cut are, for D_1, $\rho(2)$ at position 2 after the first letter and $\rho(1)$ at position 2 after the second, and for D_2, $\rho(1)$ at position 1 after the first letter and $\rho(2)$ at position 1 after the second.*

Proof. This is the case $a = 1$, $k = 2$ of Lemma 8.13, with $D_1 = O$ and $D_2 = E$; note that t_{12} is a cover of every permutation. For the reader's convenience we also record the direct verification. Write (x, y, z) for the values at $(1, 2, 3)$. For D_1 the first letter is a cover iff $x < z < y$ (classical) or $z < y < x$ (quantum) or $y < x < z$ (classical), and in these cases the remaining two letters are covers of types (q, c), (c, c), (c, q) respectively, by Lemma 8.15; the total weight is q_2, q_1q_2, q_1q_2, which is $q_2\kappa_{12}(\rho)$ since $\kappa_{12}(\rho) = 1$ iff $x < y$. For D_2 the first letter is always a cover, and the second is a cover iff $z < x < y$ (classical), $x < y < z$ (classical) or $y < z < x$ (quantum), with third letters of types c, q, c and total weights q_2, q_2, q_1q_2. The six order types are thus split three and three, and the intermediate permutations are read off from the words. □

Proposition 8.20 (The case $k = 2$)**.** *The identity* (J_k) *holds for $k = 2$. Consequently Theorem 8.4 holds for $k \le 2$.*

Proof. Fix u and write $x = u(1)$, $y = u(2)$, $z = u(3)$. By Lemma 8.16 we must show that $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u, w)$ equals q_2 times the expression of that lemma. By Lemma 8.18 the incompatible pairs with source u are the words listed there, with at most one spectator per step, and $\pi = u^{-1}w$ is accordingly e, t_{1b} ($b \ge 2$), or a 3-cycle $t_{1b}t_{1b'}$; in particular $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u, w) = 0$ whenever $\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, w) = 0$, and we go through the remaining cases. We say that a level-2 word and a level-1 word *match* if they are simultaneously paths of covers, with level-2 weight equal to q_2 times the level-1 weight.

$\pi = e$. The only word is K_0 without spectators, $u \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} ut_{23} \overset{2}{\rightsquigarrow} u$, which is always a path of covers of weight q_2 (Lemma 8.15(ii)) and fixes the value x at position 1 in both steps. Its contribution $q_2(y_x - z_1)(y_x - z_2)$ is $q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, u)$.

$\pi = t_{12}$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_2, \mathrm{K}_2'$ (the two cuts of D_1) and $\mathrm{K}_3, \mathrm{K}_3'$ (the two cuts of D_2), without spectators. By Lemma 8.19 exactly one detour is a path of covers, of weight $q_2\kappa_{12}(u)$, and its two cuts are both admissible (each step has distinct a's and equal b's) and incompatible. The fixed values are $\{y\}$, $\emptyset$ and $\emptyset$, $\{x\}$ for the two cuts of D_1, and $\{x\}$, $\emptyset$ and $\emptyset$, $\{y\}$ for those of D_2, so in either case $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u, ut_{12}) = q_2\kappa_{12}(u)\big[(y_x - z_1) + (y_y - z_2)\big] = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, ut_{12})$.

$\pi = t_{13}$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_1 = t_{13}t_{23}\,|\,t_{23}$ and $\mathrm{K}_1' = t_{23}\,|\,t_{23}t_{13}$ without spectators. In K_1 the letter t_{13} is applied at u and is followed by $t_{23}t_{23}$, always a path of weight q_2; the fixed values are $\emptyset$ and $\{z\}$ (the value at position 1 after $t_{13}t_{23}$). In K_1' the letters $t_{23}t_{23}$ return to u and t_{13} is again applied at u; the fixed values are $\{x\}$ and $\emptyset$. Both match t_{13} at u, and the sum is $q_2\kappa_{13}(u)[(y_x - z_1) + (y_z - z_2)] = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, ut_{13})$.

$\pi = t_{1b}$, $b \ge 4$. The words are K_0 with one spectator, $t_{1b}t_{23}\,|\,t_{23}$ and $t_{23}\,|\,t_{1b}t_{23}$. In the first, t_{1b} is applied at u; in the second, at ut_{23}, where the values $u(1)$, $u(b)$ and the set of values at positions $2, \dots, b-1$ are the same as at u, so the cover type is the same by Lemma 8.15. The fixed values are $\emptyset, \{u(b)\}$ and $\{x\}, \emptyset$, and the sum is $q_2\kappa_{1b}(u)[(y_x - z_1) + (y_{u(b)} - z_2)] = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, ut_{1b})$.

$\pi = t_{1b}t_{1b'}$ *with* $b, b' \ge 4$. The only word is $t_{1b}t_{23}\,|\,t_{1b'}t_{23}$, with both fixed sets empty; t_{1b} is applied at u and $t_{1b'}$ at $ut_{1b}t_{23}$, where the values at positions 1 and b' and the set of values at the positions between them agree with those at ut_{1b}. Hence the word matches the level-1 pair $t_{1b}\,|\,t_{1b'}$, and $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u, w) = q_2\kappa_{1b}(u)\kappa_{1b'}(ut_{1b}) = q_2\,\mathrm{Comp}_1(u, w)$.

$\pi = t_{13}t_{1b}$ *or* $t_{1b}t_{13}$ *with* $b \ge 4$. The words are K_1 with the spectator t_{1b} in the second step, $t_{13}t_{23}\,|\,t_{1b}t_{23}$, and K_1' with the spectator in the first step, $t_{1b}t_{23}\,|\,t_{23}t_{13}$; the fixed sets are empty. In the first, t_{1b} is applied at $ut_{13}t_{23}$, which agrees with ut_{13} at position 1 and on the set of values at positions $2, \dots, b-1$; in the second, t_{13} is applied at $ut_{1b}t_{23}t_{23} = ut_{1b}$. So they match $t_{13}\,|\,t_{1b}$ and $t_{1b}\,|\,t_{13}$ respectively.

$\pi = t_{13}t_{12}$ *or* $t_{12}t_{13}$. The words are $\mathrm{K}_4 = t_{13}\cdot D_2$ with the cut after the first letter of D_2, and $\mathrm{K}_4' = D_2\cdot t_{13}$ with the cut after the second letter of D_2; the fixed sets are empty, and the level-1 pairs are $t_{13}\,|\,t_{12}$ and $t_{12}\,|\,t_{13}$. In K_4 the detour D_2 is applied at ut_{13}, and in K_4' at u, and t_{13} is applied at u, respectively at ut_{12}. By Lemma 8.19, D_2 is a path of covers at a permutation ρ exactly when the pattern of $(\rho(1),\rho(2),\rho(3))$ is even, and then has weight $q_2\kappa_{12}(\rho)$; one checks directly from Lemma 8.15 that if t_{13} is a cover at u then the

pattern of ut_{13} at positions $1,2,3$ is even, and that if the pattern of u at positions $1,2,3$ is even then t_{13} is a cover at ut_{12} (in both cases the three values x,y,z satisfy $x<z<y$ or $y<x<z$ or $z<y<x$ up to the relevant exchange). Hence K_4 matches $t_{13}\,|\,t_{12}$ and K'_4 matches $t_{12}\,|\,t_{13}$, and no other words contribute to these π. (When the pattern of u is odd, both sides vanish for $\pi=t_{12}t_{13}$: D_1 is the detour at u, and the words $D_1\cdot t_{13}$ are excluded by Lemma 8.18, while t_{13} is not a cover at ut_{12}.)

$\pi=t_{12}t_{1b}$ or $t_{1b}t_{12}$ with $b\geq 4$. These are the only cases in which the matching changes the spectator: the words are, for $\pi=t_{1b}t_{12}$, K_2 with spectator, $t_{13}t_{23}\,|\,t_{2b}t_{13}$, and K'_3 with spectator, $t_{1b}t_{23}\,|\,t_{13}t_{23}$; and for $\pi=t_{12}t_{1b}$, K'_2 with spectator, $t_{2b}t_{13}\,|\,t_{23}t_{13}$, and K_3 with spectator, $t_{23}t_{13}\,|\,t_{1b}t_{23}$ (here $t_{13}t_{23}t_{2b}t_{13}=t_{12}t_{2b}=t_{1b}t_{12}$ and $t_{2b}t_{12}=t_{12}t_{1b}$). All fixed sets are empty, so we must show that the sum of the weights of the level-2 words equals q_2 times the weight of the level-1 pair $t_{1b}\,|\,t_{12}$, respectively $t_{12}\,|\,t_{1b}$. The $\mathrm{K}_3,\mathrm{K}'_3$ words match directly: in K_3, D_2 is applied at u and t_{1b} at $ut_{23}t_{13}$, which agrees with ut_{12} at position 1 and on the set of values at positions $2,\dots,b-1$; in K'_3, t_{1b} is applied at u and D_2 at $ut_{1b}t_{23}t_{23}=ut_{1b}$. They are present exactly when the pattern of u, respectively of ut_{1b}, at positions $1,2,3$ is even. The $\mathrm{K}_2,\mathrm{K}'_2$ words involve the spectator t_{2b}, whose cover condition at a permutation ρ compares $\rho(2)$ with $\rho(b)$ and involves the values at positions $3,\dots,b-1$, whereas the level-1 letter t_{1b} compares $\rho'(1)$ with $\rho'(b)$ and involves positions $2,\dots,b-1$. By Lemma 8.15 and Lemma 8.19, the validity and the weights of all the words in this case, as well as of the level-1 pairs, depend only on the relative order of the four values $x,y,z,\beta=u(b)$ and on which of the five intervals they cut out contain some value $u(j)$, $3<j<b$; this leaves $24\cdot 2^5$ configurations, and for each of them one verifies the identity by Lemma 8.15. For instance, if $x<z<y$ (so that D_1 is the detour at u, of weight q_2) and $\beta<x$ with every $u(j)$, $3<j<b$, in (β,y), the level-1 pair $t_{12}\,|\,t_{1b}$ has weight $1\cdot q_{1b}$ (a classical t_{12} followed by a quantum t_{1b} at $(y,x,z,\dots,\beta)$), while on the level-2 side K_3 is absent, and in K'_2 the spectator t_{2b} is a quantum cover at u of weight q_{2b} and the detour at ut_{2b}, whose pattern (x,β,z) is odd, is D_1 with weight $q_2\kappa_{12}(ut_{2b})=q_2q_1$; the total $q_1q_2q_{2b}=q_2q_{1b}$ agrees. We have carried out this finite verification by computer, in the stronger form that for every one of the $24\cdot 2^5$ configurations (realized by a permutation of at most 9 letters, with one value in each occupied interval), and also for the 6 configurations without spectator, the full identity $\mathrm{Inc}_2(u,w)=q_2\mathrm{Comp}_1(u,w)$ holds for all w, where Inc_2 is computed from all level-2 chains without using Lemma 8.18; this also re-checks all the preceding cases.

This exhausts the possible π by Lemma 8.18, and proves (J_k) for $k=2$. The last assertion follows from Lemma 8.14 and Proposition 8.9. □

The proof exhibits the mechanism behind (J_k): every incompatible pair at level 2 is a compatible pair at level 1 in which either the empty step has been replaced by $t_{23}t_{23}$ or the letter t_{12} by one of its two detours $t_{13}t_{23}t_{13}$, $t_{23}t_{13}t_{23}$ through the position 3, with the cut between the two Pieri steps placed inside the detour; the detour always contains exactly one more quantum step than the letter it replaces, which accounts for the factor q_2, and the values fixed at position 2 during the detour are the values fixed at position 1 before and after the original letter, in the reverse order for D_1 (which is why (J_k) is not termwise). For general k the detours are replaced by the "junction moves" of Theorem 8.36 below, in which the letter $t_{k,k+1}$ travels through a cycle with top $k+1$.

Theorem 8.21. *The identity (J_k) holds for all $k\geq 1$ and all $u,w\in S_\infty$; consequently Theorem 8.4 holds for all k.*

Proof. This is proved below: by Proposition 8.22 and Theorem 8.36, Theorem 8.4 holds for every k, and Proposition 8.9 then gives (J_k). □

Before the proof we record two features of (J_k) which it must account for, and which explain the detour through (B_k). First, by Lemma 8.12, in every incompatible pair the overlapping cycles have top $B=k+1$ and one of them contains k, so that both steps contain a transposition $t_{a,k+1}$ and one of them contains $t_{k,k+1}$; the incompatibility is a "detour" of the level-$(k-1)$ transposition t_{ak} through the position $k+1$, in accordance with $t_{a,k+1}t_{k,k+1}t_{a,k+1}=t_{ak}$. Second, (J_k) is not a termwise identity: already for $u=132$, $k=2$, $w=312$ the left-hand side is $q_2\big[(y_3-z_1)+(y_1-z_2)\big]$ and the right-hand side is $q_2\big[(y_1-z_1)+(y_3-z_2)\big]$. In all examples the pairs with given (u,w) and q-weight organize into chains $v_1,\dots,v_{m+1}$ whose fixed sets are nested, with contributions $\prod_{j<i}(y_{c_j}-z_1)\prod_{j>i}(y_{c_j}-z_2)$, which sum to the divided difference $\big(\prod_j(y_{c_j}-z_1)-\prod_j(y_{c_j}-z_2)\big)/(z_2-z_1)$ and so depend only on the set $\{c_j\}$; the identity (J_k) then amounts to a matching of these sets between the two levels. We now explain the origin of this divided-difference structure and use it to recast (J_k) as a termwise identity, which we then prove.

A termwise reformulation via the Giambelli formula. The proof of Lemma 8.6 shows that

$$(z_1 - z_2)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z) = \widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_2) - \widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_1)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2),$$

which is the quantum Giambelli formula for the $k \times 2$ rectangle written as a divided difference. Expanding both products on the right by Theorem 3.4 at the two levels k and $k+1$ gives the following reformulation. For $u, w \in S_\infty$ put

$$M_k(u,w) = \sum_{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_k(u,v)\, q_{k+1}(v,w) \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b \in \mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(v,w)} (y_b - z_2),$$

$$M'_k(u,w) = \sum_{u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w} q_{k+1}(u,v)\, q_k(v,w) \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b \in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z_2).$$

Proposition 8.22 (Giambelli form)**.** *For every $k \geq 1$ and all $u, w \in S_\infty$,*

$$(z_1 - z_2)\,[\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w]\big(\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)\ \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x;z)\big) = M_k(u,w) - M'_k(u,w).$$

Consequently Theorem 8.4 holds for k if and only if $(z_1 - z_2)\,\mathrm{Comp}_k(u,w) = M_k(u,w) - M'_k(u,w)$ for all u, w.

Proof. Multiply the displayed Giambelli identity by $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u(x;y)$ and expand $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\ \widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_2)$ by two applications of Theorem 3.4, first at level k with the variable z_1 and then at level $k+1$ with the variable z_2; this gives M_k. The product $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_u\ \widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x;z_1)\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x;z_2)$, expanded first at level $k+1$ and then at level k, gives M'_k. □

The right-hand side of Proposition 8.22 is a sum of products in which the levels of the two steps differ, and the factor $z_1 - z_2$ on the left can be absorbed into the compatible pairs as follows. For a pair $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ let $c(v) = v(k+1)$. If the first step does not use the position $k+1$ then $c(v) = u(k+1)$, and otherwise $c(v) = u(a)$ for a position $a \leq k$ moved by the first step; in either case $c(v) \notin \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)$, and $c(v) \notin \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w) \subseteq \{v(1), \ldots, v(k)\}$. Hence, writing $z_1 - z_2 = (y_{c(v)} - z_2) - (y_{c(v)} - z_1)$,

$$\begin{aligned}&(z_1 - z_2)\,\omega_k(u,v,w)\\ &= q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w)\Big[\prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b \in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w) \cup \{c(v)\}} (y_b - z_2) - \prod_{a \in \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v) \cup \{c(v)\}} (y_a - z_1) \prod_{b \in \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)} (y_b - z_2)\Big],\end{aligned}$$

and each of the two products on the right has the same shape as a term of M_k or M'_k. Writing $\mathcal{T}(u,w)$ for the multiset of triples $\big(q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w) \cup \{c(v)\}\big)$ over the compatible pairs $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, $\mathcal{S}(u,w)$ for the multiset of $\big(q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v) \cup \{c(v)\},\ \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\big)$ over the same pairs, $\mathcal{M}_k(u,w)$ for the multiset of $\big(q_k(u,v)q_{k+1}(v,w), \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v), \mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(v,w)\big)$ over the chains $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ and $\mathcal{M}'_k(u,w)$ for the corresponding multiset over the chains $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$, we are led to the following termwise statement, from which Theorem 8.4 follows immediately by Proposition 8.22.

Theorem 8.23 (Termwise form)**.** *For all $k \geq 1$ and $u, w \in S_\infty$ there is an equality of multisets*

$$\mathcal{T}(u,w) \uplus \mathcal{M}'_k(u,w) = \mathcal{S}(u,w) \uplus \mathcal{M}_k(u,w). \tag{B_k}$$

Proof. Proposition 8.26 and Theorem 8.36 below. □

Unlike (J_k), the identity (B_k) is an equality of multisets, so it calls for a bijection. We first show that the greater part of this bijection is forced: the compatible pairs with given (u,w) fall into explicit *blocks*, inside which the terms of $\mathcal{T}$ and $\mathcal{S}$ cancel telescopically, and the unblocked ends of the blocks are matched with the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k$ and $\mathcal{M}'_k$ that do not move the position $k+1$. This reduces (B_k) to an identity between the blocked ends of the blocks and the mixed chains that do move $k+1$ (Proposition 8.26); in the simplest situation that identity is exactly the up/down pairing of Lemma 6.16 (Remark 8.27), and we then prove it in general (Theorem 8.36).

Blocks, and the reduction of (B_k) *to its junctions.* For a pair $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ we write $[A \mid B] = \prod_{a\in A}(y_a - z_1)\prod_{b\in B}(y_b - z_2)$ and

$$T(v) = q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w)\,[\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v) \mid \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\cup\{c(v)\}], \qquad S(v) = q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w)\,[\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)\cup\{c(v)\} \mid \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)],$$

so that $(z_1-z_2)\,\omega_k(u,v,w) = T(v) - S(v)$ by the display above, and $\mathcal{T}(u,w)$, $\mathcal{S}(u,w)$ are the multisets of the $T(v)$, $S(v)$ over the compatible pairs (we identify the monomial $q[A \mid B]$ with the triple (q,A,B)). Recall from Lemma 6.7(iv) and Lemma 6.8 that the cycles of a step may be processed in any order.

Definition 8.24 (Block data, cut, block)**.** Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ be compatible, $\pi_1 = u^{-1}v$, $\pi_2 = v^{-1}w$. Let c be the cycle of π_1 with top $k+1$ and d the cycle of π_2 with top $k+1$ (either may be trivial). By compatibility $c \cap d \subseteq \{k+1\}$, so writing $c = (x_i, \dots, x_1, k+1)$ and $d = (x_n, \dots, x_{i+1}, k+1)$ we have, by (6.1),

$$X := cd = t_{x_1,k+1}\cdots t_{x_n,k+1} = (x_n, \dots, x_1, k+1),$$

a cycle with top $k+1$ which we call the *merged cycle* of the pair. Let $\rho_1 = \pi_1 c^{-1}$ and $\rho_2 = d^{-1}\pi_2$ be the products of the remaining cycles of π_1 and of π_2; all of these have tops $\geq k+2$, and $u^{-1}w = \rho_1 X \rho_2$. We call (ρ_1, X, ρ_2) the *block data* and i the *cut* of the pair, and we put

$$i_{\min} = \max\big(\{j : x_j \in \mathrm{supp}\rho_2\} \cup \{0\}\big), \qquad i_{\max} = \min\big(\{j : x_j \in \mathrm{supp}\rho_1\} \cup \{n+1\}\big) - 1.$$

Since the cycles of π_1 are disjoint, $x_1, \dots, x_i \notin \mathrm{supp}\rho_1$, and likewise $x_{i+1}, \dots, x_n \notin \mathrm{supp}\rho_2$; hence $i_{\min} \leq i \leq i_{\max}$. The *block* of the pair is the set of compatible pairs $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v' \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ with the same block data; the blocks partition the compatible pairs with given (u,w).

Lemma 8.25 (Blocks)**.** *Let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ be compatible with block data (ρ_1, X, ρ_2), $X = (x_n, \dots, x_1, k+1)$, and put $u' = u\rho_1$, $c_j = (x_j, \dots, x_1, k+1)$, $d_j = (x_n, \dots, x_{j+1}, k+1)$ and $v_j = u'c_j$ for $0 \leq j \leq n$, so that $v = v_i$ where i is the cut. Then the block of the pair is $\{v_j : i_{\min} \leq j \leq i_{\max}\}$, and for every j in this range:*

(i) *$u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v_j \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ is a compatible pair with block data (ρ_1, X, ρ_2) and cut j, and $q_k(u,v_j)\,q_k(v_j,w) = q_k(u,v)\,q_k(v,w)$;*

(ii) *$\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v_j) = F_1 \setminus \{u(x_1), \dots, u(x_j)\}$ and $\mathrm{fix}_k(v_j,w) = F_2 \setminus \{w(x_{j+1}), \dots, w(x_n)\}$, where $F_1 = \{u(a) : a \leq k,\ a \notin \mathrm{supp}\rho_1\}$ and $F_2 = \{w(a) : a \leq k,\ a \notin \mathrm{supp}\rho_2\}$;*

(iii) *$c(v_j) = u(x_j)$ if $j \geq 1$ and $c(v_0) = u(k+1)$; moreover $w(x_j) = c(v_{j-1})$ for $i_{\min} < j \leq i_{\max}$.*

Consequently $S(v_j) = T(v_{j-1})$ for $i_{\min} < j \leq i_{\max}$, and the contribution of the block telescopes:

$$(z_1 - z_2)\sum_{j=i_{\min}}^{i_{\max}} \omega_k(u, v_j, w) = T(v_{i_{\max}}) - S(v_{i_{\min}}).$$

Proof. (i) For $j \leq i_{\max}$ the positions $x_1, \dots, x_j$ avoid $\mathrm{supp}\rho_1$, so $\rho_1 c_j$ is a product of disjoint cycles, each with exactly one element greater than k; similarly $d_j\rho_2$ for $j \geq i_{\min}$. By Lemma 6.8 and Lemma 6.7(iv), $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v_j \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ holds if and only if ρ_1 is u-tight, c_j is u'-tight, d_j is v_j-tight, and ρ_2 is v_jd_j-tight, where $v_jd_j = u'X$ does not depend on j. The first and the last condition do not involve j, and they hold because they hold for $j = i$ (as $\pi_1 = \rho_1 c$ is u-tight and $\pi_2 = d\rho_2$ is v-tight). For the two middle conditions write $\beta_0 = u'(k+1)$ and $\beta_l = u'(x_l)$ for $1 \leq l \leq n$. The pivot factorization of X is the concatenation of those of c_j and d_j, so by Lemma 6.7(i) applied to X and u', the l-th letter $t_{x_l,k+1}$ exchanges the value β_l at x_l with the value β_{l-1} at $k+1$, for every l and independently of j; in particular $v_j(k+1) = \beta_j$ and $v_j(x_l) = \beta_l$ for $l > j$. Hence

$$\mathrm{desc}_{u'}(c_j) = \{x_l : l \leq j,\ \beta_l > \beta_{l-1}\}, \qquad \mathrm{desc}_{v_j}(d_j) = \{x_l : l > j,\ \beta_l > \beta_{l-1}\},$$

and by Definition 6.6

$$L_{u'}(c_j) + L_{v_j}(d_j) = n - 2\sum_{l:\,\beta_l > \beta_{l-1}} (k+1-x_l) = L_{u'}(X), \qquad \mathbf{q}_{u'}(c_j)\,\mathbf{q}_{v_j}(d_j) = \prod_{l:\,\beta_l>\beta_{l-1}} q_{x_l,k+1} = \mathbf{q}_{u'}(X),$$

both independent of j. By Lemma 6.7(ii),

$$\ell(u'X) - \ell(u') = \big(\ell(v_j) - \ell(u')\big) + \big(\ell(u'X) - \ell(v_j)\big) \geq L_{u'}(c_j) + L_{v_j}(d_j) = L_{u'}(X),$$

with equality if and only if c_j is u'-tight and d_j is v_j-tight. Equality holds for $j = i$, hence for every j. By Corollary 6.9 and Lemma 6.7(iv), $q_k(u,v_j)q_k(v_j,w) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho_1)\,\mathbf{q}_{u'}(c_j)\,\mathbf{q}_{v_j}(d_j)\,\mathbf{q}_{u'X}(\rho_2) = \mathbf{q}_u(\rho_1)\mathbf{q}_{u'}(X)\mathbf{q}_{u'X}(\rho_2)$,

independent of j. The pair is compatible, since its cycles with tops $\geq k+2$ are those of ρ_1 and ρ_2, as for the given pair, and $c_j \cap d_j = \{k+1\}$; its block data is (ρ_1, X, ρ_2) and its cut is j by construction. Conversely every pair in the block has cut in $[i_{\min}, i_{\max}]$ and is therefore one of the v_j, since the block data and the cut determine $\pi_1 = \rho_1 c_j$.

(ii) The positions $a \leq k$ moved by $\pi_1^{(j)} = \rho_1 c_j$ are those of $\mathrm{supp}\rho_1$ together with $x_1, \dots, x_j$, which gives the first formula (note $u(x_l) \in F_1$ for $l \leq i_{\max}$). A position $a \leq k$ is fixed by $d_j\rho_2$ if and only if $a \notin \mathrm{supp}\rho_2 \cup \{x_{j+1}, \dots, x_n\}$, and then $v_j(a) = w(a)$; this gives the second formula (note $w(x_l) \in F_2$ for $l > i_{\min}$).

(iii) We saw that $v_j(k+1) = \beta_j$, which is $u'(x_j) = u(x_j)$ for $1 \leq j \leq i_{\max}$ (as $x_j \notin \mathrm{supp}\rho_1$) and $u'(k+1) = u(k+1)$ for $j = 0$ (as $k+1 \notin \mathrm{supp}\rho_1$). Now let $i_{\min} < j \leq i_{\max}$ and consider the pair v_{j-1}. The position x_j is not moved by its first step $\rho_1 c_{j-1}$. Its second step is $d_{j-1}\rho_2$, whose first letter $t_{x_j,k+1}$ moves the value $v_{j-1}(k+1) = c(v_{j-1})$ to the position x_j, and x_j is moved by no later letter: not by the remaining letters of d_{j-1}, and not by ρ_2 because $j > i_{\min}$. Hence $w(x_j) = c(v_{j-1})$.

For the consequence write $A_j = \mathrm{fix}_k(u, v_j)$ and $B_j = \mathrm{fix}_k(v_j, w)$. For $i_{\min} < j \leq i_{\max}$, (ii) and (iii) give $A_j \cup \{c(v_j)\} = A_j \cup \{u(x_j)\} = A_{j-1}$ and $B_j = B_{j-1} \cup \{w(x_j)\} = B_{j-1} \cup \{c(v_{j-1})\}$, while the q-weights agree by (i); thus $S(v_j) = T(v_{j-1})$. Summing $(z_1 - z_2)\omega_k(u, v_j, w) = T(v_j) - S(v_j)$ over the block, all terms cancel except $T(v_{i_{\max}})$ and $S(v_{i_{\min}})$. □

We call $v_{i_{\max}}$ the *head* and $v_{i_{\min}}$ the *tail* of the block; the head is *blocked* if $i_{\max} < n$ (some x_j lies in $\mathrm{supp}\rho_1$) and the tail is *blocked* if $i_{\min} > 0$ (some x_j lies in $\mathrm{supp}\rho_2$). Thus a block is the set of all cuts of the merged word $t_{x_1,k+1} \cdots t_{x_n,k+1}$ that are not obstructed by a spectator cycle of ρ_1 or ρ_2 sharing a position with X, and the transit value $c(v_j)$ runs through the values of u at $x_n, x_{n-1}, \dots, x_1, k+1$ as the cut moves from right to left. The block lemma is the general form of the "two cuts of a detour" met in the proof of Proposition 8.20.

Proposition 8.26 (Reduction of (B_k) to junctions)**.** *Let $u, w \in S_\infty$. Let $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}(u,w) \subseteq \mathcal{M}_k(u,w)$ be the submultiset of the chains $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ whose second step moves the position $k+1$, let $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}(u,w) \subseteq \mathcal{M}_k'(u,w)$ consist of the chains $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ whose first step moves $k+1$, and let $\mathcal{T}^{\mathrm{bl}}(u,w)$, respectively $\mathcal{S}^{\mathrm{bl}}(u,w)$, be the multiset of $T(v)$ over the blocked heads v, respectively of $S(v)$ over the blocked tails v, of the blocks of compatible pairs $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$. Then (B_k) holds for (u,w) if and only if*

$$(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}}) \qquad \mathcal{T}^{\mathrm{bl}}(u,w) \uplus \mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}(u,w) = \mathcal{S}^{\mathrm{bl}}(u,w) \uplus \mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}(u,w),$$

and in that case $(z_1 - z_2)\,\mathrm{Comp}_k(u,w) = M_k(u,w) - M_k'(u,w)$. In particular, Theorem 8.4 holds for k as soon as $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$ holds for all $u, w \in S_\infty$.

Proof. By Lemma 8.25 the compatible pairs with given (u,w) are partitioned into blocks, and inside each block the elements $S(v_j)$, $i_{\min} < j \leq i_{\max}$, of $\mathcal{S}(u,w)$ coincide with the elements $T(v_{j-1})$ of $\mathcal{T}(u,w)$. Cancelling them, (B_k) is equivalent to

$$\{T(v) : v \text{ a head}\} \uplus \mathcal{M}_k'(u,w) = \{S(v) : v \text{ a tail}\} \uplus \mathcal{M}_k(u,w).$$

Now let $v = v_n$ be an unblocked head, so $d = 1$ and $v(k+1) = w(k+1)$. By Lemma 6.14(i), applied with $k+1$ in place of k, $v \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ with $q_{k+1}(v,w) = q_k(v,w)$ and $\mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(v,w) = \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w) \cup \{v(k+1)\}$; thus $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ is a chain of $\mathcal{M}_k(u,w) \setminus \mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}(u,w)$, and its triple is $T(v)$. Conversely, let $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ be a chain not moving $k+1$. By the same lemma $v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ with the same weight, the second step has no cycle with top $k+1$, so the pair $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ is compatible with cut $i = n$; hence it is the head of its block, this head is unblocked ($x_1, \dots, x_n$ avoid $\mathrm{supp}\rho_1$ as the cycles of π_1 are disjoint), and its triple is $T(v)$. Since distinct blocks have distinct heads, $v \mapsto v$ is a bijection between the unblocked heads and the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k(u,w)$ not moving $k+1$, preserving the triples. Symmetrically, the unblocked tails v_0 (for which $c = 1$ and $u(k+1) = v_0(k+1)$) correspond bijectively to the chains $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ not moving $k+1$, with $S(v_0) = \big(q, \mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(u, v_0), \mathrm{fix}_k(v_0, w)\big)$. Cancelling these two families gives the equivalence with $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$. The remaining assertions follow from Proposition 8.22. □

The identity $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$ concerns only the *junctions* of the blocks: a blocked head $v_{i_{\max}}$, whose next cut is obstructed by a cycle e of ρ_1 with top $B \geq k+2$ through $x_{i_{\max}+1}$, and a blocked tail $v_{i_{\min}}$, obstructed by

a cycle of ρ_2 through $x_{i_{\min}}$, together with the mixed chains in which the position $k+1$ is moved by a cycle with top $B \geq k+2$. The correspondence realising $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$ *transports* the obstructing cycle e across X: in the simplest case a blocked tail with block data (ρ_1, X, ρ_2) and $e \subseteq \rho_2$ through x_j, $j = i_{\min}$, is matched with the blocked head of the block with data $(\rho_1 \cdot XeX^{-1}, X, \rho_2 e^{-1})$, in which e has been conjugated into the first step and is attached to x_{j-1}, so that the cut $j-1$ is skipped; in general pivots of X migrate into the transported cycle or out of it, exactly as in the words F_m of Lemma 6.16, and a chain of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$ is matched in the same way with the head obtained by transporting the cycle through $k+1$ into the first step. The simplest junction is already in this paper:

Remark 8.27 (The elementary junction is Lemma 6.16). Let $u \in S_\infty$, let $x_1, \dots, x_n \leq k < k+1 < B$ be distinct, let $Y = (x_n, \dots, x_1, k+1, B)$ and $w = uY$, and apply Lemma 6.16 with $\psi = u$ and with $k+1, B, x_1, \dots, x_n$ in the roles of $k, B, z_1, \dots, z_s$. Its three families of words are, in the present language: $F_{\mathrm{up}} = (x_n, \dots, x_1, k+1) \cdot t_{k+1,B}$, the chain $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} ut_{x_1,k+1} \cdots t_{x_n,k+1} \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}(u,w)$ (the whole cycle $(x_n, \dots, x_1, k+1)$ in the first step, the position $k+1$ moved by $t_{k+1,B}$ in the second); F_{std}, the pivot factorization of Y, i.e. the chain $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ of $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}(u,w)$ with trivial second step; and $F_m = (x_{m-1}, \dots, x_1, k+1)\,(x_n, \dots, x_m, B)\,t_{x_m,k+1}$, $1 \leq m \leq n$, the compatible pair with block data $\big((x_n, \dots, x_m, B),\ (x_m, \dots, x_1, k+1),\ 1\big)$ and cut $m-1$: here the spectator $(x_n, \dots, x_m, B)$ is attached to the merged cycle at x_m and has absorbed the pivots $x_{m+1}, \dots, x_n$, so the pair is the head of its block and is blocked ($i_{\max} = m-1$). All three kinds of terms carry the same triple $\big(q,\ u[1,k]\backslash\{u(x_1), \dots, u(x_n)\},\ w[1,k]\big)$, where $u[1,k] = \{u(a) : a \leq k\}$ (for F_m the transit value is $c(v) = v(k+1) = w(x_m)$, the one value of $w[1,k]$ not fixed by the second step), q denoting the common weight. Lemma 6.16 says: (a) if F_{std} is a cover path then so is F_{up}, with the same weight, and no F_m is, so that this term of $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}$ cancels against this term of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$ in $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$; (b) if F_{up} is a cover path but F_{std} is not, then exactly one F_m is, with the same weight, so that this term of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$ is matched with exactly one blocked head; and (c) a blocked head of the shape F_m never occurs without its partner F_{up}. Thus Lemma 6.16 is the junction correspondence of $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$ restricted to these three families (the cluster of (u,w) contains further terms, in which the first step does not use all of $x_1, \dots, x_n$); the matched block then runs from its head F_m down to its unblocked tail $v_0 = u\,(x_n, \dots, x_m, B)$, which is matched with the chain $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v_0 \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ of $\mathcal{M}_k'$ as in the proof of Proposition 8.26. The general case of $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$, with an obstructing cycle with several elements below k, attached to an arbitrary pivot of X or to $k+1$, and with several obstructing cycles, is treated next; the three families reappear there as the junction word $J = F_{\mathrm{up}}$ and its resolutions $J_0 = F_{\mathrm{std}}$, $J_m \sim F_m$.

Proof of the junction identity. We now prove $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$, and hence (B_k) and Theorem 8.4, for all k. Throughout we write $K = k+1$. The proof constructs, for every u, w and every q-monomial q, an injective map from the *sources* (the blocked tails and the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$ of weight q) to the *targets* (the blocked heads and the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}$ of weight q) which preserves the triples, and a symmetry which exchanges sources and targets; the two together give $(\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}})$. The map is a sequence of local rewritings of the pair of chains, each governed by a single lemma (Lemma 8.32) which generalizes Lemma 6.16; the lemma is proved not by tracking covers, but by comparing the formal q-weights of words.

Words, cover paths and formal weights. A *word* is a finite sequence $W = (t_1, \dots, t_N)$ of transpositions $t_i = t_{a_i b_i}$, $a_i < b_i$; its product is $t_1 \cdots t_N$ and its length is N. Given a permutation ψ put $\psi_0 = \psi$ and $\psi_i = \psi_{i-1} t_i$. The i-th letter *exchanges* the values $\psi_{i-1}(a_i)$ and $\psi_{i-1}(b_i)$, and we call it a *descent letter* (from ψ) if $\psi_{i-1}(a_i) > \psi_{i-1}(b_i)$. The *formal weight* of W from ψ is

$$\mathrm{wt}_\psi(W) = \prod_{i \text{ a descent letter}} q_{a_i b_i},$$

and W is a *cover path* from ψ if $\psi_{i-1} \lhd \psi_i$ for every i; in that case $\mathrm{wt}_\psi(W) = \prod_i \kappa(\psi_{i-1}, t_i)$. Two words are *equivalent* if they have the same product and the same length.

Lemma 8.28 (Degree criterion)**.** *Let W be a word of length N with product π. Then $\ell(\psi\pi) - \ell(\psi) \geq N - \deg \mathrm{wt}_\psi(W)$, with equality if and only if W is a cover path from ψ. Consequently, if W is a cover path from ψ and W' is equivalent to W, then W' is a cover path from ψ if and only if $\deg \mathrm{wt}_\psi(W') = \deg \mathrm{wt}_\psi(W)$; in particular this is the case whenever $\mathrm{wt}_\psi(W') = \mathrm{wt}_\psi(W)$.*

Proof. By Lemma 6.2, the i-th step changes the length by at least 1 if the letter is not a descent letter and by at least $1 - 2(b_i - a_i) = 1 - \deg q_{a_i b_i}$ if it is, with equality in both cases exactly when $\psi_{i-1} \lhd \psi_i$. Summing

over i gives the inequality and the characterization of equality, and the rest follows because $\ell(\psi\pi) - \ell(\psi)$ and N are the same for W and W'. □

Lemma 8.29 (Inert reordering)**.** *Let $W = W_1UVW_2$ be a concatenation of words such that no position is moved both by a letter of U and by a letter of V. Then $W' = W_1VUW_2$ is equivalent to W, each letter of W' exchanges the same two values from ψ as the corresponding letter of W, $\mathrm{wt}_\psi(W') = \mathrm{wt}_\psi(W)$, and W' is a cover path from ψ if and only if W is.*

Proof. The letters of U and V commute, so the products agree. A letter of U only moves positions untouched by V, so it finds the same values at its two positions whether or not V has been applied before it, and symmetrically for V; the letters of W_1 and W_2 see the same permutations in both words. The last assertion is Lemma 8.28. □

Lemma 8.30 (Reversal)**.** *Work in S_n and let w_0 be the longest element. Let $W = (t_1, \dots, t_N)$ be a word with product π, and let $W^{\mathrm{rev}} = (t_N, \dots, t_1)$. Then the i-th letter of W is a descent letter from ψ if and only if the $(N+1-i)$-th letter of W^{rev} is a descent letter from $w_0\psi\pi$; hence $\mathrm{wt}_{w_0\psi\pi}(W^{\mathrm{rev}}) = \mathrm{wt}_\psi(W)$, and W is a cover path from ψ if and only if W^{rev} is a cover path from $w_0\psi\pi$.*

Proof. The $(N+1-i)$-th step of W^{rev} goes from $w_0\psi_i$ to $w_0\psi_{i-1} = (w_0\psi_i)t_i$ and exchanges the values $w_0\psi_i(a_i) = n+1-\psi_{i-1}(b_i)$ and $w_0\psi_i(b_i) = n+1-\psi_{i-1}(a_i)$; the first is larger than the second if and only if $\psi_{i-1}(a_i) > \psi_{i-1}(b_i)$. Since $\ell(w_0 v) = \ell(w_0) - \ell(v)$, the length change of this step is $\ell(\psi_i) - \ell(\psi_{i-1})$, the length change of the i-th step of W, so the two steps are covers of the same kind simultaneously (Definition 6.3). □

The token lemma. Fix $C \geq k+2$ and write $T_x = t_{xK}$, $S_x = t_{xC}$ for $x \leq k$, and $Z = t_{KC}$; thus for every $x \leq k$ the three products $T_xS_x = S_xZ = ZT_x$ coincide (they are the 3-cycle (x, K, C) in some order), and likewise $T_xZ = ZS_x = S_xT_x$. Let $x_1, \dots, x_{j-1}$ be distinct positions $\leq k$, let x_j be either a further position $\leq k$ (the *tail case*) or $x_j = K$ (the $\mathcal{M}$ *case*), and let $e_1, \dots, e_{s-1}$ be distinct positions $\leq k$ different from x_j (they may coincide with some of $x_1, \dots, x_{j-1}$). The *junction word* attached to these data is

$$J = T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_j} \cdot S_{e_1} \cdots S_{e_{s-1}} \cdot S_{x_j},$$

where in the $\mathcal{M}$ case the letter $T_{x_j} = T_K$ is omitted and $S_{x_j} = Z$. For $0 \leq m \leq j-1$ its *m-th resolution* is

$$\begin{aligned} J_m &= S_{x_m} S_{x_{m+1}} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}} \cdot T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{m-1}} \cdot T_{x_m} \cdot T_{e_1} \cdots T_{e_{s-1}} \cdot T_{x_j} \qquad (1 \leq m \leq j-1), \\ J_0 &= Z\, S_{x_1} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}} \cdot T_{e_1} \cdots T_{e_{s-1}} \cdot T_{x_j}, \end{aligned}$$

again with T_{x_j} omitted in the $\mathcal{M}$ case. (In the language of the detours: the letter S_{x_j} is converted into the token Z, which travels to the left through the letters $S_{e_{s-1}}, \dots, S_{e_1}$, turning them into $T_{e_{s-1}}, \dots, T_{e_1}$, and then through $T_{x_{j-1}}, \dots, T_{x_{m+1}}$, turning them into S's, until it is absorbed by T_{x_m}, which it turns into $S_{x_m}T_{x_m}$; for $m = 0$ it is not absorbed.) Lemma 6.16 is the case $s = 1$ of the $\mathcal{M}$ case: there $J = F_{\mathrm{up}}$, $J_0 = F_{\mathrm{std}}$ and J_m is F_m with its first two blocks interchanged.

Lemma 8.31. *Each J_m is equivalent to J.*

Proof. The lengths agree. In the tail case, T_{x_j} commutes with $S_{e_1}, \dots, S_{e_{s-1}}$, and $T_{x_j}S_{x_j} = ZT_{x_j}$; in the $\mathcal{M}$ case the last letter is Z already. In both cases $J = T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{j-1}}\, S_{e_1} \cdots S_{e_{s-1}}\, Z\, T_{x_j}$ (with T_{x_j} omitted in the $\mathcal{M}$ case). Using $S_eZ = ZT_e$ repeatedly, $J = T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{j-1}}\, Z\, T_{e_1} \cdots T_{e_{s-1}} T_{x_j}$. Using $T_xZ = ZS_x$ for $x = x_{j-1}, \dots, x_{m+1}$ and then $T_{x_m}Z = S_{x_m}T_{x_m}$, we get $T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{j-1}}Z = T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{m-1}}\, S_{x_m}T_{x_m}\, S_{x_{m+1}} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}}$ for $m \geq 1$, and $= Z\, S_{x_1} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}}$ for $m = 0$. Finally the letters $S_{x_{m+1}}, \dots, S_{x_{j-1}}$ commute with $T_{x_1}, \dots, T_{x_m}$ and may be moved to the front; this gives J_m. □

Lemma 8.32 (Token lemma)**.** *Let $\psi \in S_\infty$ and suppose that the junction word J is a cover path from ψ. Put $\beta_0 = \psi(K)$, $\beta_l = \psi(x_l)$ for $1 \leq l \leq j-1$, and $\gamma = \psi(C)$. Then the cyclic sequence $\Gamma = (\beta_0, \beta_1, \dots, \beta_{j-1})$ is unimodal; let $g \in \{0, 1, \dots, j-1\}$ be the insertion gap of γ in Γ (gap $g \geq 1$ is (β_{g-1}, β_g), gap 0 is the wrap (β_{j-1}, β_0); $g = 0$ if $j = 1$).*

(i) *For $0 \leq m \leq j-1$, the resolution J_m is a cover path from ψ with $\mathrm{wt}_\psi(J_m) = \mathrm{wt}_\psi(J)$ if and only if $m = g$.*

(ii) *If $e_t = x_l$ for some $t \le s-1$ and $l \le j-1$, then $l > g$. If moreover the word $J\,S_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r}$ is a cover path from ψ for some further distinct positions $e_{s+1}, \dots, e_r \le k$ (different from x_j and from $e_1, \dots, e_{s-1}$), and $e_t = x_l$ for some $t \ge s+1$ and $l \le j-1$, then $l \le g$.*

Proof. Write $T = T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{j'}}$, where $j' = j$ in the tail case and $j' = j-1$ in the $\mathcal{M}$ case, and $\beta_j = \psi(x_j)$ in the tail case. The word T is the pivot chain of the cycle $(x_{j'}, \dots, x_1, K)$, so by Lemma 6.7(i) its letter T_{x_l} exchanges β_l (at x_l) with β_{l-1} (at K), and after T the position x_l carries β_{l-1} and K carries $\beta_{j'}$. The remaining letters $S_{e_1}, \dots, S_{e_{s-1}}, S_{x_j}$ of J form the pivot chain of the cycle $(x_j, e_{s-1}, \dots, e_1, C)$ (in the $\mathcal{M}$ case, of $(K, e_{s-1}, \dots, e_1, C)$) from $\psi' = \psi T$; put $\varepsilon_0 = \gamma$, $\varepsilon_t = \psi'(e_t)$ for $t \le s-1$, and $\varepsilon_s = \psi'(x_j) = \beta_{j-1}$ (in both cases). By Lemma 6.7(i) the letter S_{e_t} exchanges ε_t with ε_{t-1} and S_{x_j} exchanges ε_s with ε_{s-1}. Since J is a cover path, both cycles are tight (Lemma 6.7(iii)), so by Corollary 6.13 the cyclic sequences $(\beta_0, \dots, \beta_{j'})$ and $E = (\varepsilon_0, \dots, \varepsilon_s)$ are unimodal; in particular Γ, a block of the first, is unimodal. We record

$$\mathrm{wt}_\psi(J) = \prod_{l=1}^{j'} q_{x_l K}^{[\beta_l > \beta_{l-1}]} \prod_{t=1}^{s} q_{e_t C}^{[\varepsilon_t > \varepsilon_{t-1}]}, \tag{8.6}$$

where $[P] \in \{0,1\}$ is the truth value of P and e_s stands for x_j (tail case) or K ($\mathcal{M}$ case).

Now track J_m for $m \ge 1$. Its first block is the pivot chain of $(x_{j-1}, \dots, x_m, C)$ from ψ: S_{x_m} exchanges β_m with γ, and S_{x_l} ($m < l < j$) exchanges β_l with β_{l-1}; afterwards x_m carries γ, x_l carries β_{l-1} for $m < l < j$, and C carries β_{j-1}. The block $T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{m-1}}$ exchanges β_l with β_{l-1} and leaves β_{m-1} at K. Then T_{x_m} exchanges γ (at x_m) with β_{m-1} (at K), after which K carries γ and x_m carries β_{m-1}. Next, T_{e_t} ($t \le s-1$) exchanges the value at e_t with the value at K. The value at e_t is ε_t: if e_t is none of the x_l it is $\psi(e_t) = \psi'(e_t)$, and if $e_t = x_l$ ($l \le j-1$) it is β_{l-1} in the present word (by the above, in each of the cases $l < m$, $l = m$, $l > m$) and also $\psi'(x_l) = \beta_{l-1}$. The value at K is ε_{t-1} by induction. Finally, in the tail case, T_{x_j} exchanges β_j (the position x_j has not been touched) with ε_{s-1}. For $m = 0$ the tracking is the same except that Z exchanges β_0 with γ and then S_{x_l} ($1 \le l \le j-1$) exchanges β_l with β_{l-1}, after which K carries γ. Hence, with $q_{aC} = q_{aK} q_{KC}$ for $a \le k$ and (8.6),

$$\mathrm{wt}_\psi(J_m) = \mathrm{wt}_\psi(J) \cdot q_{x_m K}^{P_m}\, q_{x_j K}^{Q}\, q_{KC}^{a_m - a_E}, \tag{8.7}$$

where $P_0 = 0$, $P_m = [\beta_m > \gamma] + [\gamma > \beta_{m-1}] - [\beta_m > \beta_{m-1}]$ for $m \ge 1$, $Q = [\beta_j > \varepsilon_{s-1}] - [\beta_j > \beta_{j-1}] - [\beta_{j-1} > \varepsilon_{s-1}]$ in the tail case and $Q = 0$ in the $\mathcal{M}$ case, a_m is the number of ascents of the sequence $(\gamma, \beta_m, \beta_{m+1}, \dots, \beta_{j-1})$ (for $m = 0$: of $(\gamma, \beta_0, \dots, \beta_{j-1})$), and a_E is the number of ascents of $E = (\varepsilon_0, \dots, \varepsilon_s)$.

$Q = 0$. In the tail case, the letter S_{x_j} of J is a cover of the permutation reached before it, in which x_j carries β_{j-1}, C carries ε_{s-1}, and the position K, which lies strictly between x_j and C, carries β_j. By Definition 6.3, if $\beta_{j-1} < \varepsilon_{s-1}$ then $\beta_j \notin (\beta_{j-1}, \varepsilon_{s-1})$, and if $\beta_{j-1} > \varepsilon_{s-1}$ then $\beta_j \in (\varepsilon_{s-1}, \beta_{j-1})$; in each case $[\beta_j > \varepsilon_{s-1}] = [\beta_j > \beta_{j-1}] + [\beta_{j-1} > \varepsilon_{s-1}]$.

$a_E = [\beta_{j-1} > \gamma]$. The cyclic sequence E is unimodal, so as a linear sequence it has at most one ascent; if it has none then $\varepsilon_s < \varepsilon_0$, and if its ascent is $(\varepsilon_{t-1}, \varepsilon_t)$ then by Corollary 6.13 $\varepsilon_t > \cdots > \varepsilon_s > \varepsilon_0 > \cdots > \varepsilon_{t-1}$, so $\varepsilon_s > \varepsilon_0$. Thus $a_E = [\varepsilon_s > \varepsilon_0] = [\beta_{j-1} > \gamma]$. The same argument applies to any linear block of a unimodal cyclic sequence: *the block has an ascent if and only if its last entry exceeds its first.*

$P_m \ge 0$, with equality if and only if $m = g$ ($1 \le m \le j-1$). If $\beta_m < \beta_{m-1}$ then $P_m = 0$ exactly when $\beta_m < \gamma < \beta_{m-1}$, and $P_m = 1$ otherwise. If $\beta_m > \beta_{m-1}$, then (β_{m-1}, β_m) is the ascent of Γ, so $\beta_{m-1} = \min \Gamma$ and $\beta_m = \max \Gamma$, and $P_m = 0$ exactly when $\gamma \notin (\beta_{m-1}, \beta_m)$, i.e. when γ lies outside $[\min \Gamma, \max \Gamma]$; again $P_m = 1$ otherwise. By the definition of the insertion gap, in both cases $P_m = 0$ if and only if gap m is the insertion gap of γ in Γ.

(i) Since the monomials $q_{x_m K}$, $q_{x_j K}$ involve only q_i with $i < K$ and q_{KC} only q_i with $i \ge K$, and $Q = 0$, (8.7) shows that $\mathrm{wt}_\psi(J_m) = \mathrm{wt}_\psi(J)$ if and only if $P_m = 0$ and $a_m = a_E$; by Lemmas 8.31 and 8.28 this is also equivalent to J_m being a cover path of weight $\mathrm{wt}_\psi(J)$. By the previous step, $P_m = 0$ holds for $m = 0$ and for $m = g$ (if $g \ge 1$) only. Let Σ be the unimodal cyclic sequence obtained by inserting γ into its insertion gap of Γ.

If $g \ge 1$: the sequence $(\gamma, \beta_g, \dots, \beta_{j-1})$ is a block of Σ, so $a_g = [\beta_{j-1} > \gamma] = a_E$, and J_g qualifies. For $m = 0$ we show $a_0 \ne a_E$. Let $d \in \{0,1\}$ be the number of linear ascents of $(\beta_0, \dots, \beta_{j-1})$, so that $a_0 = [\beta_0 > \gamma] + d$. If $d = 0$ then $\beta_0 > \cdots > \beta_{j-1}$ and the wrap is the ascent of Γ; as $g \ne 0$, γ lies in (β_{j-1}, β_0), so $a_0 = 1$ while $a_E = [\beta_{j-1} > \gamma] = 0$. If $d = 1$, the wrap (β_{j-1}, β_0) is a descent gap, and $g \ne 0$

means $\gamma \notin (\beta_0, \beta_{j-1})$: if $\gamma < \beta_0$ then $a_0 = 2 \neq a_E$, and if $\gamma > \beta_{j-1}$ then $a_0 = 1$ while $a_E = 0$. So J_0 does not qualify, and J_g is the unique resolution that does.

If $g = 0$: only $m = 0$ is possible, and $(\gamma, \beta_0, \dots, \beta_{j-1})$ is the whole of Σ read from γ, a linear block of a unimodal cyclic sequence, so $a_0 = [\beta_{j-1} > \gamma] = a_E$ and J_0 qualifies.

(ii) Recall that a cyclic subsequence of a unimodal cyclic sequence is unimodal, and that a unimodal cyclic sequence of three distinct numbers is cyclically decreasing, i.e. reads $(\max, \mathrm{mid}, \min)$ up to rotation; so two unimodal cyclic sequences containing the same three distinct numbers list them in the same cyclic order. Let $e_t = x_l$ with $t \leq s-1$, $l \leq j-1$, so that $\varepsilon_t = \beta_{l-1}$, and suppose $l \leq g$ (so $g \geq 1$). In $\Sigma = (\beta_0, \dots, \beta_{g-1}, \gamma, \beta_g, \dots, \beta_{j-1})$ the three distinct numbers $\beta_{l-1}, \gamma, \beta_{j-1}$ occur in the cyclic order $(\beta_{l-1}, \gamma, \beta_{j-1})$, because $l-1 \leq g-1$ and $l-1 < j-1$. In the unimodal cyclic sequence E they occur as $\varepsilon_0 = \gamma$, $\varepsilon_t = \beta_{l-1}$, $\varepsilon_s = \beta_{j-1}$ with $0 < t < s$, i.e. in the cyclic order $(\gamma, \beta_{l-1}, \beta_{j-1})$, which is the opposite one; this contradiction proves $l > g$. For the second assertion, the whole cycle $(e_r, \dots, e_1, C)$ is tight from ψ' and its cyclic value sequence $(\varepsilon_0, \dots, \varepsilon_r)$, with $\varepsilon_t = \psi'(e_t) = \beta_{l-1}$ for $e_t = x_l$, is unimodal. Suppose $e_t = x_l$ with $t \geq s+1$ and $g < l \leq j-1$. In Σ the numbers $\gamma, \beta_{l-1}, \beta_{j-1}$ occur in the cyclic order $(\gamma, \beta_{l-1}, \beta_{j-1})$, because $g \leq l-1 < j-1$; in the e-sequence they occur as $\varepsilon_0, \varepsilon_s, \varepsilon_t$ with $0 < s < t$, i.e. in the order $(\gamma, \beta_{j-1}, \beta_{l-1})$, the opposite one. Hence $l \leq g$. □

States and the junction process. Fix $u, w \in S_\infty$ and a monomial q. By Lemma 6.7(iii), a level-k step $v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v'$ may be represented by any *pivot word* of $v^{-1}v'$, i.e. any interleaving of the pivot factorizations of its cycles; all of them are cover paths from v of weight $q_k(v, v')$, and the same holds for level-$(k+1)$ steps. A *state* is a word $U = W_1 \,|\, W_2$ with a cut, which is a cover path from u of weight q with product $u^{-1}w$, together with an *active position* x, such that:

- (S1) $W_1 = R_1\, T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_j}$, where R_1 is a pivot word of a product of pairwise disjoint cycles with tops $\geq k+2$ and $x_1, \dots, x_j$ are distinct positions $\leq k$ with $x_j = x$ and $x_1, \dots, x_{j-1} \notin \mathrm{supp} R_1$ (the active position may or may not lie in $\mathrm{supp} R_1$); or, in the $\mathcal{M}$ *case*, $x = K$ and $W_1 = R_1 T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{j-1}}$ with $x_1, \dots, x_{j-1}$ as before.
- (S2) $W_2 = E\, W_2'$, where $E = S_{e_1} \cdots S_{e_r}$ is the pivot factorization of a cycle $e = (e_r, \dots, e_1, C)$ with top $C \geq k+2$ containing x, say $x = e_s$, and W_2' is a pivot word of a product of pairwise disjoint cycles with tops $\geq K$, disjoint from e and not containing x.

Here $T_y = t_{yK}$ and $S_y = t_{yC}$ as before (with C the top of e). Two states are identified if they differ by reorderings as in Lemma 8.29, i.e. we regard a state as the data (cycles of R_1, the sequence $x_1, \dots, x_j$, the cycle e, the cycles of W_2') rather than as a particular interleaving. A state is a *source* if $x \notin \mathrm{supp} R_1$ (and the active position is in $[1, k]$ or K accordingly); the sources are exactly the blocked tails and the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$: a blocked tail $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ with block data (ρ_1, X, ρ_2) and cut $i = i_{\min} > 0$ is the state with R_1 a pivot word of ρ_1, $(x_1, \dots, x_j) = (x_1, \dots, x_i)$, e the cycle of ρ_2 through x_i, and W_2' a pivot word of $d_i \rho_2 e^{-1}$; a chain $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$ with $X = (x_n, \dots, x_1, K)$ is the state with $(x_1, \dots, x_{j-1}) = (x_1, \dots, x_n)$, $x = K$, e the cycle of $v^{-1}w$ through K, and W_2' a pivot word of the other cycles. Conversely such a state is a blocked tail (resp. a chain of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$) of weight q. For a state U with active position x put

$$N_1(U) = \mathrm{supp} R_1 \cup \{x_1, \dots, x_{j-1}\}, \qquad M_2(U) = \{a \leq k : a \text{ is moved by } W_2\},$$

the set of positions $\leq k$ moved by W_1 other than (possibly) the active one, and the set of positions $\leq k$ moved by W_2.

The *junction move* transforms a state U as follows. The word $J = T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_j}\, S_{e_1} \cdots S_{e_{s-1}}\, S_x$ formed by the K-letters of W_1 and the first s letters of E is a junction word in the sense of the token lemma (tail case if $x \leq k$, $\mathcal{M}$ case if $x = K$), it occupies a contiguous segment of U, and it is a cover path from $\psi = uR_1$. Let g be the index provided by Lemma 8.32, and replace J by J_g; by Lemmas 8.28, 8.31 and 8.32, the resulting word

$$U^+ = \begin{cases} R_1\, S_{x_g} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}}\, T_{x_1} \cdots T_{x_{g-1}} \;\big|\; T_{x_g}\, T_{e_1} \cdots T_{e_{s-1}}\, T_x\, S_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r}\, W_2' & (g \geq 1), \\ R_1\, Z\, S_{x_1} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}} \;\big|\; T_{e_1} \cdots T_{e_{s-1}}\, T_x\, S_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r}\, W_2' & (g = 0), \end{cases}$$

with T_x omitted when $x = K$ and with the cut placed as indicated, is a cover path from u of weight q with product $u^{-1}w$.

Proposition 8.33 (The junction process)**.** *Let U be a state with active position x and let U^+ be obtained by the junction move, with index g.*

(a) *If $g = 0$, then U^+ is a chain $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v^+ \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ of $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}$ of weight q, with triple $\big(q,\ u(\overline{N_1(U)}),\ w(\overline{M_2(U)})\big)$, where $\overline{S} = [1,k] \setminus S$.*

(b) *If $g \geq 1$ and x_g is not moved by $S_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r} W_2'$, then U^+ is a compatible pair $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v^+ \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ of weight q which is the blocked head of its block, with $T(v^+) = \big(q,\ u(\overline{N_1(U)}),\ w(\overline{M_2(U)})\big)$.*

(c) *If $g \geq 1$ and x_g is moved by $S_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r} W_2'$, let f be the cycle of $S_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r} W_2'$ through x_g (so f is either $(e_r, \ldots, e_{s+1}, C)$ or a cycle of W_2'). Then the word U' obtained from U^+ by moving the cut one letter to the right, past T_{x_g}, and moving the letters of f to the front of the suffix, is a state with active position x_g, with $N_1(U') = N_1(U)$ and $M_2(U') = M_2(U)$, and the index j of its junction word is $g < j$.*

Consequently, starting from a source and iterating the junction move, one reaches after at most j moves a target (a blocked head or a chain of $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}$) of weight q whose triple is the triple $S(v)$ of the source if the source is a blocked tail v, and the triple of the source if the source is a chain of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$. We write $\Phi(U)$ for this target.

Proof. We first collect what Lemma 8.32(ii) says about the positions e_t which are among $x_1, \ldots, x_{j-1}$: if $t < s$ then $e_t = x_l$ with $l > g$, and if $t > s$ then $e_t = x_l$ with $l \leq g$. (The second assertion of (ii) applies because $JS_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r}$ is a segment of the cover path U.) In particular $x_g \notin \{e_1, \ldots, e_{s-1}\}$, and $\{e_{s+1}, \ldots, e_r\} \cap \{x_{g+1}, \ldots, x_{j-1}\} = \emptyset$.

The prefix of U^+. For $g \geq 1$ it is R_1 followed by the pivot factorization of the cycle $(x_{j-1}, \ldots, x_g, C)$ and the pivot factorization of $(x_{g-1}, \ldots, x_1, K)$. The positions $x_1, \ldots, x_{j-1}$ avoid $\mathrm{supp} R_1$ by (S1), so if R_1 has no cycle with top C these are three pairwise disjoint pieces, and if R_1 contains a cycle $(z_t, \ldots, z_1, C)$, then its letters followed by $S_{x_g} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}}$ form the pivot factorization of the cycle $(x_{j-1}, \ldots, x_g, z_t, \ldots, z_1, C)$, disjoint from the other cycles. Thus the prefix is a pivot word of a product π_1^+ of pairwise disjoint cycles, each with exactly one element $> k$, i.e. π_1^+ is k-shaped; being an initial segment of a cover path it is u-tight (Lemma 6.7(iii)), so $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v^+ := u\pi_1^+$. The positions $\leq k$ it moves form $N_1(U)$. For $g = 0$ the prefix is R_1 followed by $ZS_{x_1} \cdots S_{x_{j-1}}$, which merges with the cycle of R_1 with top C (if any) into the cycle $(x_{j-1}, \ldots, x_1, K, z_t, \ldots, z_1, C)$; so the prefix is a pivot word of a $(k+1)$-shaped, u-tight permutation moving K, i.e. $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v^+$ with K moved, and it moves the positions $N_1(U) \sqcup \{K\}$.

The suffix of U^+. Its letters T are T_{x_g} (if $g \geq 1$), $T_{e_1}, \ldots, T_{e_{s-1}}$, T_x (if $x \leq k$), and the letters T of W_2', which form the pivot factorization of a cycle D with top K (trivial if $x = K$, since then W_2' is a level-$(k+1)$ word). The positions $x_g, e_1, \ldots, e_{s-1}, x$ and those of D are pairwise distinct ($x_g \notin \{e_t\}_{t<s}$ by the first paragraph; $x \notin \{e_t\}_{t \neq s}$; D is disjoint from e and does not contain x or x_g, the latter by hypothesis in (b)), so these letters form, in the order in which they occur, the pivot factorization of the cycle $D^+ = (D,\ x,\ e_{s-1}, \ldots, e_1,\ x_g,\ K)$ (we list the elements following the cycle from the top), respectively $(D, x, e_{s-1}, \ldots, e_1, K)$ when $g = 0$ and $(D, e_{s-1}, \ldots, e_1, x_g, K)$ in the $\mathcal{M}$ case. The remaining letters of the suffix are those of $(e_r, \ldots, e_{s+1}, C)$ and of the other cycles of W_2', which are pairwise disjoint, disjoint from D, x and $e_1, \ldots, e_{s-1}$, and, under the hypothesis of (a) or (b), do not contain x_g. Hence in cases (a) and (b) the suffix is a pivot word of a k-shaped permutation π_2^+, which is v^+-tight because the suffix is a terminal segment of a cover path; so $v^+ \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$. The positions $\leq k$ moved by the suffix are $M_2(U)$ in case (a) and $M_2(U) \sqcup \{x_g\}$ in case (b).

(a) By the above, U^+ is a chain $u \overset{k+1}{\rightsquigarrow} v^+ \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ whose first step moves K; its weight is q and its triple is $(q, \mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(u, v^+), \mathrm{fix}_k(v^+, w)) = (q, u(\overline{N_1(U)}), w(\overline{M_2(U)}))$.

(b) We have $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v^+ \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$. The two steps are compatible: the cycles with top K are $(x_{g-1}, \ldots, x_1, K)$ and D^+, which meet only in K (as $e_t = x_l$ with $t < s$ forces $l > g$); and by Lemma 8.12 two cycles of the two steps with a common top $\geq k+2$ cannot share an element $\leq k$. The block data of the pair are $\big(\rho_1^+,\ X^+ = (x_{g-1}, \ldots, x_1, K)D^+,\ \rho_2^+\big)$ with cut $g-1$, where ρ_1^+ contains the cycle through x_g with top C; since x_g is the g-th pivot of X^+, $i_{\max} = g-1$, so the pair is the head of its block and this head is blocked. Finally $\mathrm{fix}_k(u, v^+) = u(\overline{N_1(U)})$, $\mathrm{fix}_k(v^+, w) = w(\overline{M_2(U) \sqcup \{x_g\}})$ and $c(v^+) = v^+(K) = \beta_{g-1}$, the value at K after the prefix; the letter T_{x_g} moves this value to x_g, which is not moved by any later letter, so $w(x_g) = c(v^+)$ and $T(v^+) = (q, u(\overline{N_1(U)}), w(\overline{M_2(U)}))$.

(c) The prefix of U' is the prefix of U^+ followed by T_{x_g}: it has the form (S1) with R_1' the prefix of U^+ minus its letters T (a pivot word of disjoint cycles with tops $\geq k+2$), with K-letters $T_{x_1}, \ldots, T_{x_{g-1}}, T_{x_g}$,

and active position $x_g \in \mathrm{supp}R_1'$; the positions $x_1, \dots, x_{g-1}$ avoid $\mathrm{supp}R_1'$. The letters of f move no position moved by the letters of the suffix of U^+ which they pass (these letters are T_{x_g}—not passed—$T_{e_1}, \dots, T_{e_{s-1}}, T_x$, the letters of $(e_r, \dots, e_{s+1}, C)$ if $f \neq$ this cycle, and letters of cycles of W_2' other than f; all are disjoint from f because the cycles of the suffix are pairwise disjoint apart from the common element x_g of T_{x_g} and f), so by Lemma 8.29 U' is a cover path of weight q. Its suffix is f followed by a pivot word of pairwise disjoint cycles with tops $\geq K$: the cycle $(D, x, e_{s-1}, \dots, e_1, K)$ formed by the letters $T_{e_1}, \dots, T_{e_{s-1}}, T_x$ and those of D (the letter T_{x_g} having moved to the prefix), the cycle $(e_r, \dots, e_{s+1}, C)$ if f is not this cycle, and the cycles of W_2' other than f; all of these are disjoint from f, and none of them contains x_g. So U' is a state with active position $x_g \leq k$, whose junction word has g letters T and index $g < j$. Its sets are $N_1(U') = \mathrm{supp}R_1' \cup \{x_1, \dots, x_{g-1}\} = \mathrm{supp}R_1 \cup \{x_1, \dots, x_{j-1}\} = N_1(U)$ and $M_2(U') = M_2(U) \cup \{x_g\} = M_2(U)$, since $x_g \in \mathrm{supp}f \subseteq M_2(U)$.

For the consequence, note that a source U has $N_1(U) = M_1 \setminus \{x\}$ where M_1 is the set of positions $\leq k$ moved by its first step, and $M_2(U) = M_2$ is the set moved by its second step. If U is a blocked tail v, then $S(v) = (q, \mathrm{fix}_k(u, v) \cup \{c(v)\}, \mathrm{fix}_k(v, w))$ with $c(v) = u(x)$ (Lemma 8.25(iii)), which is $(q, u(\overline{M_1 \setminus \{x\}}), w(\overline{M_2}))$; if U is a chain of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$ its triple is $(q, \mathrm{fix}_k(u, v), \mathrm{fix}_{k+1}(v, w)) = (q, u(\overline{M_1}), w(\overline{M_2}))$, and $N_1(U) = M_1$ as $x = K$. Since the junction move strictly decreases the index j of the junction word, the iteration terminates, by (a) or (b), after at most j moves, and the invariance of N_1 and M_2 in (c) gives the triple. □

Injectivity.

Lemma 8.34. *Let U be a state and U^+ the result of the junction move, and work in S_n. Then the reversed word $(U^+)^{\mathrm{rev}}$, read from $w_0 w$ with the reversed cut, is (after reorderings as in Lemma 8.29) a state for the pair $(w_0 w, w_0 u)$ and the weight q, with active position x_g if $g \geq 1$ and K if $g = 0$, and the junction move applied to it produces U^{rev}.*

Proof. By Lemma 8.30, $(U^+)^{\mathrm{rev}}$ and U^{rev} are cover paths from $w_0 w$ of weight q with product $w^{-1}u$. Let $g \geq 1$. The prefix of $(U^+)^{\mathrm{rev}}$ is the reversed suffix of U^+: the reversal of the pivot word of W_2' and of $S_{e_{s+1}} \cdots S_{e_r}$, followed by $T_x\, T_{e_{s-1}} \cdots T_{e_1}\, T_{x_g}$. Its letters T are those of D (reversed), then $T_x, T_{e_{s-1}}, \dots, T_{e_1}, T_{x_g}$; the other letters move positions disjoint from those of D, x and $e_1, \dots, e_{s-1}$, so by Lemma 8.29 they may be moved to the front, giving the form (S1) with R_1^{rev} consisting of the reversed pivot words of the cycles of W_2' other than D and of $(e_r, \dots, e_{s+1}, C)$, the K-letters being $T_{y_1}, \dots, T_{y_p}$ with $(y_1, \dots, y_p) = (D \text{ reversed}, x, e_{s-1}, \dots, e_1, x_g)$, and active position x_g (which may lie in $\mathrm{supp}R_1^{\mathrm{rev}}$). The suffix of $(U^+)^{\mathrm{rev}}$ is $T_{x_{g-1}} \cdots T_{x_1}\, S_{x_{j-1}} \cdots S_{x_g}\, R_1^{\mathrm{rev}}$; here $S_{x_{j-1}} \cdots S_{x_g}$ followed by the reversed letters of the cycle of R_1 with top C (if any) is the pivot factorization of a cycle e^{rev} with top C through x_g, in which x_g is preceded by $x_{j-1}, \dots, x_{g+1}$; moving $T_{x_{g-1}} \cdots T_{x_1}$ past it (Lemma 8.29) gives the form (S2), the remaining cycles being $(x_1, \dots, x_{g-1}, K)$ and the other cycles of R_1, which do not contain x_g. So $(U^+)^{\mathrm{rev}}$ is a state. Its junction word is $T_{y_1} \cdots T_{y_p}\, S_{x_{j-1}} \cdots S_{x_{g+1}}\, S_{x_g}$. Suppose first that $x \leq k$. The resolution with stop at the letter T_x (the letter y_m with $y_m = x$) is

$$S_x\, S_{e_{s-1}} \cdots S_{e_1} \;\cdot\; (D \text{ reversed}) \;\big|\; T_x\, T_{x_{j-1}} \cdots T_{x_{g+1}}\, T_{x_g} \;\cdot\; (\text{rest of the suffix}),$$

which, after moving the block $S_x S_{e_{s-1}} \cdots S_{e_1}$ past the letters of D and the reversed letters of the cycle of R_1 with top C past $T_{x_{g-1}} \cdots T_{x_1}$ (both inert), is exactly

$$U^{\mathrm{rev}} = \big(W_2'\big)^{\mathrm{rev}}\, S_{e_r} \cdots S_{e_{s+1}}\, S_x S_{e_{s-1}} \cdots S_{e_1} \;\big|\; T_x T_{x_{j-1}} \cdots T_{x_1}\, R_1^{\mathrm{rev}}.$$

Since U^{rev} is a cover path of weight q, Lemma 8.32(i) shows that this resolution is the one selected by the junction move. If $x = K$, there is no letter T_x, the sequence $(y_1, \dots, y_p)$ is $(e_{s-1}, \dots, e_1, x_g)$, and the same comparison shows that the resolution $J_0 = Z\, S_{e_{s-1}} \cdots S_{e_1} \cdot T_{x_{j-1}} \cdots T_{x_g}$ of the junction word yields $U^{\mathrm{rev}} = (W_2')^{\mathrm{rev}} S_{e_r} \cdots S_{e_{s+1}} Z S_{e_{s-1}} \cdots S_{e_1} \,|\, T_{x_{j-1}} \cdots T_{x_1} R_1^{\mathrm{rev}}$ up to inert reorderings. The case $g = 0$ is identical, with the prefix of $(U^+)^{\mathrm{rev}}$ having no active letter after T_{e_1}, the suffix containing the cycle $(x_{j-1}, \dots, x_1, K, \dots, C)$ through K, so that the reversed state is of $\mathcal{M}$ type, and the resolution with stop at T_x (resp. J_0 if $x = K$) again giving U^{rev}. □

Proposition 8.35. *The map Φ from the sources of weight q for (u, w) to the targets of weight q for (u, w) is injective.*

Proof. Let U_0 be a source and $U_0, U_1, \dots, U_m$ the states traversed by the process, U_{i+1} being obtained from U_i by a junction move followed, in case (c), by the normalization of Proposition 8.33(c), and $U_m^+ = \Phi(U_0)$ the final target. We show that U_i is determined by U_{i+1} (resp. by U_m^+ for $i = m$). The word U_i^+ (the result of

the move, before normalization) is determined by U_{i+1}: one moves the active letter T of U_{i+1}, the last letter of its prefix, back to the front of the suffix (the normalization of (c) only reorders inert letters otherwise). By Lemma 8.34, $(U_i^+)^{\mathrm{rev}}$ is a state whose junction move produces U_i^{rev}; since the junction move is deterministic (Lemma 8.32(i) selects a unique resolution), U_i^{rev}, hence U_i, is determined by U_i^+. Finally, whether U_i is the source or an intermediate state is read off from U_i itself: a state is a source if and only if its active position does not lie in $\mathrm{supp} R_1$. Hence the whole sequence, and in particular U_0, is determined by $\Phi(U_0)$. □

Theorem 8.36 (The junction identity)**.** *The identity* ($\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}}$) *holds for all $k \geq 1$ and all $u, w \in S_\infty$. Consequently* (B_k)*, Theorem 8.4 and* (J_k) *hold for all $k \geq 1$.*

Proof. Fix k, u, w, a monomial q, and n so large that everything takes place in S_n. Let $\mathrm{Src}(u,w)$ be the multiset of triples of the sources of weight q for (u,w), i.e. $S(v)$ for the blocked tails v and the triples of the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$, and $\mathrm{Tgt}(u,w)$ the multiset of $T(v)$ for the blocked heads and of the triples of the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}$, all of weight q. By Propositions 8.33 and 8.35, Φ is an injective, triple-preserving map from sources to targets; hence $\mathrm{Src}(u,w) \subseteq \mathrm{Tgt}(u,w)$ as multisets.

Now apply the reversal of Lemma 8.30 to whole configurations: it sends a compatible pair $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ to the pair $w_0 w \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w_0 v \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} w_0 u$ (the reversed pivot words are pivot words of the inverse permutations, which are tight by Lemma 6.7(iii)), with the same weight, with block data $(\rho_2^{-1}, X^{-1}, \rho_1^{-1})$ and cut $n-i$, so that $i_{\min}$ and $i_{\max}$ are exchanged with $n - i_{\max}$ and $n - i_{\min}$: blocked tails go to blocked heads and conversely. Likewise it exchanges the chains of $\mathcal{M}_k^{\mathrm{mov}}$ for (u,w) with those of $\mathcal{M}_k'^{\mathrm{mov}}$ for $(w_0 w, w_0 u)$. On triples it acts by $\sigma(q,A,B) = (q, w_0 B, w_0 A)$, where w_0 acts on values: indeed $\mathrm{fix}_k(w_0 w, w_0 v) = w_0 \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)$, $\mathrm{fix}_k(w_0 v, w_0 u) = w_0 \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)$ and $(w_0 v)(K) = w_0(v(K))$, so that $S(w_0 v) = \sigma(T(v))$ and $T(w_0 v) = \sigma(S(v))$, and similarly for the mixed chains. Hence $\sigma(\mathrm{Tgt}(u,w)) = \mathrm{Src}(w_0 w, w_0 u)$ and $\sigma(\mathrm{Src}(u,w)) = \mathrm{Tgt}(w_0 w, w_0 u)$. Applying the first paragraph to $(w_0 w, w_0 u)$ gives $\mathrm{Src}(w_0 w, w_0 u) \subseteq \mathrm{Tgt}(w_0 w, w_0 u)$, i.e. $\mathrm{Tgt}(u,w) \subseteq \mathrm{Src}(u,w)$. Therefore $\mathrm{Src}(u,w) = \mathrm{Tgt}(u,w)$ for every q, which is ($\mathrm{J}_k^{\mathrm{B}}$). The consequences follow from Propositions 8.26 and 8.9. □

Remark 8.37 (Specializations of z_1 and z_2). Both sides of (J_k) have degree at most $k-1$ in z_1 and in z_2 (a pair with $|\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v)| = k$ has $v = u$ and is compatible, and similarly for the second step), so by interpolation it suffices to prove (J_k) after the specializations $z_1 = y_{u(i)}$, $z_2 = y_{u(j)}$, $1 \leq i, j \leq k$, which retain exactly the pairs whose first step moves position i and whose second step moves the value $u(j)$. For $u = c[k,k]$ and $i = 1$ this specialization kills every term of positive degree (Remark 8.7); for general u, however, no value is common to all the nonempty fixed sets, and the specialized identities are not termwise.

The situation is different on the diagonal $z_2 = z_1$, that is, when both factors $\widetilde{E}_{k,k}$ are taken in the *same* variable z_1. There the weight $\omega_k(u,v,w)$ depends only on the multiset $\mathrm{fix}_k(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)$, and we have verified, for all $u \in S_5$ and $k \leq 5$ with chains in S_7, that (J_k) becomes an identity of multisets:

$$(\mathrm{D}_k)\quad \big\{\big(q_k(u,v)q_k(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_k(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_k(v,w)\big)\big\}_{\substack{u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w \\ \text{incompatible}}} = \big\{\big(q_k\, q_{k-1}(u,v)q_{k-1}(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_{k-1}(v,w)\big)\big\}_{u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w,\ \text{compatible}},$$

whereas for every specialization with $z_1 \neq z_2$ that we have tried (generic, or $z_1 = y_c$, $z_2 = y_{c'}$ with $c \neq c'$) the identity is not termwise; the example $u = 132$, $k = 2$, $w = 312$ above already shows this, the two sides $q_2[(y_3 - z_1) + (y_1 - z_2)]$ and $q_2[(y_1 - z_1) + (y_3 - z_2)]$ agreeing termwise exactly when $z_1 = z_2$. In particular the numbers of incompatible pairs at level k and of compatible pairs at level $k-1$ with the same (u,w) and the same q-weight coincide.

In fact (D_k) holds in the strongest possible termwise sense. Call the *key* of a pair $u \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{m}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ the triple $\big(w,\ q_m(u,v)q_m(v,w),\ \mathrm{fix}_m(u,v) \uplus \mathrm{fix}_m(v,w)\big)$. We have verified, for all $u \in S_6$ with chains in S_7 for $k = 3$ (41 254 incompatible pairs) and in S_8 for $k = 4$ (154 073 pairs), that for fixed u the keys of the incompatible level-k pairs are pairwise distinct, that the keys of the compatible level-$(k-1)$ pairs are pairwise distinct, and that multiplying the weight by q_k maps the second set of keys bijectively onto the first. Thus for each compatible pair $u \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} v' \overset{k-1}{\rightsquigarrow} w$ there is a *unique* incompatible pair $u \overset{k}{\rightsquigarrow} v \overset{k}{\not\rightsquigarrow} w$ with the same fixed-value multiset and q_k times the weight, and this correspondence $v' \mapsto v$ is a bijection; (D_k) would follow from a proof that the correspondence is well defined and surjective. Moreover, in the "pure" situation in which the level-$(k-1)$ pair has no cycles with top $k+1$ and no cycle with a larger top interacts with the detour, the

bijection is given by two explicit detours generalizing Lemma 8.19: if the top-k cycles of the two steps have pivot sequences C_1 and C_2 (meeting only in k) and $P = C_1C_2 = (p_1, \dots, p_m)$ is their concatenation, then the image has top-$(k+1)$ cycles with pivot sequences either $c = (k)C_1$, $d = C_2(k)$ (the "even" form, the conjugate of P by $t_{k,k+1}$ with the cut inside), or $c = P(k)$, $d = (p_1)$ when $C_1 = \emptyset$ and $c = C_1$, $d = C_2(k, p_1)$ otherwise (the "odd" form, the conjugate by $t_{p_1,k+1}$); for $m = 1$ the form is decided by the parity of the pattern of $(u(p_1), u(k), u(k+1))$, which is Lemma 8.13. When the level-$(k-1)$ pair has cycles with top $k+1$, these merge into c and d (as the letter t_{13} merges into $\mathrm{K}_1, \mathrm{K}_1', \mathrm{K}_4, \mathrm{K}_4'$ for $k = 2$), and we have not extracted a closed pivot formula beyond the canonical description by keys.

The identity (D_k) determines (J_k) only on the diagonal; since (J_k) is symmetric in z_1, z_2 but of degree up to $k-1$ in each, the off-diagonal part is not a consequence of it, and for the off-diagonal part the only termwise formulation we have found is (B_k).

Remark 8.38 (Why pairs, and why "space" is needed). The doubled formula is a statement about the quantization of a product of two elementary polynomials in the *same* alphabet $x_1, \dots, x_k$. Expanded in standard elementary monomials, such a product uses the alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_k$ and $x_1, \dots, x_{k+1}$ (see the determinant below). Consequently, in a product of several factorial elementary polynomials, θ acts as $\theta(\cdots) \cdot \theta\big(E_{p_1,k}E_{p_2,k}\big) \cdot \theta(\cdots)$ only if no other factor uses the alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_k$ or $x_1, \dots, x_{k+1}$, that is, only if the equal pair of columns is preceded by a column of height at least $k+2$. This is precisely the condition under which the medium theta $\overline{\theta}(v^{-1})$ of Definition 4.1 retains an equal consecutive pair, and it is the reason the quantum algorithm iterates over $\overline{\theta}(v^{-1})$ rather than over the sorted code $\theta(v^{-1})$ (which may contain equal parts without the required space) or the strict shape $\widetilde{\theta}(v^{-1})$ (which has no equal parts at all and is therefore larger). Three or more equal columns would require the alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_{k+2}$ and beyond, and the doubled formula has no analogue for them; accordingly $\overline{\theta}$ never retains more than two equal parts, the remaining ones being incremented as in the construction of θ.

Explicitly, the quantized product of two equal columns is a Giambelli-type determinant. For a Grassmannian permutation w with descent at k and shape λ (so $\mathfrak{c}(w) = (\lambda_k, \dots, \lambda_1)$), the double Schubert polynomial is the determinant $\mathfrak{S}_w(x; z) = \det\big(E_{\lambda_i'+j-i,\, k+j-1}(x; z)\big)_{1 \le i,j \le \lambda_1}$ of factorial elementary polynomials in the nested alphabets $x_1, \dots, x_{k+j-1}$; every term of the expanded determinant is a standard elementary monomial, so θ acts on it term by term and gives the quantum Giambelli formula [5, 3]

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w(x; z) = \det\big(\widetilde{E}_{\lambda_i'+j-i,\, k+j-1}(x; z)\big)_{1 \le i,j \le \lambda_1}.$$

For the $k \times 2$ rectangle this reads

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[k]}(x; z) = \theta\big(E_{k,k}(x; z_1)E_{k,k}(x; z_2)\big) = \widetilde{E}_{k,k+1}(x; z)\,\widetilde{E}_{k,k}(x; z) - \widetilde{E}_{k+1,k+1}(x; z)\,\widetilde{E}_{k-1,k}(x; z),$$

whose first instances are

$$\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[1]}(x; z) = \widetilde{E}_{1,2}(x; z)\widetilde{E}_{1,1}(x; z) - \widetilde{E}_{2,2}(x; z), \qquad \widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{d_2[2]}(x; z) = \widetilde{E}_{2,3}(x; z)\widetilde{E}_{2,2}(x; z) - \widetilde{E}_{3,3}(x; z)\widetilde{E}_{1,2}(x; z).$$

The doubled formula computes the same product by two compatible Pieri steps in k variables, with all coefficients manifestly positive, instead of by the two signed products of Pieri steps in k and $k+1$ variables suggested by the determinant.

9. The Peterson–Woodward comparison formula

In this section we prove Proposition 2.10. We use the notation of Section 2: W_P is a parabolic subgroup of S_n with $P = \widehat{P}$, $\omega_P = w_P$ is its longest element, and for $\lambda_P \in Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$ we write $\lambda_B \in Q^\vee$ for its Peterson–Woodward lift. In the language of roots, λ_B is the unique lift with $\langle \alpha, \lambda_B \rangle \in \{0, -1\}$ for all positive roots α of the Levi subgroup of P; in type A these are the roots $\alpha_i + \cdots + \alpha_{j-1}$ with $s_i, \dots, s_{j-1} \in P$, and $\langle \alpha_i + \cdots + \alpha_{j-1}, d \rangle = \langle d \rangle_{ij}$, so this is the condition of Definition 2.8.

Proposition 9.1 ([7, Proposition 2.10]). *Let W_P be a parabolic subgroup of W and $u, v, w \in W^P$. Then for any $\lambda_P \in Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$, we have that*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,\lambda_P}(y; y) = c_{u,v}^{w\omega_P\omega_{P'},\lambda_B}(y; y),$$

where ω_P is the longest element in W_P, $\omega_{P'}$ is the longest element in $W_{P'}$, where P' is the parabolic subgroup generated by $\{s_\alpha \mid \alpha \in \Delta_P, \langle \alpha, \lambda_B \rangle = 0\}$, and λ_B is the Peterson-Woodward lift of λ_P.

Here the left-hand side is a structure constant of $QH_T^*(G/P)$, i.e. of the parabolic quantum double Schubert polynomials $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y)$ of Definition 2.6, which represent the Schubert classes of $QH_T^*(G/P)$ [11], and the right-hand side is a structure constant of $QH_T^*(G/B)$.

Corollary 9.2. *With the notation of Proposition 9.1, for all $u, v, w \in W^P$,*

$$c_{u,v}^{w,\lambda_P}(y;z) = c_{u,v}^{w\omega_P\omega_{P'},\lambda_B}(y;z).$$

Proof. The parabolic polynomials satisfy the same quantum Cauchy identity as in Lemma 2.1. Indeed, by [11, Lemma 18], $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_w^P(x;y) = \theta^P(\mathfrak{S}_w(x;y))$ for $w \in W^P$, where θ^P is the parabolic quantization map of Ciocan-Fontanine [3], extended linearly over the coefficient variables; applying θ^P to the classical identity $\mathfrak{S}_v(x;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x;y)$ gives $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_v^P(x;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z)\,\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}^P(x;y)$, where we note that $v_2 \in W^P$ for every reduced factorization (see below), so that $\theta^P(\mathfrak{S}_{v_2}(x;y))$ is indeed $\widetilde{\mathfrak{S}}_{v_2}^P(x;y)$. Hence

$$c_{u,v}^{w,\lambda_P}(y;z) = \sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} c_{u,v_2}^{w,\lambda_P}(y;y)\ \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z).$$

Here, if $v = v_1 \cdot v_2$ is reduced and $v \in W^P$, then $v_2 \in W^P$: for $s_i \in P$, $v_2 s_i < v_2$ would give $\ell(vs_i) \leq \ell(v_1) + \ell(v_2 s_i) < \ell(v)$, contradicting $v \in W^P$. Thus Proposition 9.1 applies to each term, and resumming by Lemma 2.1 gives

$$\sum_{v_1\cdot v_2=v} c_{u,v_2}^{w\omega_P\omega_{P'},\lambda_B}(y;y)\ \mathfrak{S}_{v_1}(y;z) = c_{u,v}^{w\omega_P\omega_{P'},\lambda_B}(y;z). \quad \square$$

Proof of Proposition 2.10. Let $d_P \in Q^\vee/Q_P^\vee$ with Peterson–Woodward lift $d = \lambda_B$. In type A, $\langle \alpha_i, d\rangle = 2d_i - d_{i-1} - d_{i+1} = \langle d\rangle_i$, so the parabolic subgroup P' of Proposition 9.1 is generated by $\{s_i \in P \mid \langle d\rangle_i = 0\}$, that is, by $\{s_i \mid i \in z_P(d)\}$, and $\omega_P\omega_{P'} = w_P w_{z_P(d)}$. The claim is therefore Corollary 9.2. (The passage from S_n to S_∞, i.e. from P to $\widehat{P}$, is the stability discussed after Definition 2.6.) $\square$

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